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INDEX

1. **What is the Gospel**
2. **The Centrality of the Gospel**
3. **Applying the Gospel to Culture**
4. **Why to Plant Churches**
5. **Toward a Theology of Church Planting**
6. **Urban Education and Church Planting**
7. **Contextualization and Theology**
8. **Globalization and the City**
9. **What is Christian Renewal**
10. **Topics for Training**

Tim Keller

WHAT IS THE GOSPEL?
(Three Perspectives)

Introduction: At the heart of Redeemer's ministry is the conviction that "the gospel" is not just a way to be saved from the penalty of sin, but is the fundamental dynamic for living the whole Christian life--individually and corporately, privately and publicly. In other words, the gospel is not just for non-Christians, but also for Christians.

A. What *is* the gospel?

Biblical Perspectives on the Gospel.

The word *evangelion* ('the gospel') or *evangelizdomai* ('declare the gospel') occurs so often in the New Testament (virtually every author uses it) that *"clearly the term gospel is a kind of code word for many New Testament writers that summarizes something very basic regarding what the early Christians though Christian faith was all about."*[1] But what <u>is</u> that 'very basic' core of Christian faith?

In our desperate search for simplicity, it is easy to overlook the great variety of ways that the 'gospel' is used in the Bible. The most obvious example is how Paul makes 'gospel' almost synonymous with 'justification by faith', while the gospel writers almost seem to make it synonymous with 'the kingdom of God'. We have to be careful that we do not elevate one perspective on the gospel over all others, nor that we assume the perspectives contradict one another. We must have an outline of the gospel that encompasses the way all the Biblical writers speak.

- **News vs. Ethical Instruction** **("THE GOSPEL OF JESUS CHRIST"** Mark 1:1**)**
  The 'normative' perspective: **<u>What</u> happened?**

  When the early Christians chose the term Greek term "ev-angelion" they immediately distinguished the Christian message apart from that of other religions. An 'angel' was a herald or messenger that brought news of some historical event that had already happened, and that had changed our condition. The most common examples in Greek

[1] James V. Brownson, *Speaking the Truth in Love: New Testament Resources for a Missional Hermeneutic.* [Christian Mission and Modern Culture Series](Trinity Press: Harrisburg, PA, 1998), p.31.

literature are "evangels" about a victory in war or the ascension of a new king.

When Christians chose *evangelion* to express the essence of their faith, they passed over words that Hellenistic religions used, such as "illumination" *(photismos)* and "knowledge" *(gnosis)* or that Judaism used such as "instruction" or "teaching" *(didache)* or "wisdom" *(sophia).*[2] Of course, all of these words were used to describe Christianity, but none achieved the centrality of "gospel". What does that mean? First, it means that the gospel is news about what God has already been done for you, rather than instruction and advice about what you are to do for God. The primacy of his work, not our work, is part of the essence of faith. In other religions, God reveals to us how we can find or achieve salvation. In Christianity, God achieves salvation for us. The gospel brings news primarily, rather than instruction.

Second, it means that the gospel is all about historic events, and thus it has a public character. *"It identifies Christian faith as news that has significance for all people, indeed for the whole world, not merely as esoteric understanding or insight."*[3] In other religions, the stories of miracles and other special events in the lives of the founder are not essential. Whether or not Buddha did Miracle X, that does not affect whether the 8-Fold path to enlightenment works or not. But if Jesus is not risen from the dead, Christianity does not "work". The gospel is that Jesus died and rose for us. If the historic events of his life did not happen, then Christianity does not "work" for the good *news* is that God has entered the human "now" (history) with the life of the world to come.

This public, historic aspect of the gospel is especially seen when the term "the gospel of Christ" or "of Jesus Christ" is used. Often the word "gospel" and the life and work of Christ are essentially synonyms. Particularly significant is how Luke links "gospel" to "Jesus". In Acts 5:42, it reads, literally, *"they never stopped… evangelizing Christ Jesus".* Obviously, Jesus is not the object of their evangelism (they are not trying to convert him!) But the word *"evangelizdomenoi"* means, all by itself, 'to preach the gospel' or literally "to gospelize". So in the places in Acts where it says, literally "they evangelized Jesus", the English translations have to render it "they told the gospel about Jesus Christ" or "they told the good news that Jesus was the Christ" (cf. NIV Acts 5:42). But the Greek construction clearly has a stronger meaning than that. Its intentional

[2] Brownson, p.46.
[3] Brownson, p.46.

redundancy aims to say that the good news they preached *was* Jesus. His very life, and all his works, is what saves us. To declare Jesus and to declare the gospel is the same thing. Jesus does not bring the gospel--he *is* the gospel, because the gospel is that God has broken into history and accomplished everything necessary for our salvation. (You will find this same construction repeatedly. See Acts 8:35, 10:36, 11:20.) We can also see the terms "gospel of Christ" or "gospel of Jesus Christ" in Mark 1:1; 1 Cor.9:12,18; 2 Cor.2:12; 9:13;10:14; Gal.1:7, and so on. (Compare also Rom.1:9-"The gospel of his Son".)

Summary: First, the gospel is news that Jesus Christ's life and death and resurrection in history has achieved our salvation. Unlike the founders of religions, who could be said to bring good news, Jesus is the good news. It is interesting to notice that "the gospel of Jesus Christ" is used both by the Synoptic writers (cf. Mark 1:1) who emphasize also the kingdom aspect of the gospel, and by Paul, who emphasizes the sonship aspect of the gospel.

- **Grace vs. Pride of Place ("THE GOSPEL OF THE KINGDOM"** Matt.4:23**)**
  The 'situational' perspective: How did it happen?

We also see that the gospel is not simply that Christ has come into history to save us, but also how he will accomplish that. Answer is through a new, deep structure or 'paradigm' that completely contradicts the way of the world. God's saving purposes are effected through the crucified and risen Christ. Christ wins through losing, triumphs through defeat, achieves power through service, comes to wealth via poverty. Jesus pulls off a 'great reversal'. *"The essence of sin is man substituting himself for God, while the essence of salvation is God substituting himself for man. Man…puts himself where only God deserves to be; God…puts himself were only man deserves to be."*[4]

This pattern so contradicts the thinking and practice of the world, that it creates an 'alternate kingdom', an 'alternate city' (Matt.5:14-16). Many Christians 'reduce' the gospel to the good news of individual forgiveness of sins. But clearly, the gospel writers are talking about something much more than that. The *"gospel of the kingdom"* is a phrase used numerous times in Matthew, Mark, and Luke. The 'Great Reversal' of the cross means that the gospel proclaims a complete reversal of the values of the world--power, recognition, status, wealth. For example, the gospel is especially welcomed by the poor and for the poor (Luke 4:18- *He has anointed me…to preach the gospel to the poor."* Cf. also Luke 7:22.) Preaching

[4] John Stott, *The Cross of Christ.* (Inter-Varsity Press, 1986), p.160.

the gospel and healing people's bodies are closely associated (Luke 9:6). The gospel creates a people with a whole alternate way of being human. Racial and class superiority, accrual of money and power at the expense of others, yearning for popularity and recognition--all these things are marks of living in the world, and are the opposite of the mindset of the kingdom (Luke 6:20-26).

What is the relationship of the gospel to the kingdom? On the one hand, we could say that the gospel 'brings' the kingdom, in that it transforms people so that they live according to the great reversal of the cross. Luke tells us in 16:16 that the gospel brings or proclaims a kingdom that we need to 'press into' and enter. People who are converted by the gospel "see" a new kingdom (cf. John 3:3--*"No one can see the kingdom of God unless he is born again"*) and also enter that kingdom (John 3:5). Once we see that we are sinners saved by grace alone, our old patterns are broken up, and live lives of sacrificial service rather than self-aggrandizement (cf. 2 Cor.8:9). But on the other hand, the in-breaking kingdom of God *is* the gospel! Twice Luke actually says that the kingdom *is* the gospel message (Luke 4:43; 16:16). The fact that Jesus has broken in to history to redeem all of life and give us a new order *is* great news. Why?

Looking for salvation to anything but the grace of Christ sets up an 'idol' or a 'power' or a 'false savior-king'. Human society is miserable under the influence of these idol-powers: such as sex, money, power, or race. (Also, human hearts are miserable under the influence personal idol-powers, such as approval, comfort, control.) When we understand that we can be saved by sheer grace through Christ, we stop seeking salvation (either that of psychological fulfillment, or of social transformation, or of spiritual blessing, or of all three) by any other means. That destroys the power of these false savior-kings over us. The declaration of the gospel of grace *is* therefore always a declaration of the kingdom. A new savior is a new king. For example, Paul says that Peter's racism was *"not in line with the truth of the gospel"* (Gal.2:14). If we are saved by grace alone--but we continue to be racists, we continue to bow to a false savior-king; we continue to look to our race and culture to justify ourselves over others. But the gospel is the gospel of Christ's kingdom. The reversal of the cross, the grace of God, tears down our pride and thus liberates us from bondage to other powers in our lives and our society.

Sum: Second, we see that the gospel of free grace is necessarily a 'gospel of the kingdom' which effects the way we live in society and in the world. The gospel is not just (as is often thought) the message of how you can get individual forgiveness and eternal life through Jesus.

But we cannot separate this second 'perspective' from the first. If we are not saved wholly by Christ (not ourselves) then the kingdom of God is not good news! It is not good news to be told, simply: "God has created a mini-society of freedom and justice based on his laws. Join up!" That would make the message of Christianity a burdensome one of instruction on how to live (Perspect #1) not a message of grace. But also, separated from the other perspectives, the kingdom of God would simply never 'work'. What makes people able to change their mindset from 'worldly' to 'kingdom' is the existential experience of justification and sonship (Perspect #3), not just being told to live unselfishly.

- **Faith vs. Works-Performance ("THE GOSPEL OF YOUR SALVATION"** Eph.1:13**)**
  The 'existential' perspective: <u>In whom</u> does it happen?

While the gospels (especially the 'Synoptics'--Matthew, Mark, and Luke) stress the gospel of the kingdom, the epistles, and especially those of Paul, show how it is additionally *"the gospel of your salvation"* (Eph.1:13).

Paul, better than any other Biblical writer, explores the meaning of the 'gospel of Christ' for the individual believer. First, he tells us that the gospel is *the* way that the work of salvation proceeds in our lives. The gospel is (lit.) *"the power of God into salvation for everyone who believes"* (Rom.1:16). The gospel does not just come with power, but it actually *is* God's saving power in verbal form. As nearly all students of the Bible agree, the word 'salvation' cannot be confined to the past tense only. There is a strong tendency to think of 'salvation' as simply the freedom from the penalty of sin we receive the moment we first believe. But though the Bible says that Christians <u>have</u> been saved (Rom.10:9,13) once they believe, it also says that they "*<u>are being</u>"* saved (2 Cor.2:15), and that some day we *<u>"shall be saved"</u>* "we have been saved from the penalty of sin, we are being saved from the power of sin, and we will be saved from the very presence of sin." But for our purposes we have to ask--when Paul says that the gospel is the very power of God "for salvation", is he only talking of the limited sense of freedom from the penalty of sin? Is he suggesting that some other power will be the basis for our salvation from the power and the presence of sin? That is not likely. Paul is telling us that the gospel is how we are saved, through and through.

Secondly, he tells us that the gospel *"reveals a righteousness <u>from</u> God"* (Rom. 1:17). Here and in Galatians 2 Paul specifically identifies the gospel with the teaching that we receive not just pardon and

forgiveness but also the righteousness of Christ (2 Cor.5:21). This is received by faith in the finished work of Christ, not by good works or our merit.

If we think of the gospel as only pardon or forgiveness of sins, we will trust in God for our past salvation, but will trust in our own present strivings and attainments for our present relationship with God. But the *"hope of the gospel"* (Col.1:23) is that *now he has reconciled you by Christ's body through death to present you holy in his sight, without blemish and free from accusation."* (Col.1:22). The gospel offers not just forgiveness for our bad record, but also complete acceptance through Christ's perfect record. Christ did not only die in our place but lived a perfect life in our place. Therefore we do not simply get forgiveness for sins from Christ, but also complete acceptance. His perfect past and record now (in God's sight) becomes ours.

Thus the entire Christian life is a life "*lived* (in a continual present progressive) *by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me."* (Gal.2:20). On the one hand, this certainly means we can only enter a relationship with God by the deliberate act of trusting in his work and rejecting any trust in our own. (Rom.4:5--*Now to the one who does not work, but trusts God who justifies the wicked, his faith is credited to him as righteousness.*) But, on the other hand, (as the present progressive of Gal.2:20 indicates) we must continually remind ourselves of our status as legally righteous, adopted children of God. Galatians is written to Christians who are losing their grip on the doctrine of free justification and may be 'returning to the bondage' (Gal.5:1) to false savior-gods (Gal.4:8). Whenever we lose our grip on the gospel of salvation-by-faith-not-works, and we fall back into some form of works-righteousness, we return to fear and bondage.

The Importance of All the Perspectives

These three perspectives are important to "keep together". There are today different 'parties' that have isolated and focused on one aspect of the gospel--this usually leads to difficulties and imbalances. The 'classic evangelical' position is 'the gospel of Christ'--which all by itself leads to a ministry almost strictly of apologetics, evangelism, and discipleship. The implications for worship: a very sermon/teaching oriented service. This is the position of the evangelical world of the last 50 years. If you 'came up' in Inter-Varsity or Campus Crusade, or in one of the older confessional churches or independent Bible churches--that is what you heard.

The 'progressive evangelical' position is the 'gospel of the kingdom'--which all by itself leads to a ministry mainly of community-building and

social justice. The implications for worship: often more liturgical. This position is gaining a lot of steam, and is uniting former liberals, who are recognizing the bankruptcy former way, and former classical evangelicals, who are recognizing the individualism of their former ways. This group is strong at seeing the church as a 'counter-culture' modeling the kingdom, and strong on calls to engage with modern culture. The problem is--they often reject the very idea of legal, forensic justification (as too individualistic). I wonder if that might not lead to a 'communal' legalism in the end. Will calls to join the 'reign of God' lead anyone to sing 'my chains fell off, my heart was free, I rose, went forth, and followed thee?"

The 'revivalist evangelical' position is the 'gospel of sonship'. Among charismatics and others in the revival tradition (since Jonathan Edwards)--there this basic idea. Most of the time, the Christian church is moribund and lacks the power of the Spirit. In times of revival, however, the nominalism, legalism, and works-righteousness of the church falls away and there is a recapture of the gospel of free justification and sonship. Then Christians are renewed, as they recapture their identity as children of God, and non-Christians are attracted in. This position--all by itself, leads to a ministry emphasizing prayer, personal renewal, and lots of personal counseling. The implications for worship: often more on the charismatic, contemporary, informal style. This view has historically been in tension with both the classic view (which sees it as too oriented to 'feelings') and the kingdom view (which sees it as too individualistic).

But not only should these perspectives be 'combined'--it must be seen that they interpenetrate and contain one another. Put another way: if you push down *deep* enough into any of the perspectives, you find the other two! For example: if you push down into the gospel of sonship far enough, you will discover that we need to care for the poor. My new identity in Christ, when perfected, must remove class pride and racism. For another example: if you push down into the gospel of the kingdom far enough, you will see that the cross does not only liberate from the power of social idols, but personal idols, which are always rooted in self-righteousness.

In the last few years, a version of the 'revivalist tradition' has taken shape within the Reformed evangelical community in the 'Sonship' course out of New Life Presbyterian from Jack and Rose Marie Miller. Nearly all the criticism I have read or heard has come from persons who are more at home in the other two perspectives. Most of us are 'in reaction', and many of the people who have found the Sonship teaching liberating are people who may have been in more conservative churches (with the new birth emphasis) or more liberal churches (with the

kingdom emphasis) who did not really 'get' the gospel until they heard the Luther-Pauline-Jack Miller focus on imputed righteousness and grasping your adoption in Christ. The danger, of course, is to write off the other two perspectives only because they were not your pathways down into the gospel riches. The "Sonship" course is almost completely focused on personal individual renewal--because that is its purpose. The problem comes when we think "this, and only this, is the gospel."

So What *is* the Gospel?

You may notice that I haven't put the 'gospel in a nutshell' through this whole paper! That is not because it cannot be done. Some people want to assure us that 'the whole Bible' is the gospel. And while it is certainly commendable and right to say that the main theme of the whole Bible is always the gospel, it is not very practical to make this declaration. A person must believe the gospel to be rightly related to God (Mark 1:14-15). Does that mean a person has to know everything in the Bible in order to be saved?

The Bible does put the gospel in a nutshell often, but it puts it into many different 'nutshells'. See 2 Cor.5:19-21 (my favorite) or Mark 1:14-15; John 16:33b; Rom.1:1-4, 16-17; 1 Cor.15:1-5; Phil.2:5-11; 1 Tim.2:5-6; Titus 3:4-7; 1 John 1:8-2:1; 3:8b; 5:1; Rev.5:9-10. Each nutshell stresses a different 'perspective'. It is therefore somewhat risky for a church to take just one 'nutshell' and standardize it as the way to always share the gospel with someone. It tends to reduce your church to being either a doctrinalist, pietist, or culturalist church. I am not against teaching lay people to share their faith with one presentation. But I am wary of making one presentation the unique way a community hears the gospel over and over. We should recognize the different perspectives.

What, though, do all the nutshells have in common? They all tell us that--

1. In the life and work of Jesus Christ in history,
2. God achieved for us a total salvation that we could not achieve for ourselves, and
3. That must be received by faith alone.

"We need to remind ourselves from time to time that there are truths related to this gospel message that are not themselves the gospel....Preaching predestination, or creation, or the new birth, or the baptism of the Spirit is not preaching the gospel. All these things are related to the gospel and are necessary for the working of the gospel, but they are not the essential message to be believed for

salvation...Only the message that another true and obedient human being has come on our behalf, that he has lived for us the kind of life we should live but can't, that he has paid fully the penalty we deserve for the life we do live but shouldn't--only this message can give assurance that we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ."[5]

Two Gospel Nutshells

A kingdom perspective
The 'gospel' is the good news that through Christ the power of God's kingdom has entered history to renew the whole world. When we believe and rely on Jesus' work and record (rather than ours) for our relationship to God, that kingdom power comes upon us and begins to work through us.

An experiential perspective
Irreligion is avoiding God as Lord and Savior by ignoring him. ***Religion*** is avoiding God as Lord and Savior by developing a moral record and giving it to God thinking that then he owes you. But the **gospel** is *not* that we provide to him a moral record, so that then he owes us, but that *he* provides a perfect record to us--the Son of God, Jesus Christ came and lived the life we should have lived and died the death we should have died, taking the penalty for our sin --all and gives it to us, so that then we owe him. **How do we receive it?** We must say: 1) "God--please accept and relate to me because of what Jesus has done for me, not because of how I have lived", and 2) "because he gave himself utterly for me, I now offer myself utterly to you, to serve you unconditionally."
A 'Post-Modern' Gospel Presentation (Existential Perspective)

1. Everyone has a "Center". Everyone has to live for something--something that we think will give us a sense of significance and satisfaction. We all then have a "personal center"--a bottom line, an ultimate value by which we sort through all the activities of life and set priorities. It may be career, possessions, appearance, romance, peer groups, achievement, good causes, moral character, religion, marriage, children, friendships--or a combination of a several. Without this "bottom line", our life would be completely meaningless This means, however...

2. Everyone is a Slave. Whatever we live for has control over us. We do not control ourselves. **Internally,** they create **instability.** The things we live for enslave us with guilt (if we fail to attain them) or anger (if someone blocks them from us) or fear (if they are threatened) or

[5] Graeme Goldsworthy, *Preaching the Whole Bible as Christian Scripture* (Eerdmans, 2000) p.83-84

drivenness (since we must have them) or despair (if we ever lose them completely). We become emotionally dependent on them. **Externally**, they lead us to **relationally exclude**. If we are desperately trying to get our identity out being a member of our class or party or people or culture, we tend to 'demonize' the 'other'. This means, then...

a. Even the most irreligious people are really worshipping something. Whatever thing or things from which we choose to derive our value become the ultimate meaning in our lives--thus it serves as a 'god' and a gives us a sense of worth or 'righteousness' even if we don't think in those terms. Something is "Lord of our lives". People who want to be popularity are controlled by approval. People who want power are controlled by money and politics. But we do not control ourselves.

b. Even the most religious people are not really worshipping God. Religious people may look to God as Helper, Teacher, and Example, but it is their moral performance which is serving as their Savior. They are just as guilty and self-hating if they fail it, just as angry and resentful if someone blocks it, just as fearful and anxious if something threatens it, just as driven "to be good".

Sum: So both religious and irreligious people are avoiding God as Savior and Lord--but in different ways. Both are seeking to keep control of their own lives by looking to something besides God as their salvation.

Transition: We have to live for something, and something will control us. What will we do then? We must first of all see **there is a Creator**. Nothing better explains the brokenness we see. Even the best things don't 'fill the void' in our hearts. We were made for something infinite, and eternal. Only God is big enough to fill up the greatness of what we need. But second we must see that **we've tried to be our own Creator.** If there is a real Creator to which we owe everything, then what we've done is serious. Deep inside of us we know he's there, but we've conveniently used all the religious hypocrites in the world to avoid coming to grips with him. There is only one Master, however, who can *forgive* (none of the rest ever will), and who is *last* (none of the rest ever can). Neither failure on our part nor the circumstances of life can separate us from Him. Thus only in service to Him will we find freedom. To find Him now we must admit:

3. Everyone needs a Substitute. Only when we accept that Jesus came and lived the life we should have lived and died the death we should have died *in our place* and rely on him for our relationship with God and with ourselves and with others--are we set free from false kings. To transfer from false kings into the kingdom of Christ we must first admit the **problem:** that you have been substituting yourself for God either by religion (trying to be your own savior by obedience to moral standards) or

by irreligion (trying to be your own lord by disobedience to moral standards). And second to accept the **remedy:** asking God to accept you for Jesus' sake and know that you are loved and accepted because of his record, not yours.

THE CENTRALITY OF THE GOSPEL Tim Keller

PRINCIPLE
In Galatians 2:14, Paul lays down a powerful principle. He deals with Peter's racial pride and cowardice by declaring that he was not living *"not in line with the truth of the gospel"*. From this we see that the Christian life is a process of renewing every dimension of our life-- spiritual, psychological, corporate, social--by thinking, hoping, and living out the "lines" or ramifications of the gospel. The gospel is to be applied to every area of thinking, feeling, relating, working, and behaving. The implications and applications of Galatians 2:14 are vast.

Part I - IMPLICATIONS AND APPLICATIONS

IMPLICATIONS

Implication #1 - The power of the gospel.
First, Paul is showing us that that bringing the gospel truth to bear on every area of life is the way to be changed by the power of God. The gospel is described in the Bible in the most astounding terms. Angels long to look into it all the time. (I Peter 1:12). It does not simply bring us power, but it is **the power of God** itself, for Paul says *"I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation"* (Rom.1:16). It is also **the blessing of God** with benefits, which accrue to anyone who comes near (I Cor.9:23). It is even called the very light of **the glory of God** itself--*"they cannot see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ...for God...has made his light shine into our hearts to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ."* (II Cor.4:4,6)

It has **the life of God**. Paul said to the Corinthians, *"I gave you birth through the gospel"*! And then, after it has regenerated us, it is the instrument of all continual growth and spiritual progress after we are converted. *"All over the world this gospel is bearing fruit and growing, just as it has been doing among you since the day you heard it and understood God's grace in all its truth."* (Col. 1:6). Here we learn: 1) That the gospel is a living thing (cf. Romans 1:16) which is like a seed or a tree that brings more and more new life--*bearing fruit and growing*. 2) That the gospel is only "planted" in us so as to bear fruit as we understand its greatness and implications deeply--*understood God's grace in all its truth*. 3) That the gospel continues to grow in us and renew us throughout our lives--*as it has been doing since the day you heard it.* This text helps us avoid either an exclusively rationalistic or mystical approach to renewal. On the one hand, the gospel has a content--it is profound doctrine. It is *truth*, and specifically, it is the truth about *God's grace*. But on the other hand, this truth is a living power that continually expands its influence in our lives, just as a

crop or a tree would grow and spread and dominate more and more of an area with roots and fruit.

Implication #2- The sufficiency of the gospel.
Second, Paul is showing that we never "get beyond the gospel" in our Christian life to something more "advanced". The gospel is not the first "step" in a "stairway" of truths, rather, it is more like the "hub" in a "wheel" of truth. The gospel is not just the A-B-C's but the A to Z of Christianity. The gospel is not just the minimum required doctrine necessary to enter the kingdom, but the way we make all progress in the kingdom.

We are not justified by the gospel and then sanctified by obedience, but the gospel is *the* way we grow (Gal.3:1-3) and are renewed (Col.1:6). It is the solution to each problem, the key to each closed door, the power through every barrier (Rom.1:16-17). It is very common in the church to think as follows. "The gospel is for non-Christians. One needs it to be saved. But once saved, you grow through hard work and obedience." But Col.1:6 shows that this is a mistake. Both confession and "hard work" that is not arising from and "in line" with the gospel will not sanctify you--it will strangle you. All our problems come from a failure to apply the gospel. Thus when Paul left the Ephesians he committed them *"to the word of his grace, which can build you up"* (Acts 20:32)

The main problem, then, in the Christian life is that we have not thought out the deep implications of the gospel, we have not "used" the gospel in and on all parts of our life. Richard Lovelace says that most people's problems are just a failure to be oriented to the gospel--a failure to grasp and believe it through and through. Luther says, *"The truth of the Gospel is the principle article of all Christian doctrine....Most necessary is it that we know this article well, teach it to others, and beat it into their heads continually."* (on Gal.2:14f) The gospel is not easily comprehended. Paul says that the gospel only does its renewing work in us as we understand it *in <u>all</u> its truth*. All of us, to some degree live around the truth of the gospel but do not "get" it. So the key to continual and deeper spiritual renewal and revival is the ***continual re-discovery of the gospel***. A stage of renewal is always the discovery of a new implication or application of the gospel--seeing more of its truth. This is true for either an individual or a church.

APPLICATIONS

The two "thieves" of the gospel.
Since Paul uses a metaphor for being "in line" with the gospel, we can consider that gospel renewal occurs when we keep from walking "off-line" either to the right or to the left. The key for thinking out the implications of the gospel is to consider the gospel a "third" way between two mistaken opposites. However, before we start we must realize that the gospel is not a half-way compromise

between the two poles--it does not produce “something in the middle”, but something different from both. The gospel critiques both religion and irreligion (Matt.21:31; 22:10).

Tertullian said, "Just as Christ was crucified between two thieves, so this doctrine of justification is ever crucified between two opposite errors." Tertullian meant that there were two basic false ways of thinking, each of which "steals" the power and the distinctiveness of the gospel from us by pulling us “off the gospel line” to one side or the other. These two errors are very powerful, because they represent the natural tendency of the human heart and mind. (The gospel is *“revealed”* by God (Rom.1:17)--the unaided human mind cannot conceive it.) These “thieves” can be called *moralism* or *legalism* on the one hand, and *hedonism* or *relativism* on the other hand. Another way to put it is: the gospel opposes both *religion* and *irreligion.* On the one hand, "moralism/religion" stresses truth without grace, for it says that we must obey the truth in order to be saved. On the other hand, "relativists/irreligion" stresses grace without truth, for they say that we are all accepted by God (if there is a God) and we have to decide what is true for us. But "truth" without grace is not really truth, and "grace" without truth is not really grace. Jesus was "full of grace *and* truth". Any religion or philosophy of life that de-emphasizes or lose one or the other of these truths, falls into legalism or into license and either way, the joy and power and "release" of the gospel is stolen by one thief or the other.

"I am more sinful and flawed than I ever dared believe" (vs. antinomianism)
"I am more accepted and loved than I ever dared hope" (vs. legalism)

The moralism-religion thief. How does moralism/religion steal joy and power?

Moralism is the view that you are acceptable (to God, the world, others, yourself) through your attainments. (Moralists do not have to be religious, but often are.) When they are, their religion if pretty conservative and filled with rules. Sometimes moralists have views of God as very holy and just. This view will lead either to a) self-hatred (because you can't live up to the standards), or b) self-inflation (because you think you have lived up to the standards). It is ironic to realize that inferiority *and* superiority complexes have the very same root. Whether the moralist ends up smug and superior or crushed and guilty just depends on how high the standards are and on a person's natural advantages (such as family, intelligence, looks, willpower). Moralistic people can be deeply religious--but there is no transforming joy or power.

The relativism-irreligion thief. How does relativism steal joy and power?

Relativists are usually irreligious, or else prefer what is called "liberal" religion. On the surface, they are more happy and tolerant than moralist/religious people. Though they may be highly idealistic in some areas (such as politics), they believe that everyone needs to determine what is right and wrong for them. They are not convinced that God is just and must punish sinners. Their beliefs in God will tend to see Him as loving or as an impersonal force. They may talk a great deal about God's love, but since they do not think of themselves as sinners, God's love for us costs him nothing. If God accepts us, it is because he is so welcoming, or because we are not so bad. The concept of God's love in the gospel is far more rich and deep and electrifying.

What do both religious and irreligious people have in common? They seem so different, but from the viewpoint of the gospel, they are really the same.

They are both ways to avoid Jesus as Savior and keep control of their lives.
Irreligious people seek to be their own saviors and lords through irreligion, "worldly" pride. ("No one tells me how to live or what to do, so I determine what is right and wrong for me!") But moral and religious people seek to be their own saviors and lords through religion, "religious" pride. ("I am more moral and spiritual than other people, so God owes me to listen to my prayers and take me to heaven. God cannot let just anything happen to me--he owes me a happy life. I've earned it!") The irreligious person rejects Jesus entirely, but the religious person only uses Jesus as an example and helper and teacher--but not as a Savior. (Flannery O'Connor wrote that religious people think *"that the way to avoid Jesus was to avoid sin..."*) These are two different ways to do the same thing--control our own lives. (Note: Ironically, Moralists, despite all the emphasis on traditional standards, are in the end self-centered and individualistic, because they have set themselves up as their own Savior. Relativists, despite all their emphasis on freedom and acceptance, are in the end moralistic because they still have to attain and live up to (their own) standards or become desperate. And often, they take great pride in their own open-mindedness and judge others who are not.)

They are both based on distorted views of the real God.
The irreligious person loses sight of the law and holiness of God and the religious person loses sight of the love and grace of God, in the end they both lose the gospel entirely. For the gospel is that on the cross Jesus fulfilled the law of God out of love for us. Without a full understanding of the work of Christ, the reality of God's holiness will make his grace unreal, or the reality of his love will make his holiness unreal. Only the gospel--that we are so sinful that we need to be saved utterly by grace--allows a person to see God as he really is. The gospel shows us a God far more holy than the legalist can bear (he *had* to die because we could not satisfy his holy demands) and yet far more merciful than a humanist can conceive (he had to *die* because he loved us).

They both deny our sin--so lose the joy and power of grace.

It is obvious that relativistic, irreligious people deny the depth of sin, and therefore the message “God loves you” has no power for them. But though religious persons may be extremely penitent and sorry for their sins, they see sins as simply the failure to live up to standards by which they are saving themselves. They do not see sin as the deeper self-righteousness and self-centeredness through which they are trying to live lives independent of God. So when they go to Jesus for forgiveness, they only as a way to "cover over the gaps" in their project of self-salvation. And when people say, "I know God is forgiving, but I cannot forgive myself", they mean that they reject God's grace and insist that they be worthy of his favor. So even religious people with “low self-esteem” are really in their funk because they will not see the depth of sin. They see it only as rules breaking, not as rebellion and self-salvation.

A whole new way of seeing God.
But Christians are those who have adopted a whole new system of approach to God. They may have had both religious phases and irreligious phases in their lives. But they have come to see that their entire reason for both their irreligion and their religion was essentially the same and essentially wrong! Christians come to see that both their sins and their best deeds have all really been ways of avoiding Jesus as savior. They come to see that Christianity is not fundamentally an invitation to get more religious. A Christian comes to say: "though I have often failed to obey the moral law, the deeper problem was why I was trying to obey it! Even my efforts to obey it has been just a way of seeking to be my own savior. In that mindset, even if I obey or ask for forgiveness, I am really resisting the gospel and setting myself up as Savior." To "get the gospel" is turn from self-justification and rely on Jesus' record for a relationship with God. The irreligious don't repent at all, and the religious only repent of sins. But Christians also repent of their righteousness. That is the distinction between the three groups--Christian, moralists (religious), and pragmatists (irreligious).

Summary. Without a knowledge of our extreme sin, the payment of the cross seems trivial and does not electrify or transform. But without a knowledge of Christ's completely satisfying life and death, the knowledge of sin would crush us or move us to deny and repress it. Take away either the knowledge of sin or the knowledge of grace and people's lives not changed. They will be crushed by the moral law or run from it angrily. So the gospel is not that we go from being irreligious to being religious, but that we realize that our reasons for both our religiosity and our irreligiosity were essentially the same and essentially wrong. We were seeking to be our own Saviors and thereby keep control of our own life. When we trust in Christ as our Redeemer, we turn from trusting either self-determination or self-denial for our salvation--from either moralism or hedonism.

A whole new way of seeing life

Paul shows us, then, that we must not just simply ask in every area of life: "what is the moral way to act?" but "what is the way that is in-line with the gospel?" The gospel must be continually "thought out" to keep us from moving into our habitual moralistic or individualistic directions. We must bring everything into line with the gospel.

The example of racism.
Since Paul used the gospel on racism, let's use it as an example:

The moralistic approach to race. Moralists/legalists would tend to be very proud of their culture. They would fall into cultural imperialism. They would try to attach spiritual significance to their cultural styles, to make themselves feel morally superior to other peoples. This happens because moralistic people are very insecure, since they look a lot at the eternal law, and they know deep down that they cannot keep it. So they use cultural differences to buttress their sense of righteousness.
The relativistic/hedonist approach to race. But the opposite error from cultural imperialism would be cultural relativism. This approach would say, "yes, traditional people were racists because they believed in absolute truth. But truth is relative. Every culture is beautiful in itself. Every culture must be accepted on its own terms." ***The gospel approach to race.*** Christians know that racism does not stem so much from a belief in truth, but from a lack of belief in grace. The gospel leads us to be: a) on the one hand, somewhat critical of *all* cultures, including our own (since there is truth), but b) on the other hand, we can feel morally superior to no one. After all, we are saved by grace alone, and therefore a non-Christian neighbor may be more moral and wise than you. This gives the Christian a radically different posture than either moralists or relativists.

Note: Relativists (as we said above) are ultimately moralistic. And therefore they can be respectful only of other people who believe everything is relative! But Christians cannot feel morally superior to relativists.

The example of a physical handicap.
Let's come down from something sociological (racism) to something psychological. Imagine that through disease or an accident, you lost your eyesight--you became blind. How would you bring the gospel to bear on this pain and grief?
The moralistic person will either a) despair, because the handicap takes away something which was his/her "righteousness" or b) deny, refusing to admit the new permanent limitation. ***The hedonistic person will also either*** a) despair, because the handicap takes away their ability to live a pleasure-oriented life, or b) deny, because his/her philosophy cannot bear it. But ***the gospel will lead to*** a) resist the handicap, yet b) accept it too. Too much resistance is denial and too much acceptance is despair. The gospel is real

about both sin and grace, and thus can give the handicapped person the same balance.)

Part II. - THE KEY TO EVERYTHING

We have seen that the gospel is the way that anything is renewed and transformed by Christ--whether a heart, a relationship, a church, or a community. It is the key to all doctrine and our view of our lives in this world. Therefore, all our problems come from a lack of orientation to the gospel. Put positively, the gospel transforms our hearts and thinking and approaches to absolutely everything.

A. The Gospel and the individual.

1. Approach to discouragement. When a person is depressed, the moralist says, "you are breaking the rules--repent." On the other hand, the relativist says, "you just need to love and accept yourself". But (assuming there is no physiological base of the depression!) the gospel leads us to examine ourselves and say: "something in my life has become more important than God, a pseudo-savior, a form of works-righteousness". The gospel leads us to repentance, but not to merely setting our will against superficialities. It is without the gospel that superficialities will be addressed instead of the heart. The moralist will work on behavior and the relativist will work on the emotions themselves.

2. Approach to the physical world. Some moralists are indifferent to the physical world--they see it as "unimportant", while many others are downright afraid of physical pleasure. Since they are seeking to earn their salvation, they prefer to focus on sins of the physical like sex and the other appetites. These are easier to avoid than sins of the spirit like pride. Therefore, they prefer to see sins of the body as worse than other kinds. As a result, legalism usually leads to a distaste of pleasure. On the other hand, the relativist is often a hedonist, someone who is controlled by pleasure, and who makes it an idol. The gospel leads us to see that God has invented both body and soul and so will redeem both body and soul, though under sin both body and soul are broken. Thus the gospel leads us to enjoy the physical (and to fight against physical brokenness, such as sickness and poverty), yet to be moderate in our use of material things.

3. Approach to love and relationships. Moralism often makes relationships into a "blame-game". This is because a moralist is traumatized by criticism that is too severe, and maintains a self-image as a good person by blaming others. On the other hand, moralism can use the procuring of love as the way to "earn our salvation" and convince ourselves we are worthy persons. That often creates what is called "co-dependency"--a form of self-salvation through needing people or needing people to need you (i.e. saving yourself by saving others). On the

other hand, much relativism/liberalism reduces love to a negotiated partnership for mutual benefit. You only relate as long as it is not costing you anything. So the choice (without the gospel) is to selfishly use others or to selfishly let yourself be used by others. But the gospel leads us to do neither. We do sacrifice and commit, but not out of a need to convince ourselves or others we are acceptable. So we can love the person enough to confront, yet stay with the person when it does not benefit us.

4. Approach to suffering. Moralism takes the "Job's friends" approach, laying guilt on yourself. You simply assume: "I must be bad to be suffering". Under the guilt, though, there is always anger toward God. Why? Because moralists believe that God owes them. The whole point of moralism is to put God in one's debt. Because you have been so moral, you feel you don't really deserve suffering. So moralism tears you up, for at one level you think, "what did I do to deserve this?" but on another level you think, "I probably did everything to deserve this!" So, if the moralist suffers, he or she must either feel mad at God (because I have been performing well) or mad at self (because I have not been performing well) or both. On the other hand, relativism/pragmatism feels justified in avoiding suffering at all costs--lying, cheating, and broken promises are OK. But when suffering does come, the pragmatist also lays the fault at God's doorstep, claiming that he must be either unjust or impotent. But the cross shows us that God redeemed us through suffering. That he suffered not that we might not suffer, but that in our suffering we could become like him. Since both the moralist and the pragmatist ignore the cross in different ways, they will both be confused and devastated by suffering.

5. Approach to sexuality. The secularist/pragmatist sees sex as merely biological and physical appetite. The moralist tends to see sex as dirty or at least a dangerous impulse that leads constantly to sin. But the gospel shows us that sexuality is to reflect the self-giving of Christ. He gave himself completely without conditions. So we are not to seek intimacy but hold back control of our lives. If we give ourselves sexually we are to give ourselves legally, socially, personally--utterly. Sex only is to happened in a totally committed, permanent relationship of marriage.

6. Approach to one's family. Moralism can make you a slave to parental expectations, while pragmatism sees no need for family loyalty or the keeping of promises and covenants if they do not "meet my needs". The gospel frees you from making parental approval an absolute or psychological salvation, pointing how God becomes the ultimate father. Then you will neither be too dependent or too hostile to your parents.

7. Approach to self-control. Moralists tell us to control our passions out of fear of punishment. This is a volition-based approach. Liberalism tells us to express ourselves and find out what is right for us. This is an emotion-based approach. The gospel tells us that the free, unloseable grace of God "teaches" us to "say

no" to our passions (Titus 2:13) if we listen to it. This is a whole-person based approach, starting with the truth descending into the heart.

8. Approach to other races and cultures. The liberal approach is to relativize all cultures. ("We can all get along because there is no truth".) The conservatives believe there is truth for evaluation of cultures, and so they choose some culture as superior and then they idolize it, feeling superior to others in the impulse of self-justifying pride. The gospel leads us to be: a) on the one hand, somewhat critical of all cultures, including our own (since there is truth), but b) on the other hand, we are morally superior to no one. After all, we are saved by grace alone. Christians will exhibit both moral conviction yet compassion and flexibility. For example, gays are used to being "bashed" and hated or completely accepted. They never see anything else.

9. Approach to witness to non-Christians. The liberal/pragmatist approach is to deny the legitimacy of evangelism altogether. The conservative/moralist person does believe in proselytizing, because "we are right and they are wrong". Such proselyzing is almost always offensive. But the gospel produces a constellation of traits in us. a) First, we are compelled to share the gospel out of generosity and love, not guilt. b) Second, we are freed from fear of being ridiculed or hurt by others, since we already have the favor of God by grace. c) Third, there is a humility in our dealings with others, because we know we are saved only by grace alone, not because of our superior insight or character. d) Fourth, we are hopeful about anyone, even the "hard cases", because we were saved only because of grace, not because we were likely people to be Christians. d) Fifth, we are courteous and careful with people. We don't have to push or coerce them, for it is only God's grace that opens hearts, not our eloquence or persistence or even their openness. All these traits not only create a winsome evangelist but an excellent neighbor in a multi-cultural society.

10. Approach to human authority. Moralists will tend to obey human authorities (family, tribe, government, cultural customs) too much, since they rely so heavily on their self-image of being moral and decent. Pragmatists will either obey human authority too much (since they have no higher authority by which they can judge their culture) or else too little (since they may only obey when they know they won't get caught). That mean either authoritarianism or anarchy. But the gospel gives you both a standard by which to oppose human authority (if it contradicts the gospel), but on the other hand, gives you incentive to obey the civil authorities from the heart, even when you could get away with disobedience.

11. Approach to human dignity. Moralists often have a pretty low view of human nature--they mainly see human sin and depravity. Pragmatists, on the other hand, have no good basis for treating people with dignity. Usually they have no religious beliefs about what human beings are. (If they are just chance products of evolution, how do we know they are more valuable than a rock?)

But the gospel shows us that every human being is infinitely fallen (lost in sin) and infinitely exalted (in the image of God). So we treat every human being as precious, yet dangerous!

12. Approach to guilt. When someone says, "I can't forgive myself", it means there is some standard or condition or person that is more central to your identity than the grace of God. God is the only God who forgives--no other "god" will. If you cannot forgive yourself, it is because you have failed your real God, your real righteousness, and it is holding you captive. The moralist's false god is usually a God of their imagination which is holy and demanding but not gracious. The pragmatist's false god is usually some achievement or relationship.

13. Approach to self-image. Without the gospel, your self-image is based upon living up to some standards--whether yours or someone's imposed upon you. If you live up to those standards, you will be confident but not humble. If you don't live up to them, you will be humble but not confident. Only in the gospel can you be both enormously bold and utterly sensitive and humble. For you are both perfect and a sinner!

14. Approach to joy and humor. Moralism has to eat away at real joy and humor--because the system of legalism forces you to take yourself (your image, your appearance, your reputation) very seriously. Pragmatism on the other hand will tend toward cynicism as life goes on because of the inevitable cynicism that grows. This cynicism grows from a lack of hope for the world. In the end, evil will triumph--there is no judgment or divine justice. But is we are saved by grace alone, then the very fact of our being Christians is a constant source of amazed delight. There is nothing matter-of-fact about our lives, no "of course" to our lives. It is a miracle we are Christians, and we have hope. So the gospel which creates bold humility should give us a far deeper sense of humor. We don't have to take ourselves seriously, and we are full of hope for the world.

15. Approach to "right living". Jonathan Edwards points out that "true virtue" is only possible for those who have experienced the grace of the gospel. Any person who is trying to earn their salvation does "the right thing" in order to get into heaven, or in order to better their self-esteem (etc.). In other words, the ultimate motive is self-interest. But persons who know they are totally accepted already do "the right thing" out of sheer delight in righteousness for its own sake. Only in the gospel do you obey God for God's sake, and not for what God will give you. Only in the gospel do you love people for their sake (not yours), do good for its own sake (not yours), and obey God for his sake (not yours). Only the gospel makes "doing the right thing" a joy and delight, not a burden or a means to an end.

B. The Gospel and the church.

1. Approach to ministry in the world. Legalism tends to place all the emphasis on the individual human soul. Legalistic religion will insist on converting others to their faith and church, but will ignore social needs of the broader community. On the other hand, "liberalism" will tend to emphasize only amelioration of social conditions and minimize the need for repentance and conversion. The gospel leads to love which in turn moves us to give our neighbor what*ever* is needed--conversion or a cup of cold water, evangelism and social concern.

2. Approach to worship. Moralism leads to a dour and somber worship which may be long on dignity but short on joy. A shallow understanding of "acceptance" without a sense of God's holiness can lead to frothy or casual worship. (A sense of neither God's love nor his holiness leads to a worship service that feels like a committee meeting.) But the gospel leads us to see that God is both transcendent yet immanent. His immanence makes his transcendence comforting, while his transcendence makes his immanence amazing. The gospel leads to both awe and intimacy in worship, for the Holy One is now our Father.

3. Approach to the poor. The liberal/pragmatist tend to scorn the religion of the poor and see them as helpless victims needing expertise. This is born out of a disbelief in God's common grace or special grace to all. Ironically, the secular mindset also disbelieves in sin, and thus anyone who is poor must be oppressed, a helpless victim. The conservative/moralists on the other hand tend to scorn the poor as failures and weaklings. They see them as somehow to blame for their situation. But the gospel leads us to be: a) humble, without moral superiority knowing you were "spiritually bankrupt" but saved by Christ's free generosity, and b) gracious, not worried too much about "deservingness", since you didn't deserve Christ's grace, c) respectful of believing poor Christians as brothers and sisters from whom to learn. The gospel alone can bring "knowledge workers" into a sense of humble respect for and solidarity with the poor.

4. Approach to doctrinal distinctives. The "already" of the New Testament means more boldness in proclamation. We can most definitely be sure of the central doctrines that support the gospel. But, the "not yet" means charity and humility in non-essentials beliefs. In other words, we must be moderate about what we teach except when it comes to the cross, grace and sin. In our views, especially those that Christians cannot agree on, we must be less unbending and triumphalistic ("believing we have arrived intellectually"). It also means that our discernment of God's call and his "will" for us and other must not be propagated with overweening assurance that your insight cannot be wrong. Vs. pragmatism, we must be willing to die for our belief in the gospel; vs. moralism, we must not fight to the death over every one of our beliefs.

5. Approach to holiness. The "already" means we should not tolerate sin. The presence of the kingdom includes that we are made "partakers of the divine nature" (II Pet. 1:3). The gospel brings us the confidence that anyone can be changed, that any enslaving habit can be overcome. But the "not yet" our sin which remains in us and will never be eliminated until the fullness of the kingdom comes in. So we must avoid pat answers, and we must not expect "quick fixes". Unlike the moralists, we must be patient with slow growth or lapses and realize the complexity of change and growth in grace. Unlike the pragmatists and cynics, we must insist that miraculous change is possible.

6. Approach to miracles. The "already" of the kingdom means power for miracles and healing is available. Jesus showed the kingdom by healing the sick and raising the dead. But the "not yet" means nature (including us) is still subject to decay (Rom.8:22-23) and thus sickness and death is still inevitable until the final consummation. We cannot expect miracles and the elimination of suffering to be such a normal part of the Christian life that pain and suffering will be eliminated from the lives of faithful people. Vs. moralists, we know that God can heal and do miracles. Vs. pragmatists, we do not aim to press God into eliminating suffering.

7. Approach to church health. The "already" of the kingdom means that the church is the community now of kingdom power. It therefore is capable of mightily transforming its community. Evangelism that adds *"daily to the number of those being saved"* (Acts 2:47) is possible! Loving fellowship which *"destroyed...the dividing wall of hostility"* between different races and classes is possible! But the "not yet" of sin means Jesus has not yet presented his bride, the church "*as a radiant church, without stain or wrinkle or any other blemish"* (Eph.5:27). We must not then be harshly critical of imperfect congregations, nor jump impatiently from church to church over perceived blemishes. Error will never be completely eradicated from the church. The "not yet" means to avoid the overly severe use of church discipline and other means to seek to bring about a perfect church today.

8. Approach to social change. We must not forget that Christ is even now ruling in a sense over history (Eph.1:22ff). The "already" of grace means that Christians can expect to use God's power to change social conditions and communities. But the "not yet" of sin means there will be "wars and rumors of wars". Selfishness, cruelty, terrorism, oppression will continue. Christians harbor no illusions about politics nor expect utopian conditions. The "not yet" means that Christians will trust any political or social agenda to bring about righteousness here on earth. So the gospel keeps us from the over-pessimism of fundamentalism (moralism) about social change, and also from the over-optimism of liberalism (pragmatism).

Sum: All problems, personal or social come from a failure to use the gospel in a radical way, to get *"in line with the truth of the gospel"* (Gal.2:14). All pathologies in the church and all its ineffectiveness comes from a failure to use the gospel in a radical way. We believe that if the gospel is expounded and applied in its fullness in any church, that church will look very unique. People will find both moral conviction yet compassion and flexibility. For example, gays are used to being "bashed" and hated or completely accepted. They never see anything else. The cultural elites of either liberal or conservative sides are alike in their unwillingness to befriend or live with or respect or worship with the poor. They are alike in separating themselves increasingly from the rest of society.

Chapter 13: Applying the Gospel to Culture

The book of Ephesians may be the single best book of the Bible presenting a doctrine of the church.

Eph 1:20-23- *He raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realms, far above all rule and authority, power and dominion, and every title that can be given, not only in the present age but also in the one to come. And God placed all things under his feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills everything in every way.*

Eph 2:15- His *purpose was to create in himself one new man out of the two, thus making peace, and in this one body to reconcile both of them to God through the cross.*

Eph 3: 10-11 His *intent was that now, through the church, the manifold wisdom of God would be made known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms, according to his eternal purpose which he accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord.*

THE CHURCH AS THE EMBODIMENT OF THE KINGDOM OF GOD[1]

1. THE OVERLAP OF THE AGES.

In Eph. 1:20, we are told that Christ was *seated* (past tense) and given dominion over both *the present age* and *the age to come.* This is a surprising statement, namely that Jesus is right *now* ruling over both the present age and the age to come. (It does not say that he will rule over the age to come but that he is ruling over it.) How can he rule over something that is future? Just as puzzling, Eph. 2:2 and Col. 1:13-14 tells us that we are now delivered from the present age. (It does not say that we will be rescued from the present age, but that we are.) How can we have escaped an age that we live in?

"This present age" is the age in which sin reigns and therefore everything is disintegrating. It began with the Fall in Genesis 3. As soon as Adam and Eve sinned they experienced spiritual alienation from God, emotional alienation within, social alienation from each other, and physical alienation from nature. In other words, the present age is an age in which everything eventually falls apart--spiritually, emotionally, socially, physically. The Old Testament continually looked toward a new day, the "age to come" in which God would come back and redeem the world, and all the alienations/ disintegrations would be healed. There would be no more crying, fighting or death. Thus the religious leaders of Israel expected that when the Messiah came, the present age would end, and the age to come would begin. Why? The 'disintegration' (cf. Rom.8:18ff) is because we are not under the King. "The hands of the king are healing hands, and thus shall the rightful king be known." (Tolkien)

In Christ, even the natural order will be redeemed. Psalm 96 tells us what will happen when Jesus returns to judge or rule the earth.

Let the heavens be glad, let the earth rejoice; let the sea roar and all that fills it;
let the field exult, and all that is within it. Then shall the trees of the wood sing for joy before the Lord, for he comes, he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world in righteousness and the people with his truth. --Psalm 96:11-13

This refers to the Final Day, when we come finally into the presence of our Lord and know the freedom of being completely submitted to his royal Kingship. The healing Kingship of Christ will extend to all of life and nature. The blessedness of the kingdom is radical and all-embracing (Matthew 5:3-10). All the alienations caused by sin are healed. Each Christmas we sing Isaac Watts' hymn of praise to the blessedness of the kingdom. He paraphrases Psalm 96 in stanza two.

[1] Tim Keller, *Theology of Christian Community*, School of Servant Leadership, Version 1.0

Joy to the world! the Saviour reigns:
Let men their songs employ,
While fields and floods, rocks, hills, and plains,
Repeat the sounding joy.

No more let sins and sorrows grow,
Nor thorns infest the ground;
He comes to make his blessings flow
Far as the curse is found!

The kingdom of God is the means for renewal of the entire world and all the dimensions of life. From the throne of Jesus Christ flows new life and power such that no disease, decay, poverty, blemish or pain can stand before it.

Jesus, however, comes saying the kingdom is here (Mark 1: 14-15), that it is among us (Luke 17:21), that we enter it when we are born again (John 3:5); yet he tells us to pray for "thy kingdom come" and that it has not yet come. This is the same kind of odd teaching we see in Paul when he talks about the present age and the age to come as both being present now. How could this be? Jesus, the Messiah, does not come to redeem the world only once. He comes twice. The first time, he brings the power of the age to come into this world (that is why we can experience it--Heb.6:5; John 3:5). But the present age is not gone--it is still here. When Christ returns, the old age will end completely, and the age to come will come fully. Meanwhile we live in "the overlap of the ages."

This means that there are two spiritual dimensions, two different ways of thinking (notice Rom. 12:2), two different realms in which different "gods" rule (notice Col. 1:13-14). When we become Christians, even though we live in the world, we are rescued from it. What does that mean? Col. 1:13-14 says we are *"transferred"* out of it. Since we aren't transferred physically, it must mean we are transferred legally and spiritually. For example, in the age to come, we will hear the verdict "Well, done, good and faithful servant." But when we become Christians we receive the end-time verdict now (Rom. 8:1) and we are called to live in the light of that, with the joyous confidence that is due. That is part of what it means to "not be conformed to this age" (Rom. 12:2). We are free from the condemnation of this age and therefore from the thinking and values of this age. Even further, the power of the Holy Spirit comes in, which is "the powers of the age to come" (Heb.6:5). We only get a foretaste, but it is a real taste. We become healed of the alienations of the present age. We stop falling apart spiritually, emotionally, relationally--though not physically (yet).

2. THE 'POWERS' AND 'AUTHORITIES'.

A major and puzzling issue in the writings especially of Paul is his reference to 'principalities and powers and rulers' in the heavenly places. What are they? There are three less-than adequate interpretations. 1) Liberal commentators think that these are demons, and therefore we can discount all such references as outmoded superstition. 2) Charismatic Christians think these are simple demonic forces as well, but they do not discount them. They believe they are evil spirits who try to possess or oppress individuals and most charismatic resources take a pretty pietistic and individualistic approach to them. 3) Some evangelicals just kind of ignore all the references.

A better interpretation is the most complex one--the 'powers' are never merely demons but human authorities and power which become demonic apart from Christ. Sometimes, the New Testament's discussion of the 'powers' or 'rulers of this world' are clearly human authorities (since they killed Christ, I Cor.2:8; and they collect taxes, Romans 13). Yet other times, the 'ruler' or 'rulers' of this world are clearly Satan or demons (Eph. 2:2, John 12:31). Perhaps it is clearest in the book of Revelation that human civil, economic and social rulers are linked to demonic forces. Paul tells us clearly that these powers were <u>unmasked</u> and defeated by the cross (Col. 2:14) and now are under the risen Christ's feet (Eph. 1:21). These powers also see the alternative way of using power in the church (Eph. 3:10).

A good exposition of this more nuanced interpretation is in Lesslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralistic*

Society: When we hear St. Paul speak of 'principalities, powers, dominions, thrones, authorities'... we imagine a host of angelic or demonic beings flying around in the air somewhere above our heads ... [But] these powers do not exist apart from the human agencies in which they are embodied--Pilate, Herod, Caiaphas, the powers 'that crucified Christ' (1 Cor 2:8). Yet they are not identical with these particular individuals. We are talking about power and authority which is real, exercised by real human beings, but which is not identical with them.

[What Paul means] is that good gifts have become powers that enslave, from which Christ had to deliver us by his death. The powers of this world, created in Christ and for Christ, become agents of tyranny....

Race (with family, kinship, tribal communities) is an element in the structuring of human life-but when it is given absolute status, not subject to the power of Christ, it becomes a demonic power. Money is another example. In some societies it becomes a power which demands and receives absolute devotion. In the vision of Marx, the proletariat was to be a sort of corporate Messiah which would overthrow the power of the false god of capitalism. But alas, the proletariat is not Christ. And Marxist ideology became itself a demonic power in the Pauline sense, which crushes the free expression of the human spirit.…In Galatians, Paul even seems to identify the powers with the Law. He tells believers that if they go back into legalism and seek to save themselves with the Law, they will turn back to the "stoichea" of the universe. He says the same in Col. 2:8, 20 So the Law, like the other powers, is a good gift of God, yet it has become a power that enslaves, from which Christ had to deliver us.

The principalities and powers are real ... In the cross, Christ has disarmed them ... The cross and the resurrection do not destroy the powers, [race, capital, political influence, physical beauty] but they are cast off their thrones, they lose their pretended absoluteness. Nothing is now absolute except God as he is known in Jesus Christ--everything else is relativized. That is the bottom line for all Christian thinking and the starting point for all the Christian action in the affairs of the world.

Summary. The 'powers' are race, capital, politics, religion, scholarship, institutions, law--all good gifts that become enslaving and oppressing powers when exercised by people as alternative saviors and salvations apart from Christ. Outside of Christ, morality, money, race--all become oppressive powers. Inside Christ, they become our servants.

3. THE 'WISDOM OF THE CHURCH'

How are we to challenge the power, then? Eph. 3:10-11 says that the purpose of the church is to show the world--and the powers--the "wisdom of God." Eph. 2:11-5 says that the church is to exhibit a *new humanity*. The kingdom of God--the "age to come" is a completely alternate way of using God's good gifts. We don't make race or money or the state or the individual or the proletariat into an idol--a "savior." When we do so, it creates a power that oppresses.

What is the relationship of the church to the partially here kingdom of God? On the one hand, the church is a pilot plant of the kingdom of God. It is not simply a collection of individuals who are forgiven. It is a "royal nation" (I Peter 2:9), in other words, a counterculture. The church is to be a new society in which the world can see exhibited what family life, business practices, race relations, and all of life can be under the kingship of Jesus Christ. God is out to heal all the effects of sin, psychological, social and physical.

On the other hand, the church is to be an agent of the kingdom. It is not only to model the healing of God's rule but it is to spread it. "You are ... a royal priesthood, a holy nation ... that you may declare the deeds of him that called you out of darkness into his marvelous light" (I Peter 2:9). Christians go into the world as witnesses of the kingdom (Acts). To spread the kingdom of God is more than simply winning men to Christ. It is also working for healing of persons, families, relationships; it is doing deeds of mercy and seeking justice. It is ordering lives and relationships and institutions according to God's authority to bring in the blessedness of the kingdom.

Newbigin again: *What are we talking about when we speak of confronting the institutions of state and market economy and culture with the gospel? We are not fighting with the individuals who perform roles in these institutions. We know well that when we get a chance to talk intimately with them, they feel themselves powerless. To the outsider they appear to wield great power, but they know that they are under*

the control of forces greater than their own and that their freedom to change things is very narrowly limited. Those who call for a Christian assault on the world's politics and economics make it clear that the aim of the attack is to seize the levers of power and take control. We have seen many such successful revolutions, and we know that in most cases what has happened is simply that the oppressor and the oppressed have exchanged roles. The throne is unshaken only there is a different person on the throne.

How is the throne itself to be shaken? Only by the power of the gospel itself--announced in word, embodied in deed [and in the Christian community] ... The victory of the Church over the demonic Power of the Roman imperial system did not begin when Christians seized the levers of power: it was won when the victims knelt down in the Coliseum and prayed in the name of Jesus for the Emperor. The martyrs did not displace the emperor with swords, but rather through them the entire mystique of the Empire, its spiritual power, was unmasked, disarmed, made powerless.

I think Newbigin is saying that only when Christians can embody in their community an alternate way to use power, based on the freedom we have in the gospel, then the powers can be disarmed. Only when the world sees a true spirit of service, and not just another power grab for *our* Christian party and power-bloc, will it begin to look at itself in repentance. Only when the world sees people who have an utterly different attitude toward wealth and status will it begin to look at itself in repentance. Only when relativists see Christians embrace them in a way that they cannot embrace Christians will the world begin to look at itself in repentance.

The Church's Relationship to the Kingdom of this World

At Mt. Sinai, God constituted Israel as a nation. In the history of Israel covered by the Bible, there were two eras in which they lived as believers in a pluralistic, pagan environment. First, when they got to Canaan, they failed to drive out the idol-worshipping people groups and, instead, settled in among them. Secondly, when Nebuchadnezzar defeated Jerusalem, he carried most of the Israelites off to live in the city and environs of Babylon. In both situations, believers did not live in a believing nation or culture, where the government, the arts, the cultural institutions were committed to the Lord and his Word and will. They lived in an environment where the dominant and privileged culture was pagan. Christians in Europe and North America today live in a similar situation. Once, Christianity was privileged in society- -it was the dominant culture. The government/culture was either formally or implicitly committed to the Bible and Christianity. But now that has changed, and we find ourselves in a pluralistic culture. When we study the OT books of Judges and Daniel we learn good and bad models for how believers can relate to an unbelieving, dominant culture.

MODEL.1. THE "UN-CULTURE" - JUDGES 14-16

"Accommodations" - In this model, believers simply give in, adopting the pagan culture's values and world-view, both internally (in their fundamental values and perspectives) and externally (by learning and adopting the customs and habits of dress, food and language). This is also an **"immigrant"** model. The immigrant comes to a new culture with the goal of blending in and losing any distinct identity. Judges gives us many sad examples of this. By the time of Samson (Judges 14-16), the Israelites were so accommodated to Philistine culture that they were within a generation of losing all distinct identity.

MODEL 2. - THE "SUB-CULTURE" - JUDGES 17-18

"Privatization" - In this model, believers keep the external trappings of Christian faith and practice, but they adopt the more fundamental values and perspectives of the dominant culture. Often this is called privatization because one's faith is kept to Sunday services externals and does not really shape the way we actually live. This may be called an **"oreo"** model, in which we superficially resemble one culture but internally and actually we are another. For example, believers may not smoke or drink too much or have sex outside of marriage, and may use lots of pious evangelical jargon--tribal dialect--yet in their core beings they may be as materialistic and individualistic, status or image-conscious as the society around. In this model, believers stay somewhat apart from unbelievers in their churches, schools and institutions, yet they have just sprinkled Bible verses and pious language on a lifestyle that is fundamentally no different from those around them. They do not model the kingdom by showing the world embodied values that don't exist outside of Christ--racial

harmony, generous/simple lifestyles, psychological health and healing, chastity, self-sacrifice and integrity. Thus they are a sub-culture--just a sub-set of the dominant culture. The story of Micah and his mother is a perfect example. Though formally worshipping the Lord, the idolatrous attitude of the surrounding culture had penetrated them to the core. They sought to manipulate God into giving them prosperity and comfort through limited "buy-offs" of the deity rather than surrender to his grace.

MODEL 3. - THE "ANTI-CULTURE" - PSALM 137

"Ghettoization and/or militancy" - In this model, believers respond to the unbelieving culture with a sense of superiority and hostility and a very great degree of separation. They feel highly polluted by the very presence of the unbelieving schools, entertainment, arts and culture, and feel they cannot really function in the society without having the cultural power. In the West since Constantine, Christianity was backed by legislation and the power institutions of society. Many Christians feel the need to "take our culture back" which means, essentially, to return to Constantianism, This is the **"soldier" model,** in which believers consider themselves hostile visitors, seeking to "take back" the culture through introducing legislation and taking over storming institutions. Some take a more passive approach and withdraw from any real interaction, just denouncing and bewailing the moral decay, while others aim to get the cultural power back. Psalm 137 gave us a picture of people who are more angry than repentant over their new powerless situation, and who cannot envision how they can worship and function outside of the land where they had sovereignty.

MODEL 4. - THE "PARA-CULTURE"- JEREMIAH 28

"Revivalist" -In this model, believers respond not with too much pessimism but too much optimism. They expect a miraculous, sweeping intervention by God which will convert many or most individuals and explosively transform the culture. Therefore, instead of becoming deeply engaged with the society and people around them, working with others as co-citizens to deal with the troubles and problems, believers concentrate completely on evangelism and discipleship, building up the church and their own numbers. They often justify this by saying, "if enough people became Christians, then our other problems would go away." In this model, Christians are often pressed to go into "full-time ministry" but not to become playwrights, artists, lawyers or business people. This revivalist (also called *pietist*) approach forms a happy parallel alternative culture, with a goal of picking off individual converts and bringing them in. This is a **"tourist"** model in which the believers are just "passing through," enjoying the society but not becoming involved. The prophet Hananiah in Jeremiah 28 is a great example of this kind of optimistic approach.

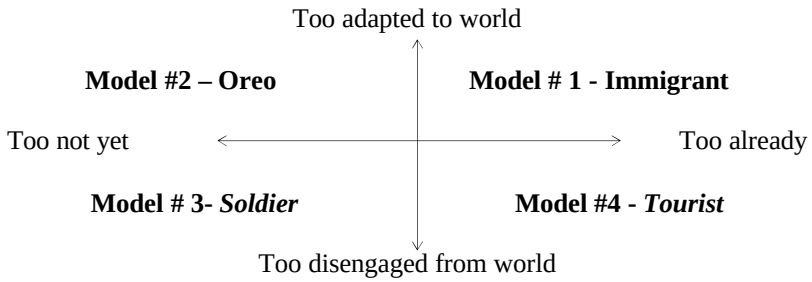
MODEL 5. – THE "COUNTER-CULTURE" - JEREMIAH 29

"Engagement" - In this model, believers engagement with the pagan culture and co-working with pagan people but in ways that reveal the distinctiveness of the values of the kingdom of God. This is a complete reverse of the second model. They are externally quite like the surrounding culture (positive toward and conversant with it), without 'jargon' and other Christians trappings--yet in worldview, values and lifestyle, they demonstrate chastity, simplicity, humility and self-sacrifice. They are quite different in the way they understand money, relationships, human life, sex, and so on. This is the **"resident aliens" or "colony of heaven"** model. Believers are truly resident, yet not seeking the power or approval of the dominant culture. They learn the language and ways of their home-resident culture, but their citizenship and ultimate allegiance is in heaven, rather than showing the world an alternative way of living and of being a human community. Jeremiah's letter to the exiles in chapter 29 lays this model out. And Daniel, Esther and Joseph show us how to live it out. Harvie Conn has a marvelous way of putting this model:

Perhaps the best analogy to describe all this is that of a model home. We are God's demonstration community of the rule of Christ in the unbelieving city. On a tract of earth's land, purchased with the blood of Christ, Jesus the kingdom developer has begun building new housing. As a sample of what will be, he has erected a model home of what will eventually fill the urban neighborhood. He now invites the ... world into that model home to take a look at what will be. The church is the occupant of that model home, inviting neighbors into its open door to Christ. Evangelism is when the signs are up, saying "Come in and look around."...As citizens of, not survivalists in, this new city within the old city, we see our ownership as the gift of Jesus the Builder (Luke 17-20-21). As residents, not pilgrims, we await the kingdom coming when the Lord returns from his distant country (Luke 19:12). The land is already his ... in this model home we live out our new lifestyle as citizens of the heavenly city that one day will come .... We do not abandon our jobs or desert the city that is .... We are to seek the peace and prosperity of the city to which God called us

in exile (Jer.29:7). And our agenda of concerns in that seeking becomes as large as the cities where our divine development tracts are found.

JESUS—THE ONLY TRUE MODEL



The first two models are over-adaptations (too close to the world) and the third and fourth models are under-engagements (too far from the world). These are not perfectly distinct categories of course, and nobody gets it right. Nobody except for one. Jesus Christ became really and fully human, one of us, completely engaged with us--yet without a bit of sin. The incarnation then becomes our ultimate model. We knew God was loving, wise and holy, but Christ brought the love, wisdom and holiness of God down and showed it to us in concrete form. That is what we are to do. Christians are to be truly incarnate in the culture, yet our citizenship is in heaven (Phil.3:20). We are to bring the love, wisdom and holiness into the midst of our culture, yet without sin.

WHY TO PLANT CHURCHES

Tim Keller
Redeemer Presbyterian Church
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Introduction

The vigorous, continual planting of new congregations is the single most crucial strategy for 1) the numerical growth of the Body of Christ in any city, and 2) the continual corporate renewal and revival of the existing churches in a city. Nothing else--not crusades, outreach programs, para-church ministries, growing mega-churches, congregational consulting, nor church renewal processes--will have the consistent impact of dynamic, extensive church planting. This is an eyebrow raising statement. But to those who have done any study at all, it is not even controversial.

The normal response to discussions about church planting is something like this:

> **A.** 'We already have plenty of churches that have lots and lots of room for all the new people who have come to the area. Let's get *them* filled before we go off building any new ones."
>
> **B.** 'Every church in this community used to be more full than it is now. The churchgoing public is a 'shrinking pie'. A new church here will just take people from churches already hurting and weaken everyone.'
>
> **C.** 'Help the churches that are struggling first. A new church doesn't help the ones we have that are just keeping their nose above water. We need *better* churches, not more churches.'

These statements appear to be 'common sense' to many people, but they rest on several wrong assumptions. The error of this thinking will become clear if we ask *'Why is church planting so crucially important?'* Because--

A. We want to be true to THE BIBLICAL MANDATE

1. Jesus' essential call was to plant churches. Virtually all the great evangelistic challenges of the New Testament are basically calls to plant churches, not simply to share the faith. The 'Great Commission' (Matt.28: 18-20) is not just a call to *'make disciples'* but to *'baptize'*. In Acts and elsewhere, it is clear that baptism means incorporation into a worshipping community with accountability and boundaries (cf. Acts 2:41-47). The only way to be truly sure you are increasing the number of Christians in a town is to increase the number of churches. Why? Much traditional evangelism aims to get a 'decision' for Christ. Experience, however, shows us that many of these 'decisions' disappear and never result in changed lives. Why? Many, many decisions are not really conversions, but often only the beginning of a journey of seeking God. (Other decisions are very definitely the moment of a 'new birth', but this differs from person to person.) Only a person who is being 'evangelized' in the context of an on-going worshipping and shepherding community can be sure of finally coming home into vital, saving faith. This is why a leading missiologist like C.Peter Wagner can say, *"Planting new churches is the most effective evangelistic methodology known under heaven."*[1]

2. Paul's whole strategy was to plant urban churches. The greatest missionary in history, St.Paul, had a rather simple, two-fold strategy. First, he went into the largest city of the region (cf. Acts 16:9,12), and second, he planted churches in each city (cf. Titus 1:5-

[1] C.Peter Wagner, *Strategies for Growth* (Glendale: Regal, 1987), p. 168.

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"appoint elders in every town"). Once Paul had done that, he could say that he had '*fully preached'* the gospel in a region and that he had *'no more work'* to do there (cf. Romans 15:19,23). This means Paul had two controlling assumptions: a) that the way to most permanently influence a country was through its chief cities, and b) the way to most permanently influence a city was to plant churches in it. Once he had accomplished this in a city, he moved on. He knew that the rest that needed to happen would follow.

Response: *'But,'* many people say, *'that was in the beginning. Now the country (at least <u>our</u> country) is filled with churches. Why is church planting important <u>now</u>?"* We also plant churches because--

B. We want to be true to THE GREAT COMMISSION. Some facts--

1. New churches best reach a) new generations, b) new residents, and c) new people groups. First (a) younger adults have always been disproportionately found in newer congregations. Long-established congregations develop traditions (such as time of worship, length of service, emotional responsiveness, sermon topics, leadership-style, emotional atmosphere, and thousands of other tiny customs and mores), which reflect the sensibilities of long-time leaders from the older generations who have the influence and money to control the church life. This does not reach younger generations. Second, (b) new residents are almost always reached better by new congregations. In older congregations, it may require tenure of 10 years before you are allowed into places of leadership and influence, but in a new church, new residents tend to have equal power with long-time area residents.

Last, (c) new socio-cultural groups in a community are always reached better by new congregations. For example, if new white-collar commuters move into an area where the older residents were farmers, it is likely that a new church will be more receptive to the myriad of needs of the new residents, while the older churches will continue to be oriented to the original social group. And new racial groups in a community are best reached by a new church that is intentionally multi-ethnic from the start. For example: if an all-Anglo neighborhood becomes 33% Hispanic, a new, deliberately bi-racial church will be far more likely to create 'cultural space' for newcomers than will an older church in town. Finally, brand new immigrant groups nearly always can only be reached by churches ministering in their own language. If we wait until a new group is assimilated into American culture enough to come to our church, we will wait for years without reaching out to them.

[Note: Often, a new congregation for a new people-group can be planted *within* the overall structure of an existing church. It may be a new Sunday service at another time, or a new network of house churches that are connected to a larger, already existing congregation. Nevertheless, though it may technically not be a new independent congregation, it serves the same function.]

In summary, new congregations *empower* new people and new peoples much more quickly and readily than can older churches. Thus they always have and always will reach them with greater facility than long-established bodies. This means, of course, that church planting is not only for 'frontier regions' or 'pagan' countries that we are trying to see *become* Christian. Christian countries will have to maintain vigorous, extensive church planting simply to *stay* Christian!

2. New churches best reach the unchurched--period. Dozens of denominational studies have confirmed that the average new church gains most of its new members (60-80%) from the ranks of people who are not attending any worshipping body, while churches over 10-

15 years of age gain 80-90% of new members by transfer from other congregations.[2] This means that the average new congregation will bring 6-8 times more new people into the life of the Body of Christ than an older congregation of the same size.

So though established congregations provide many things that newer churches often cannot, older churches in general will never be able to match the effectiveness of new bodies in reaching people for the kingdom. Why would this be? As a congregation ages, powerful internal institutional pressures lead it to allocate most of its resources and energy toward the concerns of its members and constituents, rather than toward those outside its walls. This is natural and to a great degree desirable. Older congregations therefore have a stability and steadiness that many people thrive on and need. This does not mean that established churches cannot win new people. In fact, many non-Christians will only be reached by churches with long roots in the community and the trappings of stability and respectability.

However, new congregations, in general, are forced to focus on the needs of its *non*-members, simply in order to get off the ground. So many of its leaders have come very recently from the ranks of the un-churched, that the congregation is far more sensitive to the concerns of the non-believer. Also, in the first two years of our Christian walk, we have far more close, face-to-face relationships with non-Christians than we do later. Thus a congregation filled with people fresh from the ranks of the un-churched will have the power to invite and attract many more non-believers into the events and life of the church than will the members of the typical established body.

What does this mean practically? If we want to reach our city--should we try to renew older congregations to make them more evangelistic, or should we plant lots of new churches? But that question is surely a false either-or dichotomy. We should do both! Nevertheless, all we have been saying proves that, despite the occasional exceptions, the only widescale way to bring in lots of new Christians to the Body of Christ in a permanent way is to plant new churches.

To throw this into relief, imagine Town-A and Town-B and Town-C are the same size, and they each have 100 churches of 100 persons each. But in Town-A, all the churches are over 15 years old, and then the overall number of active Christian churchgoers in that town will be shrinking, even if four or five of the churches get very 'hot' and double in attendance. In Town-B, 5 of the churches are under 15 years old, and they along with several older congregations are winning new people to Christ, but this only offsets the normal declines of the older churches. Thus the overall number of active Christian churchgoers in that town will be staying the same. Finally, in Town-C, 30 of the churches are under 15 years old. In this town, the overall number of active Christian churchgoers will be on a path to grow 50% in a generation.[3]

Response: *'But,'* many people say, *'what about all the existing churches that need help? You seem to be ignoring them.'* Not at all. We also plant churches because--

C. We want to continually RENEW THE WHOLE BODY OF CHRIST.

It is a great mistake to think that we have to choose *between* church planting and church renewal. Strange as it may seem, the planting of new churches in a city is one of the very best

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[2] Lyle Schaller, quoted in D.McGavran and G.Hunter, *Church Growth: Strategies that Work* (Nashville: Abingdon, 1980), p. 100. See C.Kirk Hadaway, *New Churches and Church Growth in the Southern Baptist Convention* (Nashville: Broadman, 1987).

[3] See Lyle Schaller, *44 Questions for Church Planters* (Nashville: Abingdon, 1991), p.12. Schaller talks about 'The 1% Rule'. Each year any association of churches should plant new congregations at the rate of 1% of their existing total--otherwise, that association will be in decline. That is just 'maintenance'. If an association wants to grow 50%+, it must plant 2-3% per year.

ways to revitalize many older churches in the vicinity and renew the whole Body of Christ. Why?

1. First, the new churches bring new ideas to the whole Body. There is plenty of resistance to the idea that we need to plant new churches to reach the constant stream of 'new' groups and generations and residents. Many congregations insist that all available resources should be used to find ways of helping existing churches reach them. However, there is no better way to teach older congregations about new skills and methods for reaching new people groups than by planting new churches. It is the new churches that will have freedom to be innovative and they become the 'Research and Development' department for the whole Body in the city. Often the older congregations were too timid to try a particular approach or were absolutely sure it would 'not work here'. But when the new church in town succeeds wildly with some new method, the other churches eventually take notice and get the courage to try it themselves.

2. Second, new churches are one of the best ways to surface creative, strong leaders for the whole Body. In older congregations, leaders emphasize tradition, tenure, routine, and kinship ties. New congregations, on the other hand, attract a higher percentage of venturesome people who value creativity, risk, innovation and future orientation. Many of these men and women would never be attracted or compelled into significant ministry apart from the appearance of these new bodies. Often older churches 'box out' many people with strong leadership skills who cannot work in more traditional settings. New churches thus attract and harness many people in the city whose gifts would otherwise not be utilized in the work of the Body. These new leaders benefit the whole city-Body eventually.

3. Third, the new churches challenge other churches to self-examination. The "success" of new churches often challenges older congregations in general to evaluate themselves in substantial ways. Sometimes it is only in contrast with a new church that older churches can finally define their *own* vision, specialties, and identity. Often the growth of the new congregation gives the older churches hope that 'it can be done', and may even bring about humility and repentance for defeatist and pessimistic attitudes. Sometimes, new congregations can partner with older churches to mount ministries that neither could do by themselves.

4. Fourth, the new church may be an 'evangelistic feeder' for a whole community. The new church often produces many converts who end up in older churches for a variety of reasons. Sometimes the new church is very exciting and outward facing but is also very unstable or immature in its leadership. Thus some converts cannot stand the tumultuous changes that regularly come through the new church and they move to an existing church. Sometimes the new church reaches a person for Christ, but the new convert quickly discovers that he or she does not 'fit' the socio-economic make up of the new congregation, and gravitates to an established congregation where the customs and culture feels more familiar. Ordinarily, the new churches of a city produce new people not only for themselves, but for the older bodies as well.

Sum: Vigorous church planting is one of the best ways to *renew* the existing churches of a city, as well as the best single way to *grow* the whole Body of Christ in a city.

There is one more reason why it is good for the existing churches of the region to initiate or at least support the planting of churches in a given area. We plant churches—

D. As an exercise in KINGDOM-MINDEDNESS

All in all, church planting helps an existing church the best when the new congregation is voluntarily 'birthed' by an older 'mother' congregation. Often the excitement and new leaders and new ministries and additional members and income 'washes back' into the mother church in various ways and strengthens and renews it. Though there is some pain in seeing good friends and some leaders go away to form a new church, the mother church usually experiences a surge of high self-esteem and an influx of new enthusiastic leaders and members.

However, a new church in the community usually confronts churches with a major issue--the issue of 'kingdom-mindedness'. New churches, as we have seen, draw most of their new members (up to 80%) from the ranks of the unchurched, but they *will* always attract some people out of existing churches. That is inevitable. At this point, the existing churches, in a sense, have a question posed to them: "Are we going to rejoice in the 80%--the new people that the kingdom has gained through this new church, or are we going to bemoan and resent the three families we lost to it?" In other words, our attitude to new church development is a test of whether our mindset is geared to our own institutional turf, or to the overall health and prosperity of the kingdom of God in the city.

Any church that is more upset by their own small losses rather than the kingdoms large gains is betraying its narrow interests. Yet, as we have seen, the benefits of new church planting to older congregations is very great, even if that may not be obvious initially.

SUMMARY

If we briefly glance at the objections to church planting in the introduction, we can now see the false premises beneath the statements. **A.** Assumes that older congregations can reach newcomers as well as new congregations. But to reach new generations and people groups will require *both* renewed older churches and lots of new churches. **B.** Assumes that new congregations will only reach current active churchgoers. But new churches do far better at reaching the unchurched, and thus they are the only way to *increase* the 'churchgoing pie'. **C.** Assumes that new church planting will only discourage older churches. There is a prospect of this, but new churches for a variety of ways, are one of the best ways to renew and revitalize older churches. **D.** Assumes that new churches only work where the population is growing. Actually, they reach people wherever the population is *changing.* If new people are coming in to replace former residents, or new groups of people are coming in--even though the net pop figure is stagnant--new churches are needed.

New church planting is the only way that we can be sure we are going to increase the number of believers in a city and one of the best ways to renew the whole Body of Christ. The evidence for this statement is strong--Biblically, sociologically, and historically. In the end, a lack of kingdom-mindedness may simply blind us to all this evidence. We must beware of that.

APPENDIX A-
HISTORICAL LESSONS

If all this is true, there should be lots of evidence for these principles in church history--and there is.

In 1820, there was one Christian church for every 875 U.S. residents. But from 1860-1906, U.S. Protestant churches planted one new church for increase of 350 in the population, bringing the ratio by the start of WWI to just 1 church for every 430 persons. In 1906 over a third of all the congregations in the country were less than 25 years old.[4] As a result, the percentage of the U.S. population involved in the life of the church rose steadily. For example, in 1776, 17% of the U.S. population was 'religious adherents', but that rose to 53% by 1916.[5]

However, after WWI, especially among mainline Protestants, church planting plummeted, for a variety of reasons. One of the main reasons was the issue of 'turf'. Once the continental U.S. was covered by towns and settlements and churches and church buildings in each one, there was strong resistance from older churches to any new churches being planted in 'our neighborhood'. As we have seen above, new churches are commonly very effective at reaching new people and growing for its first couple of decades. But the vast majority of U.S. congregations reaches their peak in size during the first two or three decades of their existence and then remain on a plateau or slowly shrink.[6] This is due to the factors mentioned above. They cannot assimilate well new people or groups of people as well as new churches. However, older churches have feared the competition from new churches. Mainline church congregations, with their centralized government, were the most effective in blocking new church development in their towns. As a result, however, the mainline churches have shrunk remarkably in the last 20-30 years.[7]

What are the historical lessons? Church attendance and adherence overall in the United States is in decline and decreasing. This cannot be reversed in any other way than in the way it originally had been so remarkably *increasing.* We must plant churches at such a rate that the number of churches per 1,000 population begins to grow again, rather than decline, as it has since WWI.

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[4] *Ibid*, pp.14-26.
[5] Roger Finke and Rodney Stark, *The Churching of America 1776-1990* (New Brunswick: Rutgers, 1992) p.16.
[6] Schaller, *44 Questions*, p.23.
[7] See Schaller's case that it is a lack of church planting that is one major cause of the decline of mainline Protestantism. *Ibid*, p.24-26. Finke and Stark show how independent churches, such as the Baptists, who have had freedom to plant churches without interference, have proliferated their numbers. *Churching*, p.248.

Toward a Theology of City Church Planting

T.Keller

1. Biblical-Theological Origins of Church Planting

The Abrahamic dispersion

Probably the first church planter was Abraham. He was told by God to '*get out*' of his homeland.' So he was sent forth into a foreign land, becoming an exile or *stranger* in a foreign land (Heb 11:8-9.) There, however, he would meet God and worship and live in the presence of God (Gen 12:1-3.) God then called Abraham to make his family into a community of faith (Gen 17:1-16) through which some day God would save the world (Gen 12:3a.) Notice these three elements—**1)** going out into exile, **2)** worshipping there in the presence of God, and **3)** creating a cohesive faith-community.

The Babylonian dispersion

When God formed his people at Mount Sinai he created a central sanctuary—the tabernacle. The tabernacle (and later the temple) was the only place the people could meet to worship. It was the only sanctuary, the only place where God dwelled and could be approached. It was illegal to offer sacrifices to God at any other place. The priesthood, the liturgy, the sanctuary—all was in one place only.

The origins of the Jewish synagogue are uncertain, but many believe it began during the Babylonian captivity. Ezekiel had a vision of the glory-throne of God (his *shekinah* presence) with wheels (Ezekiel 10.) It was a vivid way for God to say that his presence was mobile and went with his people as they went into exile. According to tradition it was during the 70 year exile that Jews began establishing weekly gatherings for prayer, worship, and study. In other words, they were planting local congregations for the first time. There were two bases for their church planting. **1)** They had a demographical basis—namely, the dispersion of their people throughout the nations. **2)** They had a theological basis—namely, the mobile glory of God (the chariot-throne of Ezekiel's visions.) **3)** Facing these realities, the Jews learned how to form themselves into specific, cohesive faith-communities. Sometime in these years the concept of the *minyan* was developed; it was required that there be 10 males meeting in the group before it was legal for them to begin holding services and become a congregation.

When the exile was over and the Second Temple built, there was no longer any official support for the planting of congregations. The temple was rebuilt and the central cultus re-established, but the tradition is that many Jews never returned to Palestine and continued to worship in local congregations. However, after the destruction of the Temple in 70 AD, the now-developed skills of congregation-planting became the primary means by which Judaism survived and thrived for the next 2,000 years.

The Christian dispersion

When the Christian church was established it immediately had same demographic and theological bases for church planting that the Jews in exile had, only much more so. **1)** First, God began the church not as a nation state but as a movement that would spread through all nations (Matt 28:19.) In Acts 2 the first sermon and worship service of the Church after the descent of the Spirit was in the tongues of all nations. Thus no one human culture or language was more fundamental or sacred to the people of God than any other. This meant the church was *in dispersion in principle,* by it's very nature. Dispersion to the church is not a temporary anomaly nor as a judgment by God as it was for the Jews. Thus Peter and James can refer to all Christians, even Gentile ones, as 'the dispersion' or 'the exiles' (1 Peter 1:1; James 1:1.) **2)** Second, the New Testament gives us a far more powerful theological basis for belief in 'the mobile glory of God' than just a cryptic vision. In Jesus Christ, God has 'tabernacled among us' and shown us 'his glory' (John 1:14ff.) Thus the centralized sanctuary is obsolete. Jesus is now our Temple (John 2:19,) our Priest (Heb 4:14ff,) our Sacrifice (Hebrews 9-10.) And since Jesus indwells his people, then both corporately (1 Peter 2:5) and individually (1 Cor 6:19) *we* are temples of the Holy Spirit and *we* are all priests (1 Peter 2:5,9.) When we are gathered in his name he is in our midst (Matt 18:20.)

3) These two ingredients, with all their intense potencies, should have propelled the first Christians out into the world to form cohesive faith-communities. In other words, church planting should have begun immediately. But the early chapters of the book of Acts shows us that the earliest Christians did not at first grasp that they were a dispersion among the nations. They struggled with the idea that Gentiles could be full Christian believers and brethren. They saw themselves as mainly a Jewish movement and they did not leave Jerusalem to plant new churches. Instead they simply built up the central Jerusalem church to be larger and larger. As many commentators have pointed out, God had to forcibly expel them from Jerusalem through persecution before the Christians began to actually become *"scattered"* i.e. a church-planting dispersion. Acts 8:1-4 tells us that virtually everyone but the apostles were scattered out from Jerusalem, and *"those who had been scattered preached the word wherever they went."* It is only after this that we have cross-cultural conversions and church-planting in earnest.

Conclusions: 1) First, ***church planting requires a theology of exile.*** The 'Christendom' model of the church, in which the church is seen as the chaplain of society—does not lead to much church planting. This is the traditional 'mainline' mindset, but it can also be found in conservative churches. The 'Christendom' mindset celebrates and identifies too deeply with one particular human culture. Church members do not think of themselves as strangers but as proprietors of the culture. A theology of exile on the other hand perceives the church as both a prophetic and priestly counter-culture in every society. Christians love their home-city and society yet they sense a stronger connection with Christians of all other nations than with non-believers of their own human racial group. The Christendom mindset prizes established institutions and tradition and scorns new congregations meeting in rented facilities to 'not really be a church.' It also tends to scorn immigrants and new-comers from other cultures, while the theology of exile shows an equal concern for all peoples. **2)** Second, ***church planting requires a 'redemptive-historical' reading of Scripture.*** The 'Redemptive-Historical' method (RHM) reads the Bible "diachronically" rather than just "synchronically". It sees the Bible not just as a depository of individual pieces of data that must be summarized but also a history of how God is saving the world in stages--a redemption-history. In this view, the Bible is not just 'God-Sin-Christ-Faith' but 'Creation-Fall-Redemption-Restoration.' The whole Bible is seen as one big (true) story with a central plot-line: God restores the world lost in Eden by intervening in history to call out and form a new humanity. One major implication of this way of reading the Bible is that 'missions' is not just a department of life and the church. Rather the whole Bible is mainly about the mission of God. Mission is what God is all about, what life is all about. Sending out—dispersing—is the essence of the Christian life, not something only for experts. **3)**Third, ***church planting requires a wake-up call from God.*** I guess we should not be surprised that relatively few churches understand the cruciality of new church planting. Despite the fact that God created the church in dispersion, to penetrate every people and nation and neighborhood, and despite the fact that his presence exists not just in established buildings and institutions but everywhere his name is confessed—look what it takes to get the people of God off dead center. For Abraham it took a vision, for the Jews it took an invasion, for the Christians it took a bloody persecution!

2. Biblical Methods of Church Planting

Introduction

Church planting is mentioned many places in the New Testament. Paul refers to 'planting and watering' churches with Apollos 1 Cor 3:6-7. But the main place to go to learn about the methods of church planting is the book of Acts. And here we face an old problem—to what degree are the historical descriptions of the early church normative for church practice today? All orthodox Christians agree that *pre*scriptive statements of the Bible are normative for us, but the *de*scriptive histories of the Old and New Testament have both good examples and bad examples in them. Are we always sure which is which? The safest approach, I think, is to take the church planting practices of Paul in Acts very seriously, but to recognize that the Bible is not giving us an absolute rule-book for church-planting in all times, places, and contexts. Best to look for general principles, then, then extremely detailed practices.

The naturalness of church planting

In Acts--church planting is not a traumatic or unnatural event. It is not something odd or once-in-a lifetime, as it is with most churches. With the exception of the original persecution in Acts 8, it is not forced on people by circumstances. Church planting is woven into the warp and woof of things, it happens constantly, it happens normally. Paul never evangelizes and disciples without also church planting. For decades, expositors looked to Acts to find 'the basic elements of ministry'. They always made lists such as these: Bible teaching, evangelism, fellowship, discipleship, worship. Yet right there along with everything else is church planting, but it is often ignored. There's a very dubious, tacit 'cessationism' going on here! Implicitly, almost unconsciously, readers said, 'well, but that was for then--we don't do that now". But the principle is--*church planting must be natural and constant, not traumatic and episodic.*

The normal ministry of Paul had three phases, easily seen in Acts 14: **1)** First there evangelism**.** 21-*'they preached the good news';* but it does not use the word for preach, rather a more comprehensive word--they *evangelizdomenoi* 'gospeled' the city. There's a great deal more to that than simply preaching sermons. The book of Acts shows Paul spreading the gospel through preaching in synagogue services, sharing in small group Bible studies, speaking out in market-places or leading discussions in rented halls, or just talking to people one on one. **2)** Second, there is incorporation into community. In 14:21a – we see Paul goes to the converts to "*strengthen and encourage"* them. These are two verbs used together chapter 9, 15, 18, and John Stott calls them an almost technical term for building up new believers. How did Paul do it? He taught them "*the faith"* (v.22)-- a definite body of beliefs and theology. But also he congregated them. New believers do not simply go on living their lives as they were but they are led to assemble regularly and are brought into a community. **3)** Third, there is leadership development. They *appointed elders* each place. Paul chose elders, a plurality of leaders out of the converts, who now become the ones who teach and shepherd the people in the faith. Though we have to allow plenty of flexibility for different cultures (see below), the unavoidable principle is that he did not keep them under his direct authority or dependent on him. He made them *churches* in their own right--not just loose knit 'fellowships' directly under him. They had their own leadership, their own structure. When he began meeting with them they were *"disciples"* (v.22) but when he left them, they were *"churches"* (v.23). In summary, church multiplication is as natural in the book of Acts as individual convert multiplication.

The avenues of church planting

As Tim Chester points out in his essay "Church Planting: A Theological Perspective" (in *Multiplying Churches*, edited by Steve Timmis,) there were two basic launching models for churches in Acts. Basically, church planting was either initiated by pioneer individuals, or by church planting churches. **1)** In Paul and his companions, we see pioneer church planting. Though he was sent out by the Antioch church, and he was thus accountable for his doctrine and behavior (Acts 13:1ff.), his work in every city was pioneering work. He did ground-breaking evangelism in each place, without the cooperation or work of other churches. **2)** The other model is churches planting churches. It is implicit but is there in the New Testament if you don't screen it out by thinking anachronistically about the word 'church' when you see it in the text. The churches Paul planted (in fact all Christian churches for 200 yrs) were *house*hold churches. Example: Lydia's conversion immediately becomes bridge to conversion her household which then makes her home the first Philippi church. By v.40, they go to Lydia's home to meet the brethren. The same thing happens in Acts 18 with the household of Crispus. What did this mean? It means that the church at Philippi, Corinth, and everywhere else--very naturally could only grow by multiplying new assemblies or house churches. Though Paul writes to the "church" singular "at Corinth", it is obvious by the end of the book that he is addressing number of household churches--Chloe, Stephanus, etc. The point for us--Tim Chester says, because the household church basic building block, *church planting was built into the church's very nature.* You only grow by multiplying new assemblies of Christians who met for edification, evangelism, and praise.

In pioneering church planting:	In church church planting:
Minister/Leaders are often self-initiators; but a church can also call and send	Minister/leaders are selected by church body
No core members; pioneer gets all core networking and evangelism	Members come from a) pooling cell groups b) Hiving off distant families.
Money a) from mission agency, or b) raised pers support various friends and churches, c) or tent-making/self-employed or all above	a) core group pledge, b) support church subsidy, c) outside grants from distant churches or individuals--for a period of time
Mentor--distant pastor or leader, seen infreq Or reading-only mentor (dead or distant)	Regular meetings with coach who is nearby. Often peer supervision possible.
Model: Often more innovative, forging new models or imitating distant ones	Similar but seldom identical to mother church

Objections to natural church planting

There is a very common objection to reading the book of Acts the way we are doing it. It goes like this: *"That was then! Now, at least in N.America and Europe, we have churches all over the place. We don't need to start new churches, we should strengthen and fill the existing churches before we do that."* Here are some answers:

New churches are by far the best way to reach 1) new generations, 2) new residents, and 3) new people groups. Studies show that newer churches attract new groups about 6-10 times better and faster than older churches do. It is because when a church is new younger and newer people can get in to its leadership faster. It is because when a church is new it has no tradition and can experiment. It is because when a church is new its main goal each week is not to satisfy the desires of the long-time members (there are none!) but to reach new people. As a result new churches enormously better reaching new people to a city.

Our countries are filled with more new generations, new immigrants, and new residents than ever**.** Globalization and pluralization mean that communities and neighborhoods change rapidly. There are always new populations emerging or moving into towns and cities. If there is not a lot of church planting to reach them they will be lost. Older churches don't reach new groups as well. Today's diversity makes the traditional parish model pretty obsolete for mission. You can have many churches in virtually the same location, each reaching very different kinds of people.

New churches are perhaps the best way to renew older churches and enhance all ministries**.** The death of 'Christendom' in the West means now have something Acts not--lots of stagnant or dying churches. We need not only to plant new churches in order to replace many of them, but also to renew many of them. How so? **(1)** *New churches are the best single way to re-vitalize older congregations in the area.* The new churches help the overall Body of Christ by a) showcasing new ministry forms and ideas that would never have been adopted in older churches, b) creating an 'it *can* be done' mindset in older churches, c) providing many new converts in the city that find their way to older churches, d) supporting many new ministries that have city-wide benefits. Church planting helps an existing church the best when the new congregation is voluntarily 'birthed' by an older 'mother' congregation. The daughter church brings the mother church into contact with many new groups of people and pioneers new programs that the mother church may have been too traditional to try. Though there is some pain in seeing good friends and some leaders go away to form a new church, the mother church usually experiences a surge of high self-esteem and an influx of new enthusiastic leaders and members. Together the two churches usually see a major increase in numbers, joy, and confidence. **(2)** *New churches are the only ministries that become self-supporting and expand the base for all other ministries.* A city needs many ministries--youth work, schools, missions to new groups, and so on. Once they are begun, they need outside funding from

Christian givers indefinitely. A new church, however, only requires funding at its beginning. Within a few years, it becomes the *source* of Christian giving to other ministries, not the *object* of it. Because it brings in large numbers of unchurched people, church planting is by far the fastest way to grow the number of *new givers* in the kingdom work in a city.

Application of natural church planting

Basically, there are two ways churches get planted--unnatural and natural. Churches that are forced to do it, and those with a church-planting mindset, natural, normal part of its ministry.

Unnatural Church Planting (two varieties)

- Defiant church planting. Some people in the church get frustrated and split away and form a new church--because there is alienation over doctrine, or vision, or philosophy of ministry. Examples: 1) charismatic splits, 2) cultural splits--2nd generation leaders leave to do a church in opposition to the will of the 1st generation church, and so on.
- Reluctant church planting. Circumstances force the church leaders against their will to plant a new church. Examples: 1) They outgrow the building and don't want to move, 2) Some members move to new area and begin to lobby for a church "out here", 3) Some members with a different vision (younger, different worship, etc.) begin to drop out or push for a new service or church. Though leaders may give only begrudging permission or even money and active support, it is still 'unnatural' because church planting won't happen again perhaps ever--unless circumstances again dictate it.

Natural Church Planting

I mean a mindset just like in the book of Acts. That means that church leaders will think of church planting as just one of the things we do along with the rest--we do teaching, evangelism, discipling, worship and music, education, and church planting! Church planting should not be like building a building--one big traumatic hiccup and we are glad that's over with. Rather it is to have the mind set of Paul, who always did a) evangelism, b) discipleship, and c) church planting. This mind-set can be broken down into two sub-strata extremely important. If you can't muster these, you can't have a natural church planting mindset.

- First, the ability to give away and to lose control of money, members, and leaders.
  Hate to use a cliche, but its true--Paul "empowered" these new leaders. He gave them ownership, and thus he lost a lot of control. This is a huge barrier for churches. They cannot bear thought of money-giving families being lost, or key leaders, or just friends. Ministers are also afraid of giving away glory. If your ministry adds people and you: *1)* assimilate them into your church, *2)* turn them into Bible studies under your church, *3)* spin them into new 'ministries' in your church, it swells your numbers, and you get both control and glory. If you organize them into churches, you are losing money, members, numbers, leaders, and control. But that is just what Paul did. An additional problem--that when you let go, you lose direct control, but you can't really avoid responsibility for problems. It is like being the parent of an adult child. You are not allowed to directly tell them what to do, but if there's a problem, you are expected to help clean it up.
  Example: I know of an evangelical congregational church in our area which existed in a small, historic building. They had filled 100 seats twice to max for 4 years in a row. They resisted church planting, fearing loss of money and people. Finally they sent 50 out to new town to form a new church. Just two years later there were 350 coming to the daughter church. Meanwhile, the mother church filled its seats in about 3 weeks. Now they are kicking selves--by now they could have planted 3 churches with nearly 1,000 people in the church-family, able to do missions, youth ministry, and many other things together. They realize that they needed to make the transition from church-planting as hiccup to a church planting mindset.

- Second, the ability to give up some control of the shape of the ministry itself.
  This is scary especially to people who care about Biblical truth. But it's a simple fact that the new church will not look just like you. It will develop its own voice and emphases. On the one hand, pains must be taken to be sure that the difference is not too great, or fellowship and cooperation is

strained. Remember the book of Acts speaks of *"the faith".* There is one body of true doctrine at the heart of Christianity. But on the other hand, if you insist that the church be a clone of your own, if you are not willing to admit the reality of contextualization in the Biblical sense of adapting and incarnating--so different generations and cultures *will* produce a different kind of church--then you won't be able to do church planting!
Example: As see--Paul's adaptations from culture to culture are famous. No-one size fits all for him. And why Acts 16:13 did Paul *'expect'* to find a prayer meeting at the river? Would you? He knew something about God-fearers. Frankly, it takes creativity and wisdom about people to do church planting--and many leaders cannot think 'outside the box'.

- Third, the ability to care for the kingdom even more than for your tribe. We see this in the way Paul talks of Apollos, who, though not a disciple of his (Acts 18:24ff.) Paul speaks of in the warmest terms (1 Cor.3:6; 4:9; 16:12) even though his disciples evidently considered themselves a particular party (1 Cor1:12; 3:4) We see it in the way Paul (as said before) constantly takes his hands off new churches. 16:40--*then he left.* What we have here is a concern not for his own power or his party's power (and even then, different apostles had their followers and emphases), but for the kingdom as a whole.
  Test: When we "lose" 2 families to a church that brings in 100 new people who weren't going to any other church, we have a choice! We must ask ourselves: "Are we going to rejoice in the new people that the kingdom has gained through this new church, or are we going to bemoan and resent the two families we lost to it?" In other words, our attitude to new church development is a test of whether our mindset is geared to our own institutional turf, or to the overall health and prosperity of the kingdom of God in the city. Will we resent the 10 people we have lost or rejoice in the 80 people the kingdom has gained?

The church-planting mindset is not so much a matter of trusting new leaders etc. but trusting God. Paul does not give the new churches up to themselves or others. Rather he *"committed them to the Lord".*

The Importance of the City in Church Planting

Paul's City-centric Church Planting strategy
-Here we see that Paul is called to Macedonia, but to reach it he automatically chooses to go to the largest city of a region (v.16). The apostle consistently targeted the largest city of a region and did extensive urban church planting and then left the region. Why?

- ***Cultural cruciality***. In the village, you might win the one or two lawyers to Christ, but if you wanted to win the legal *profession*, you need to go to the city where you have the law schools, the law journals published, etc. People who live in the large urban cultural centers, occupying the jobs in the arts, business, academia, publishing, the helping professions, and the media tend to have a disproportionate impact on how things are done in a culture. The people groups that live in the center cities in the greatest numbers tend to see their 'values' expressed in the culture.
- ***Global cruciality.*** In the village, you can win only the single people group that is there, but if you want to spread the gospel into 10-20 new national groups/and languages at once, you go to the city where they can all be reached through the one *lingua franca* of the place. The cities of the Greco-Roman world were 'globalized.' They were the seats of vast international networks. Each city had a significant community from some other part of the world which maintained its connections to its part of the world.
- ***Personal cruciality.*** In the village little changes and people live in very stable environments. Thus they are suspicious of any major change. Because of the diversity and intensity of the cities, urbanites are much more open to radically new ideas--like the gospel! Because they are surrounded by so many people *like* and *un*like themselves, and so much more mobile and subject to change, urbanites are far more open to change/conversion than any other kind of resident.

Because of Paul's city-centric church planting strategy, by year 300 AD, 50% of the urban populations of the Roman empire were Christian, while over 90% of the countryside was still pagan. (Note: Some

believe that the very word "pagan" comes from the Greek *paganus* meaning a farmer or man of the country.) Because Christianity captured the cities, it eventually captured the society, as must always be the case. What captivates the cities also captivates the art, media, scholarship and the professions. Cities are the "culture forming wombs" of the society, made by God to be so.

Our urbanized, globalized world today

Our world today is even more urbanized and globalized than the world of ancient Rome. In 1950 New York was the only world city with a population of over 10 million people. Today, however, there are over 20 such cities, twelve of which have arrived in the last two decades, with many more to come. All of these new giant mega-cities are developing in what used to be called the "Third World". The millions of newcomers to burgeoning cities have characteristics that make them far more open to Christianity than they were before arriving. First, they are more open to new ideas and change in general, having been uprooted from traditional settings. Second, they have great need for help and support in order to face the moral, economic, emotional, and spiritual pressures of city life.

Cities are even more globally connected to each other today than they were during the glory of Rome. Major world cities are far more connected to other major cities around the world than they are to their own nations. On the one hand, the "business-class" and other elites of New York, London, and Tokyo are able to identify more with one another than with the non-urban citizens of their own countries. But the strong connections between major cities are not only through the 'elites'. Huge, diverse immigrant populations in global cities tie each urban area more tightly to scores of other countries around the world than to its own regional locale. In other words, NYC is as connected to the Philippines, Haiti, Columbia, China, and Nigeria as it is to New Jersey or Connecticut. Second, these networked world-cities are becoming more economically and culturally powerful than the national governments of their geographical regions. Why is this? 1) The mobility of capital means national governments are now virtually powerless to control the flow of money in and out of their own economies, thus greatly decreasing their influence in general. The cities are the seats of multi-national corporations and international economic, social, technological networks. 2) The technology/ communication revolution means that national governments are powerless also to control what their people watch or learn. As a result, it is the culture/values set of world-class cities that is now being transmitted around the globe to every tongue, tribe, people, and nation. A major city like New York or Los Angeles now is far more influential in forming the culture of residents in, say, rural Indiana or rural Mexico than are the national or local governments or civic institutions. We now have the overall major erosion of nation-state power in 800 years.

Harvie Conn concludes that we are witnessing again the rise of the 'City-State". He says: *"Great metropolitan regions...not states, not even the nation-states--are starting to emerge as the world's most influential players."* Thus world-class cities are increasingly crucial to setting the course of culture and life as a whole, even in the areas of the world (Europe and North America) where cites are not literally growing in size. Urban culture reaches far beyond the city limits into the suburbs and even rural areas. Kids in Iowa or even Mexico are becoming more like young adults in L.A. and New York City than they are like adults in their own locales. The coming world 'order' will be a global, multi-cultural, urban order.

Sum: We must reach the city to reach the world. We must reach the city to reach the culture. City church-planting is the key to both.

A Statement of Mission-Intent

Here is a statement of mission intent for those individuals and churches who want to be guided by the theological vision for church planting outlined above.

1. Who are we?

- We believe that the great cities are the key to global culture, and the central city is the key to each metroplex.

- We believe that a key to reaching our society is for Christians to live in numbers in the city--not despising it, seeking control of it, nor fully assimilating to it--but loving it and seeking its flourishing.
- We are deeply burdened by the fact that, though the peoples who live in city-centers are disproportionately important to the course of life in the world, no Christian movement is reaching them on any kind of scale, in the US or abroad.

2. What are our aspirations?

- We want to build a movement of new churches and ministries in the new global city-centers of the world, where there are currently no such movements.
- We want to propagate a model of gospel ministry which, though it must be contextualized to each culture and city, provides a unique blend of balances and range of practices that effectively relate the gospel to culture.
- We want to leverage the knowledge-bases and resources of the Redeemer NYC and its network so as to grow Christian communities in select global cities that reach the 'tipping point'—the city-shaping size and spiritual depth—by including 6-8% of the city-center population.

3. With whom do we want to do this?

- We want this to be a unified effort in multi-colors. In North America, we want our City-Center Gospel movement to consist of African-American-led, Anglo-led, Asian-led, and Hispanic-led multi-ethnic churches and ministries.
- We want to join hands across not just ethnic but denominational lines. To win our cities, we must begin and unite churches of many traditions, united around the gospel.
- We want to listen intently to and partner wherever possible with Christian leaders in every city and country where we work. We believe profoundly in the need for non-paternalistic, sensitive contextualization in every setting.
- We want to seek new and innovative means to forge transforming connections with the thought leaders and oppressed peoples of our culture, in order to ignite a passion for God in every venue of human endeavor. We yearn to work with all who seek the lordship of Christ over the whole of life with unabashed hope in the power of the Holy Spirit to transform individuals, communities and culture.
- In all these efforts we are determined to be people of prayer, depending on God to achieve what human striving cannot.

Conclusion: We have said that we must be careful not to read the book of Acts as a strict rule book for church planting. Yet we are facing a post-secular, urbanized, global world that is much like the Greco-Roman world. For the first time in 1500 years, there will be multiple, vital, religious faith communities and options in every society (including real paganism.) Traditional, secular, and pagan world-views and communities are living side by side. It means also that cities again will be as influential and central to culture as they were in the Graeco-Roman world. During the *pax Romana* cities also became furiously multi-ethnic and globally connected. The book of Acts has not been more relevant since Augustine. Since we live in the Acts-world again (rather than Christendom,) church planting will be as central a strategy for reaching our world as it was for reaching that older one.

Jesus himself is the ultimate church planter. He builds his church (Matt 16:18) and he does it effectively, because Hell itself will not prevail against it. He raises up leaders and gives them the keys to the kingdom (Matt 16:19.) He establishes his converts on the word of the confessing apostle, Peter, that is, on the Word of God (v.18.) When we plant the church, we are participating in his work, for if we have any success at all, it's because '*God made it grow.'* (1 Cor 3:6) *"So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything but only God, who makes things grow."* (v.7)

CONTEXTUALIZATION AND THEOLOGY
Tim Keller, April 2004

TWO BASIC 'THEOLOGICAL FRAMEWORKS'

WHAT IS THE BIBLE ALL ABOUT?

There are two basic approaches to answering the question: *"what is the Bible all about?"* One approach is the Systematic-Theological method (STM) which tends to deal with the Scripture topically. It organizes what the Bible says by asking: *"what does the whole Bible teach about God? sin? the Holy Spirit? the Church? marriage and family? Prayer?"* It looks at every text on a particular topic and then synthesizes them all into a set of statements or principles. Another approach is the 'Redemptive-Historical' method (RHM) which tends to deal with the Scripture historically. (It deals with the Bible "diachronically" rather than just "synchronically".) It sees the Bible less as a depository of individual pieces of data that must be summarized and more as a history of how God is saving the world in stages--a redemption-history.

There is no ultimate reason why these two approaches have to contradict! (Since the Bible is coherent does not contradict itself--you can always get an answer to the question- 'what does the Bible teach about topic-X?) Having said that the STM (carried out in isolation from the RHM) tends to produce a legalistic, individualistic, privatistic mindset that undermines the full Biblical understanding of mission. How?

The STM tends to see the Bible as a repository of dos and don'ts. Ask it 'what is the Bible all about?' the answer is 'about believing and practicing the right things.' But the RHM sees the Bible as mainly about God's saving activity in stages through history. If we ask the RHM--'what *is* the Bible all about?' the answer is--It is about the true story of how 1) God initiates a saving work that we cannot do for ourselves 2) in order to a) create a new people for himself out of lost humanity and b) a new creation out of a marred and broken world. To do this takes justice and power on God's part, but also love and mercy. Only in Jesus Christ is it ultimately revealed how God's holiness and love can work together for saving purposes. Only in Christ do we see how disparate parts of the human race can become one again--through his Body.

In other words, the gospel is--*GOD HAS ENTERED THE WORLD IN JESUS CHRIST TO ACHIEVE A SALVATION THAT WE COULD NOT ACHIEVE FOR OURSELVES AND THEREBY RENEW THE WHOLE WORLD.*

- This understanding of the good news is first of all ***grace*** **-centered**. The Bible is not primarily or just about how to live right. It is about grace and rescue. Jesus has come to live the life we should live but won't, and he has come to pay the penalty we owe for the life we do live but shouldn't. So we are not reconciled to God through our efforts and record (as in all other religions) but through his efforts and record.
- This understanding of the good news is also ***kingdom*** **-centered**. The Bible is not primarily about how the individual can escape this material world. Jesus is not ultimately only saving individual souls by removing them from the world, but rather he is bringing the life and power of God--the kingdom of God--down into the material world to eventually renew and restore it completely. (Rev 21-22; cf. Is 1:10-17, 11:1-10, 61:1-11) The kingdom of God broke in to the world partially with the death and resurrection of Christ (Luke 4:16-21.) Now the Spirit indwells the church (1 Peter 2:4-10) and is at work in the world through the gospel (John 16:8-10.) But eventually the kingdom and power of God will come fully (Rom 8:18-25.)

THE GOSPEL OF THE KINGDOM AND THE MISSION OF GOD

The implications of this view of the Bible's theme are quite enormous.

First, it means ***mission is primary in the church's and the Christian's life.*** Think! If the Bible is mainly about the mission of God, then "missions" cannot be just a department of ministry or one topic under the heading of Christian living. Mission is what God is all about, what life is all about. God sends his Spirit and his Son into the world to save it. Bringing God's love, peace, and justice to a broken world is what we all must live for.

Second, it means that ***mission includes not only evangelism but also seeking peace and justice in the city.*** The goal of salvation history is not simply a 'right relationship' with God and living in heaven forever, but rather the 're-creation' of the whole material world.

The STM approach to the Bible tends to see Christianity in completely individualistic terms. So from the STM perspective, the gospel is: "I sinned and turned from God but Christ has died so I can be forgiven and taken to heaven." (Sin-Cross-Faith-Heaven) From the RHM perspective, the gospel is: "God created the world to be a paradise, but when we turned from him the whole world fell into brokenness, but through Christ God has redeemed the world and will some day restore it completely." (Creation-Fall-Redemption-Restoration)

If the goal of salvation is not just individual renewal but creation renewal, then we do not (in our mission) only call individuals to conversion (though we certainly do that!) but also embody the gospel through sacrificial service for the common good, to those in need, and to the poor. God's kingdom will eventually overcome hunger, poverty, and injustice. Those of us who are agents of that kingdom must seek to do the same. Grace-centeredness leads us to love the city, not despise it. Kingdom-mindedness leads citizens of the 'city of God' to be very *best* citizens of their earthly city.

Third, it means that ***mission is through counter-cultural communities of Christians.*** Without an understanding of the gospel of the kingdom the church is seen mainly as a supportive place of inspiration and fellowship. But if we understand the gospel of the kingdom, the church becomes not just an aggregation of people who help one another find God, but a sign in this present age of the coming new creation. We are to embody the 'new humanity' that Christ is creating as a counter-culture where money, sex, power, race-relations, business-practices, and art are used in distinctive, life-giving, non-idolatrous ways. While the STM approach points us more to how we as individuals get peace with God and 'live right', the RHM framework calls us to live our lives out as a 'counter-culture', a new nation.

Fourth, it means that ***mission includes our secular vocations, not just church ministry.*** Most American Christians 'seal off' their faith-beliefs from the way they work in their vocation. They see *real* 'Christian service' as going in to full-time Christian work. Why?

- Without a 'grace-orientation' a legalistic Christianity is much more likely to see the secular world as a 'polluted' place to flee from. When you don't grasp the gospel of grace, you tend toward a Pharisaical obsession with 'ritual purity' or 'cleanness.' Since we are saved by the purity and rightness of our lives, it encourages people to stay very much within the church where we don't have to deal with unbelievers.
- Without a 'kingdom-orientation' the gospel is seen as a means of finding individual peace and *not* as a 'world-view'-- a comprehensive interpretation of reality that effects all we do. But the gospel has a deep and vital impact on how we do art, business, government, media, and scholarship. Therefore Redeemer is highly committed to support Christians' engagement with culture, helping them work with excellence, distinctiveness, and accountability in their professions and in 'secular work.' Developing humane yet creative and excellent business environments out of our understanding of the gospel can be part of the work of restoring creation in the power of the Spirit. Bringing Christian joy, hope, and truth to embodiment in the arts is also part of this work.

Fifth, it means that ***we are actually <u>in</u> the Biblical story of redemption still.*** The STM approach tends to think of Biblical truth in a-historical categories of doctrine which we now have to "apply" to our lives today. But the RHM approach--of Creation-Fall-Redemption-Restoration-- puts us right into the very story-line. The RHM tells that we are now *in* a particular period of redemptive history (between the first and second coming of Christ). This is the period of the *"already-but-not-yet"* of the kingdom of God, which sets us apart from the epoch previous to and following this one.

The massive importance of the 'already-but-not-yet-kingdom' for both faith and practice is largely missed by those steeped in the STM approach. Christ as died, risen, and ascended has put us in a *particular*, *current, dynamic* relationship to God, our sin, our past, the Spirit, the world, and to the assembly of heaven itself. It tells us about this new relationship and status we have now, and how to live it out as the people of God in this entire epoch.

John Stott, in a very interesting and easy-to-understand chapter called "The Now and the Not Yet" in <u>*The Contemporary Christian*</u> (IVP, 1992) shows what a powerful effect this theological understanding of the present-but-still-future kingdom has on our practice. This understanding of our place in redemptive history keeps us from fundamentalism (the "not yet Christians"), Pentecostalism (the "already" Christians), and Liberalism (in some ways too "not yet" and in other ways too "already"). It keeps us from over -or under-discipline, from over- or under-emphasis on evangelism or social concern, from over-optimism or under-optimism about revival, and so on. A-historical (STM) understandings of the Bible lead constantly to these extremes. By the way, Jonathan Edwards noted these same three enemies of true revival--Dead orthodoxy, Enthusiasm, and Heterodoxy.

THEOLOGICAL FRAMEWORKS COMPARED

a. The RHM gives us a dynamic view of our place in redemptive history. The RHM tells that we are now *in* a particular period of redemptive history (between the first and second coming of Christ). This is the period of the *"already-but-not-yet"* of the kingdom of God, which sets us apart from the epoch previous to and following this one. The STM model has little concept of the all-pervasiveness of the kingdom of God. It tends to see the kingdom mainly in terms of one of the traditional 'millennial' positions.

The massive importance of the 'already-but-not-yet-kingdom' for both faith and practice is largely missed by those steeped in the STM approach. It tends to think of Biblical truth in a-historical categories of doctrine which we now have to "apply" to our lives today. It tends to rely mainly on "correctness" or technique ("5 principles for overcoming worry"). The RHM avoids over optimism or pessimism or legalism by focusing always on the dynamic kingdom-epoch lifestyle we live out now. The City of God *and* the City of Man are present realities. Christ as died, risen, and ascended has put us in a *particular*, *current, dynamic* relationship to God, our sin, our past, the Spirit, the world, and to the assembly of heaven itself. It tells us about this new relationship and status we have now, and how to live it out as the people of God in this entire epoch. This is a far more "organic" way to think out Christianity.

John Stott, in a very interesting and easy-to-understand chapter called "The Now and the Not Yet" in <u>*The Contemporary Christian*</u> (IVP, 1992) shows what a powerful effect this theological category has on our practice. This understanding of our place in redemptive history keeps us from fundamentalism (the "not yet Christians"), Pentecostalism (the "already" Christians), and Liberalism (in some ways too "not yet" and in other ways too "already"). It keeps us from over - or under-discipline, from over- or under-emphasis on evangelism or social concern, from over-optimism or under-optimism about revival, and so on. A-historical (STM) understandings of the Bible lead constantly to these extremes. By the way, Jonathan Edwards noted these same three enemies of true revival--Dead orthodoxy, Enthusiasm, and Heterodoxy.

b. The RHM gives us a more Biblical and less "western" framework. Harvie Conn in *Eternal Word and Changing Worlds* (Zondervan, 1984) points out that the highly rational, scientific approach of STM is difficult for people of non-Western cultures to enjoy or grasp. Many are now pointing out that many of the formulators of STM were unwittingly shaped and affected by the Enlightenment, its detached rationality and its mistrust of history. Harvie notes that the RHM gives much more weight to the fact that the Bible is filled with narrative. The gospel itself *is* a true story, not a set of "principles" or "laws". The STM approach has 'de-storied' the gospel. Harvie also points out that RHM understands that all God's truth is covenantal truth, never abstract from history and life. (See pp.225-234). Thus preaching and teaching from the RHM tends to be much less pietistic and abstract from life. All of this means that RHM is a vastly better vehicle for spreading the gospel through and to all people groups.

c. The RHM gives us a more corporate and less individualistic approach to ministry. The RHM understands that the goal of salvation history is not simply a 'right relationship' with God and live in heaven forever. The goal of redemption is really 're-creation'. God's saving purposes culminate in a new creation, not a disembodied eternal state. The gospel is not that we get to escape earth into heaven, but that heaven is "comes down" to transform the earth. The church, then, is not simply an aggregation of people who help one another find God, but it is called to be in this world a sign of the coming new creation. We are to embody the 'new humanity' that Christ is creating.

All of this drastically undermines the pietistic, individualistic, privatistic Christianity that can be the result of the STM approach. While the STM approach points us more to how we as individuals get peace with God and 'live right', the RHM framework calls us to live our lives out as a 'counter-culture', a new nation, in which our business practices, race relations, artistic expressions, family life, etc., show the world what humanity could be like under the Lordship of Christ. And the RHM emphasis on 'new creation' calls us to be concerned for the social and material world, since God's ultimate salvation will not only redeem the soul but the body and the physical world as well.

d. The RHM gives a much more relevant approach to 'post-modern' times. This point is closely connected to the previous one. "Post-modern" times are characterized by a rejection of the Enlightenment worship of rationality and technique, and is much more devoted to narrative and story as ways to find meaning. Also, post-modernity rejects the Enlightenment's emphasis on the individual and stresses the importance of community. As we have just seen, the RHM shows us all those resources in Biblical theology that the STM approach has tended to overlook. It breaks the Bible into stages of a Story--the story of Jesus and his salvation--while the STM breaks the Bible into logical categories. More than that, the RHM actually puts us *into* the story, showing us our place and stage in the unfolding of the kingdom of God. The RHM approach also shows concern for the regeneration of human community and even the physical environment, not just individual, interior happiness. In all these ways, RHM is much more relevant to post-modern sensibilities.

e. The RHM gives us a more Christ-centered understanding of the Bible. The RHM sees the purpose of each epoch of redemptive history as being the progressive revealing of Christ. God could have poured our judgment on mankind in the Garden, therefore the only reason there is any history is because God has purposed to send his Son into the world, to pour out judgment on him and thereby bring salvation. Jesus is the only reason there is human history, and therefore he is goal of human history. Thus everything God says and does in history explain and prepare for the salvation of his Son. The STM, on the other hand, will examine the Law, the prophets, and history of Abraham, Moses, David, etc. for information about the various doctrinal topics--what we learn about how to live, what to believe. But the RHM sees every story and law and piece of wisdom literature as pointing to Christ and his work. Preaching and teaching from an STM framework tends to be much more moralistic and legalistic.

f. The RHM gives us a more organic way of reading Biblical texts. The RHM works at understanding the differences between stages in redemptive history, while the STM largely ignores such study. But many disputes over the application of the Old Testament laws are really based on a lack of understanding of the role which the Mosaic regulations played in that time in redemptive history (i.e. how they helped us look to and prepare for God's coming salvation) and of how that role is fulfilled in Christ.

Maybe even more fundamentally, the RHM really leads us to see the very purpose of each Biblical passage differently. We have said that RHM understands God's revelation never comes in the form of textbook type information, but in the form of covenant. Why? Because the purpose of God's truth is never to merely inform, but to know God in a relationship of love and service. For example, if we read Genesis 1-2 with an STM mind-set, expecting "naked information" about how the world was created, we will see it differently than those who read with a RHM mind-set, expecting knowledge of who are Creator is and how we are to relate to him and to his creation.

Concluding Note: Do not read the above as pitting Systematic Theology *per se* against 'Biblical Theology'. There have been many proponents of the Redemptive-Historical approach that virtually deny the ability to do coherent Systematics at all. This is going too far by far, and such a denial ultimately undermines the concept of a single divine author of the whole Bible.

CONTEXTUALIZATION AND CULTURE

I. NATURE OF CULTURE - some concepts

A. What is culture?

1. "The shaping of the natural environment...."
Culture creates a *'secondary environment'* with the raw material of nature (nature itself being the 'primary environment'). It includes language, habits, ideas, beliefs, customs, social organization, technical processes, etc. When we compose and play a piece of music on a flute we are taking the natural primary elements (the metal of the flute; the sound in the air) and shaping it into something else. *"A river is nature, a canal culture; a raw quartz is nature, an arrowhead culture; a moan is nature, a word culture."* (H.Richard Niebuhr, Christ and Culture, 32)

2. ....in the service of something."
Culture creates this environment to bring the natural order into the service of certain core *"commanding truths"*. Every culture assumes an answer to the big questions--'why are we here? what are (therefore) the most important things in life? what is wrong with the world? what will put things right?' No culture is neutral on these matters, and all cultural work is covenantal--done with a view to bring nature into the service of something valued as ultimate. *"Culture...is any and all human effort and labor expended on the cosmos, to unearth its treasures and riches and bring them into...service...to something."* (H. Van Til, The Calvinistic Concept of Culture 32, 33).

> *"Every self exists in relation to values perceived as making life worth living. A value is anything good in the created order--any idea, relation, object or person in which one has an interest, from which one derives significance....These values compete....In time one is prone to choose a center of value by which other values are judged. When a finite value has been elevated to centrality and imagined as a final source of meaning, then one has chosen...a god ...that than which nothing more valuable can be conceived. "* (Thomas

Oden, Two Worlds: Notes on the Death of Modernity in America and Russia, p. 61)

> *"Culture is...a normative order by which we comprehend ourselves, others, and the larger world and through which we order our experience. At the heart of culture is a system of norms and values...but these norms and values are better understood as commanding truths so deeply embedded in our consciousness and in the habits of our lives that to question them is to question reality itself."* (James D.Hunter, Before the Shooting Begins, p. 200)

This view of culture sees culture itself (and thus each particular culture) as essentially religious at its core. Culture is the creation of a secondary environment in the service of ultimate concerns. Culture thus arises out of the only ultimate human "need"--to worship something--and out of our capacity as image-bearers to take dominion over nature to bring into the service of that which we worship. ("*Worshiped and served created things, rather than the Creator*" Rom.1:25)

B. The 'mixed nature' of culture.
All cultures are 'mixed'--that is all cultures are complex and they interweave godly and ungodly elements together very closely.

1. Cultures are mixed because a) all human beings are both radically fallen yet made in the image and likeness of God, and because b) of varying degrees of natural and special revelation that may be present within them. Even in cultures where the Bible is influential, the depravity of human nature creates idols which reign within. And on the other hand, cultures with little or no influence from the Bible may still (depending on the level of God's common grace) contain many strong elements, for God gives people a knowledge of moral truth in their consciences (Romans 2).

Therefore, every culture to some degree will reflect the knowledge of God that every person possesses, even if it is suppressed (Romans 1). Yet every culture to some degree will be distorted by sin, namely the elevation of finite values to the position of the absolute (idolatry). Therefore we can't evaluate simply evaluate more traditional, conservative cultures as being more 'Biblical' and liberal, secular cultures as being more immoral and evil. Conservative cultures often elevate the family or one's race to an absolute value--leading to the idolatries of racism, tribalism, patriarchy and other forms of moralism and oppression. Liberal cultures elevate the individual and human freedom to an absolute value--leading to the erosion of family, community, of integrity in both business and sexual practices. Yet the both the importance of the family *and* the worth and freedom of the individual are rooted in a Biblical world-view. So both the 'collectivist' traditional culture and the 'individualist' liberal culture are mixtures of darkness and light.

2. This is quite important for Christians to realize. Christians' reaction to culture is too simplistic and doesn't do analysis that goes beneath the behavioral level. They simply see contemporary culture as 'bad' and the more traditional U.S. culture of the early 20th century as better. But--

a. First, this comes from a theologically 'thin' view of sin, which sees sin as a series of discrete acts of non-compliance to God's regulations. Christian growth is seen mainly as seeking environments where you are less likely to do these sinful actions. Sin is something that can be essentially removed from the person. (This view of sin comports with a lack of understanding of the thoroughness and richness of Christ's gracious work for us. If we have to earn our salvation, we need a view of sin that is easier to deal with by conscious effort.) But a theologically 'thick' view of sin sees it as a compulsive drive of the heart to produce or discover idols.

If we have a 'thin' view of sin, we will remove from our view anything that could tempt us to do overt actions of sexual immorality, profanity, violence. By withdrawing such cultural 'texts' from our view we may feel less sinful, but that is not the case. the complex organic nature of our sin will still be at work making idols out of things that are not overt forms of law-breaking--like our moral goodness, or financial security, or our family, or doctrinal purity, or pride in our own traditional culture, and so on. In fact, too much emphasis on 'withdrawal' makes the likelihood of slipping into 'respectable' idolatries greater.

If, instead, we have the 'thick' view of sin--as idolatry that pervades all we do--should lead not to withdrawal or to uncritical consumption, but rather to 'humble, critical engagement.' We should identify cultural idolatries in popular culture as ways of repenting for the seeds of the same in our own hearts and avoiding them. (There is certainly room for specific withdrawal form some texts of popular--or 'high'!--culture, especially when we are younger. We are talking here of blanket withdrawal or uncritical consumption.

b. Second, this comes from a theologically 'thin' view of "common grace" or what is sometimes called 'general' or 'natural' revelation. As we noted above, Christians have long recognized that all people have 'knowledge' of God that they suppress, according to Romans 1-2. But many conceive of this knowledge mainly (or strictly) as cognitive information that can be retrieved somehow as we argue with people about the existence of God, the truth of Christianity, and so on. In other words, innate *knowledge of God* is thought of in intellectualistic terms.

But the language of Rom 1:18-25 gives us a much more comprehensive and dynamic picture of how 'general revelation' or 'common grace' works in lives. The *'truth'* is being *'suppressed'* (v.18) but it continues to bear down on us. The NIV translation of verse 20: *"Since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities...have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so men are without excuse."* But the verbs *nosumena* ("are being understood") and *kathopatai* ("are being seen") are in the form of present passive participles. That is, the reality of God's nature and our obligations to him are continuously present to us. It should not be thought of as static, innate ideas or information, but as a continually fresh, insistent pressure on the consciousness of every human being. In short, every artifact of human culture is a response to God's general revelation (cf. Isaiah 28 above) but always marred by an idolatrous heart that doesn't want to acknowledge the total sovereignty of God (Rom 1:21.) So all cultural production of a dialogue between God's general revelational grace and the idolatrous nature of the human heart.

> *Loss of faith in a given religion does not by any means imply the eradication of the religious instinct. It merely means that the instinct, temporarily repressed, will seek an object elsewhere.* – R. C. Zaehner, Oxford University, 1959[1]

In short, every human being producing culture (and everyone is!) is in a deep 'dialogue' with the general revelation of God. Therefore human culture is an extremely complex mixture of brilliant truth, marred half-truths, and overt resistance to the truth. We should be willing to be very engaged with general human culture produced by non-Christians. Why?

- First, a 'thick' view of sin means that even overtly Christian-produced culture will always have some idolatrous discourse within it. When we become Christians we continue to have powerful amounts of remaining sin in us. We continually struggle with remaining idolatrous impulses. Our 'Christian-cultural production' will not be free from these.
- Second, a 'thick' view of grace means that even overtly non-Christian-produced culture will always have some witness to God's truth in it. Even the angry, overtly anti-God culture is to a degree a testimony to God's reality. Many of these have an air of desperation about them. They are vainly trying to 'put out' what they know in their hearts.

[1] Quoted as the epigraph in Turner, *Hungry for Heaven.*

So Christians are never as good as their 'right beliefs' should make them and non-Christians are never as bad as their 'wrong beliefs' should make them. In general, then, this means a stance of *critical enjoyment* of human culture. On the one hand it means to recognize the half-truths and to resist the idols. How do we do this? It means when you recognize a cultural artifact that is a blatant, overt (even angry) resistance to God's general revelation, there is no need to delve deeply into it or expose yourself to it repeatedly. On the other hand it means to recognize and celebrate the wide-spread expressions of justice, wisdom, truth, and beauty in any culture.

Conclusion: The view that all cultures are essentially religious could lead to an 'absolutist' view of culture. The response to the absolutist view is a more relativistic view:

"**Absolutist" view** - Cultural forms are either pure (because the commanding truths of that culture are based on good theology) or impure (because the commanding truths are based on bad theology). Therefore every cultural product can be evaluated as acceptable or un-acceptable.

"**Relativist" view** - Cultural forms are neutral and relative because the ultimate commanding truths of any culture are all relative and arbitrary. There is no absolute truth.

But the Biblical understanding of the gospel (Christians are saved but sinners) of the image of God (people are lost but indelibly reflect the nature of God) and of common grace (all people suppress the truth about God but they nonetheless 'hear' and 'know' it)--creates a much more nuanced understanding of culture. Cultures are mixed and each has valuable elements and demonic elements.

II. CONTEXTUALIZATION.

Sources Harvie Conn, *Eternal Word and Changing World* (Zondervan, 1984); "Contextualization: Where do we begin?" in *Evangelicals and Liberation,* ed C.Amerding (Presby and Reformed, 1977); "Contextual Theology" course syllabus and 20-tape set of lectures. Available from Westminster Media; and "Normativity, Relevance, and Relativity" in *Inerrancy and Hermeneutic,* ed. Harvie Conn (Baker, 1988) David J. Hesselgrave, *Communicating Christ Cross-culturally* (Zondervan, 1978) Charles Kraft, *Communication Theory for Christian Witness* (Abingdon, 1983); and *Anthropology for Christian Witness* (Orbis, 1996) Sherwood Lingenfelter, *Ministering Cross-Culturally* (Baker, 1986) with Marvin K. Mayers; and *Transforming Culture* (Baker, 1998.) John Stott and Robert Coote, eds. *Down to Earth: Studies in Christianity and Culture.* (Eerdmans, 1980.) See especially the Appendix: "The Willowbank Report"

A. The background of the debate on 'contextualization' (see Conn's works)

1. The early missionary attitude toward culture (18th to the early 19th century)
Despite the fact that the earliest European missionaries totally rejected the Enlightenment's skepticism and criticism of Christian doctrine, they were very influenced by the Enlightenment's view of culture.

- The Enlightenment enshrined human reason as the highest value of civilization. Societies that were not as reasonable (ie not as scientific, as rational, as analytical) were considered less evolved and therefore primitive. It was believed that each culture passed through stages of development--from the magical, to the religious, to science/reason as it became better and better in understanding and dealing with the natural world. (This has been called the 'developmentalist' view of culture.)
- This Enlightenment approach passed in to the Christian mission. Of course the missionaries did not see all religion as 'primitive'--they believed the Christian religion was true! But they still deeply imbibed the Enlightenment view that less technologically

advanced cultures were dark and evil because they were less scientific and more based on impulse, emotion, passion.

- So missions in new countries were dominated by Europeans/American leadership. It was widely believed that the natives were too primitive to lead their own churches. In general, it was expected that when 'natives' adopted Christian belief they would adopt European cultural practices as well. It was expected that as Christianity spread throughout the world, one world-culture (basically European) would result.
- During the early missionary era there is virtually no drawing on the theological resources of a) heart-idolatry as a way to critique one's own culture nor b) common grace as a way to appreciate other cultures and religions. The Enlightenment rather than Christian theology shapes the church's approach to culture.

2. The indigenous church movement (late 19th-to mid-20th century)

a. Two major factors led to a change in missions.

- One factor might be called 'common sense'! Despite their earlier prejudice against nationals as being more 'primitive' and unfit for leadership, missionaries increasingly (unavoidably!) came to see how much less effective western missionaries were in their evangelism and discipleship in comparison to the fruitfulness of indigenous preachers, teachers, and leaders. This led many to call for an "indigenous church"--one in which the leadership of the churches was turned over to non-Western indigenous people.
- The second factor, however, was the science of anthropology, which was just beginning at the time.
  - Instead of judging all cultures according to a standard like human rationality, cultural anthropologists saw each culture as a complex set of practices, beliefs, and customs that helped a people group and the individuals with in it adapt to its environment. This view was called *'functionalism.'* This understanding of culture did not perceive it as being fundamentally religious in character at all. Rather, this was a 'Darwinian' approach. Culture was seen as creating a 'secondary environment' (see above, part I.) but it was done simply in order to survive and thrive in the particular setting and environment in which a group of people found themselves. A culture was now studied to determine how it differed from other cultures and how functional it was meeting people's psychological and social needs.
  - The functionalist approach led cultures as a fairly mechanical, static entity. There was no acknowledgement of the more organic view that each culture is system based on some fundamental commanding beliefs and truths. Religion was just one part of the system by which the people group navigated their environment. It was believed, therefore, that a single component of culture could removed and another slipped into its place without changing the entire system fundamentally. Culture was a mish-mash--like a row of beads on a string or a set of keys on a ring. You could remove a couple of pieces and put others in their place without changing the whole.

b. These two factors led to the 'indigenous church movement.' Henry Venn and Rufus Anderson in the early 19th century John Nevius and Roland Allen in the late 19th and early 20th were it's leaders.

- The most famous formulation of the indigenous church movement the "Three-Self" formula. Every church on every mission field should be moved toward the goal of being: a) self-supporting, b) self-governing, c) and self-propagating.
  - This was a good thing! Rufus Anderson in India shifted the emphasis of mission from 'civilizing' enterprises like liberal arts education and English language study to church planting.
  - National churches were given over to indigenous leaders and it was expected that they would develop their own music, leadership structures, and so on. So

instead of making Indian churches use European hymn music, they would not be expected to sing praises using indigenous Indian music.

- But the indigenous church movement had several inherent problems. Just as the earlier missionary movement relied unwittingly on the older view of culture put forth by European scholars, now the this movement seems to have been influenced by functionalism, the newer scholarly view of culture.
- As we said, functionalism saw culture in mechanistic terms. It believed you could replace Hindu religion with Christian religion and leave much or most of the rest of the culture intact. (That is, it was thought you could slip the Hindu bead off the string and slip the Christian bead on--and leave pretty much all the other beads intact.) So the new Indian Christian could simply use the rest of Indian culture to organize his church, do worship arts, and so on.

c. But what if *both* the 'developmentalist' and the 'functionalist' views of culture are too simplistic? What if religion is not one slice among many cultural customs, but the dynamic heart beneath of *all* the patterns of a particular culture? (What if we assume the view of culture in part I. above?) If that is the case,

- On the one hand if you replace Hinduism with Christianity it would also change the music. It would change the Indian way to do leadership and to view authority. It would change *every*thing in the culture to some degree. But
- On the other hand the new Indian Christian culture would *not* be identical to the European Christian culture. Because European Christian culture (as we saw above) was not 'pure'. Pre-Christian European culture had its own set of general-revelation truths in it on which Christian Europeans built. Pre-Christian Indian culture would have a different set of general-revelation truths than the Europeans had. (And, unfortunately, European idols--still distorting the European Christian culture--would be different than the Indian idols that would distort Indian Christian culture.) In summary--Indian Christian culture would be quite different from both European Christian culture and non-Christian Indian culture.

d. As a result of this static view of culture, two fairly big problems developed in the "indigenous church movement."

- First, the indigenous church movement did not encourage *national* leaders to do deep theological 'reflection' on how the gospel changes everything in their culture.
  - The older missionary attitude (based on 'developmentalism') was too simplistically positive toward White European culture. But the newer missionary attitude (based on 'functionalism') was too simplistically positive toward the indigenous culture. It didn't see the kind of deep changes that would be necessary if Christianity came into the non-Christian culture. It too uncritically just adopted indigenous culture whole-sale.
  - For example, indigenous Korean churches simply lifted wholesale the extremely authoritarian understanding of leadership (rooted in it Confucian past and Korea's history of being oppressed by China and Japan) and laid it down in the new Christian churches. Many of the world's churches now have brought patterns from their own culture into their practices un-processed by the gospel.
  - The functionalist approach to culture fit in well with the pietistic impulse of so much of European Christianity. Pietism focuses on the inner individual experience, and does not expect or ask how the experience of salvation will change the way we use our money, do our work, perform our art, etc. In the indigenous church movement personal salvation is offered without much thought to how Christianity would completely change a people's attitude toward power and powerlessness, art, literature, cultural ritual and symbolism. *"The Christian faith is consigned to the realm of mind and spirit rather than to the broad stream of the history of society and civilization."* (Conn)

- Second, on the other hand, the indigenous church movement did not encourage the *missionaries* to recognize the culturally adapted nature of their <u>own</u> theology and practices.
    - The indigenous church movement was a 'one-way' translation. Europeans and Americans saw their own Christianity in universal terms. Their theology (they thought) was not colored at all by their own cultural biases. So 'indigenization' was a process by which the structure of the church (leadership, music, etc) was perhaps *over*-adapted to the host culture, while the actual message of the gospel and theology was *under*-adapted to the host culture. The nationals were encouraged to simply adopt whole-sale the European confessions instead of writing their own, from the Scripture, with the older confessions as guides. (That, after all, is what ever group of confession-writers has done in the past.)
    - This view continues today among most evangelicals. "Adapting" the gospel to culture is always seen as a one-way approach. Because of 'thin' views of sin and common grace, evangelicals tend to see cultures as static, coherent wholes rather than mixtures of sinful and helpful elements, in constant flux. Thus they tend to fear cultural change at all, and they cannot critique their own culture in part. They wish to rate cultures as all-good or all-bad.

3. The Contextualization discussion - (Later 20th century to the present)

a. The World Council of Churches and contextualization.

- The initial dissatisfaction with it came from the Theological Education Fund of the World Council of Churches. This body sought to upgrade and improve theological education of the churches in the 'Third World' after WWII. During the discussions within this group, it became clear that neither the older cultural imperialism nor the newer indigenization movement was doing justice to the complexity of transmission of the gospel into a new culture. The term 'indigenization' was replaced by a new, coined word, 'contextualization.'
- The word did not really appear or get prominent usage until 1972. The WCC, which was a liberal body, saw one of inadequacies of the indigenous-church model--namely that it was superficial. While the structures and leadership was given over to the 'natives', they had western theological formulations imposed on them completely unchanged. They were sensitive to the 'one-way' approach to gospel transmission. National leaders were allowed to run the churches, but not to write theology--which had to be adopted whole-sale from Western confessions. This was seen as a continued form of cultural imperialism. (It basically was.)
- But much of the liberal WCC's concern with contextualization was (again!) too influenced by what secular sociology and anthropology was saying and doing.
    - Secular cultural anthropology had shifted again, away from the functionalist views. It has jettisoned the more mechanical, static view of culture (as a 'string of beads.') It better understands cultures as organic systems built on master 'narratives' or stories that shape the culture's view of things.
    - But secular anthropology is more deeply relativistic than ever before. Culture is now seen as a group's set of choices which contribute to its collective identity and account for life's mysteries in a particular way. Individuals choose their collective culture if it meets and fulfills their needs. If a culture fulfills ones needs (as he or she defines them) then that culture is good and fine. So all cultures are equally valid--none are more "developed" or more "functional" than any other. Cultures are in total flux, and are completely fluid.
    - Both developmentalism and functionalism had some standards by which to evaluate cultures. Today it is anathema to evaluate any cultural product as 'better' than another. We must not judge Shakespeare as being a worthier cultural product than Britney Spears. Any culture that fulfills its individual members is valid. All cultures therefore are valid.

- The problems with this view are enormous, of course, and we can't go into them here. Why should we have gone to war to stop Nazi culture from spreading, for example? And this view of culture-as-neutral is itself a radical commitment to one particular view of reality--it makes the individual self the ultimate value. And finally, this view can't really account for the power of culture. *"The problem with this perspective...is that it assumes a...self, one free and independent from culture, unencumbered by moral commitments defined by virtue of one's membership in the community. But culture is much more pervasive, powerful, and compelling than is allowed for in the liberal understanding of the self."* (J.D.Hunter, Before the Shooting Begins, 202).
- This relativism is certainly behind the WCC liberal churches' rejection of the indigenous church movement and the call to 'contextualization.' If all religious expressions are culturally relative, then every national church should come up with their own confessions and theology. To many in the mainline churches use the term 'contextualization' to mean that virtually any part of the Christian faith (the sovereignty of God, the deity of Christ) is up for grabs.

b. The initial response of evangelicals. Because the term 'contextualization' had its roots in a theologically liberal body, evangelicals were immediately wary of it. It sounded like cultural relativism and (as we noted immediately above) it often is used to promote that very thing.

- Nevertheless, while liberals saw the message and theology of national churches was *under*-adapted to their own culture (it was too 'western'), so evangelicals began to see so many things in national churches that were *over*-adapted to their own. That is, they saw many cultural practices and biases from the non-Christian culture brought in uncritically. (As we saw above--the indigenous church movement, with its static/mechanistic view of culture led to <u>both</u> over adaptation <u>and</u> under-adaptation.)
- Even evangelicals began to recognize that evangelism and church planting could be *neither* a) the oldest model of imposition--both European theology and European customs, nor b) the newer model of just substituting native customs for European customs around an unadapted core of European theology. Mission was much more complex! It was a process by which missionaries facilitated deep theological reflection by new converts about the meaning of the gospel for their life in their culture. This included not simply the structure and practices of their churches but their very theology and their formulation of the gospel.
- In the late 1970's the Lausanne Consultation on the Gospel and Culture produced the Willowbank Report, a careful statement of the need for contextualization congruent with a high view of the authority of the Scripture. From that time on most orthodox Christians and theologians agree to the importance of "contextualization". However, many people still find such talk smacking of relativism and makes them very nervous.

c. Some particular evangelical responses to the challenge of contextualization.

- Eugene Nida's approach to Bible translation--"dynamic equivalence"--and Kenneth Pike's approach to linguistics--"tagmenics" seek to shake off the effects of older secular views of culture.
  - How can Sender (S) reencode message (M) so that receptor (R) knows the same meaning, in his cultural context, that S has in his?
  - Older views (developmental and functionalist) saw words as "boxes" containing the meaning within them. In that view, the important thing is to assume there is an equivalent "box"/word in the R's language to use in the translation. (Thus NASB translates word-for-word.)
  - But Nida saw words not as "boxes" that contain meaning within them but as "arrows" that prick the hearer's heart and evoke the meaning. In this view

"meaning" is in the heart, not the word. Thus we choose words that prick the R's heart in the same way it words prick S's heart in his language.. (Thus NIV translates--"idea for idea"). This is done, says Nida, or else the real meaning of the text does not come through. Called "dynamic equivalence". It assumes you have to make greater changes to the language and cultural form of the message, if you are to maintain the same meaning or content. Keep the form, you unwittingly change the meaning--change the form in order to maintain the meaning.

- Charles Kraft. The Bible is a body of absolute truth, but as soon as we ask: "what does the Bible teach?" and begin to write our "theology" we will find that we are answering a set of questions that we have asked the Bible. What has determined what those questions are? Our list is a product of our cultural situation. For example, the Westminster Divines didn't ask the Bible much about our relationship to our parents and ancestors. But if Koreans ask "what does the Bible teach?" they will immediately ask an number of questions about one's relationship to one's family and ancestors. Thus, the Bible is absolute, but every creed or "message" taken from the Bible will be done within a particular cultural horizon. We will have understood its meaning within our own cultural context. There is, then, such a thing as 'ethno-theology.' There *is* 'Black' theology and 'Latin American' theology and 'Asian' theology in a sense. The problems:
  - The Receptor's cultural horizon has sin in it. His cultural issues and questions may be antithetical to the gospel at certain points. Therefore there is a danger, that if we adapt too far to his interests, if we remove too many 'skandalons', we will change the message of the gospel and lose it.
  - But, it is just as much a danger for the Christian Sender to underestimate the sinful elements in his own cultural context--i.e. his context is not perfect, and sinful elements may have influenced his own understanding of the gospel. Also it is a danger for the Christian Sender to underestimate God being at work in other cultures. Common grace works everywhere, and culture that doesn't seem "Christian" may have good elements within it.
  - "Conservative" mistake. So many evangelical Christians unwittingly have a static view of culture that is functionalist or even developmentalist. As a result, they look at cultures as being wholly good or bad, instead of in flux, with sinful elements and God's common grace in them all. Thus, they see their own understanding of Christianity as "pure", not contextualized, and (especially) not tainted by one's own culture's sinful imperfections. Therefore there is no attitude of humility and adaptation in the gospel communication process.
  - "Liberal" mistake. Some radical contextualizers (see the 'seeker driven church movement') may also have a naive and static view of culture. They may see it as neutral, and not as essentially religious at its core. Thus they forget that modern culture worships autonomy, etc. Wholesale adaptations to a particular culture are always dangerous and usually not wise.

B. The nature of 'contextualization'

"Contextualization" refers to the process by which we 'incarnate' the Christian faith in a particular culture, addressing a particular world-view. That is, we communicate it and practice/embody it in forms that the 'receptor-hearers' can understand. Principles behind this definition follow.

1. *Cultures are dynamic, mixed entities with a world-view about God at their heart.*

Contextualization assumes several things about culture. (Some of this is recapitulation):

- That every culture is a world-view with religion at its very heart. Every group of people are made in the image of God and therefore has an awareness of God. A culture is *"that complex...wherein a people tries to express its basic feelings toward God, nature, and itself.*

The culture of a people is its common attitude, style of living and thinking, rooted in its basic apprehension of reality." (J.H.Bavinck, quoted by Harvie Conn in Stott/Coote, p.148.)

- That culture is therefore dynamic and organic. It cannot be divided into segments, into 'beads on a string' that can be replaced without effecting every other bead. Especially, one cannot replace the religious heart of a culture without effecting everything else in it. The call to 'think world-viewishly'--to think out how the gospel effects every part of one's life, to make Christ Lord of every area of life (Col 1:15-23)--is simply the call to contextualize!
- That every culture has both demonic *and* divine grace manifesting itself within it. There are of course degrees! Some cultures surely can be less healthy than others. But especially Reformed and Catholic students of the Bible have seen that all people have 'knowledge' of God that they suppress, according to Romans 1-2. The language of Rom 1:18-25 gives us a comprehensive and dynamic picture of how 'general revelation' or 'common grace' works in lives.
- The *'truth'* is being *'suppressed'* (v.18) but it continues to bear down on us. The NIV translation of verse 20: *"Since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities...have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so men are without excuse."* But the verbs *nosumena* ("are being understood") and *kathopatai* ("are being seen") are in the form of present passive participles. That is, the reality of God's nature and our obligations to him are continuously present to us.
- This should not be thought of as static, innate ideas or information, but as a continually fresh, insistent pressure on the consciousness of every human being. In short, every artifact of human culture is a response to God's general revelation (cf. Isaiah 28 above) but always marred by an idolatrous heart that doesn't want to acknowledge the total sovereignty of God (Rom 1:21.) So all cultural production of a dialogue between God's general revelational grace and the idolatrous nature of the human heart. Every human being producing culture (and everyone is!) is in a deep 'dialogue' with the general revelation of God. Therefore human culture is an extremely complex mixture of brilliant truth, marred half-truths, and overt resistance to the truth.

2. *There is no universal, de-contextualized form or expression of Christianity.*

Contextualization assumes several things about the 'sender's' culture and the 'receptor's' culture:

- Christianity in every culture is syncretistic to a degree. It is inadequately contextualized. Every church has to some degree brought some elements of culture uncritically (un-processed by the gospel) into its form of Christianity. Individualistic cultures are miss out on the communal aspects of Christianity. Authoritarian cultures miss out on the freedom of conscience and grace aspects of Christianity. None of us have contextualized rightly.
- *Every* expression and embodiment of Christianity *is* contextualized. There is no such thing as a universal, a-historical expression of Christianity. Jesus didn't come to earth as a generalized being--by becoming human he had to become a *particular* human. He was male, Jewish, working-class. If he was to be human had to come socially and culturally-situated person.
- So the minute we begin to minister we must 'incarnate', even as Jesus did. *Actual* Christian practices must have both a Biblical form or shape as well as a cultural form or shape. For example, the Bible clearly directs us to use music to praise God--but as soon as we choose a music to use enter a culture. As soon as we choose a language, as soon as we choose a vocabulary, as soon as we choose a particular level of emotional expressiveness and intensity, as soon as we choose even an illustration as an example for a sermon--we are moving toward the social context of some people and away from the social context of others. At Pentecost, everyone heard the sermon in his or her own language and dialect. But since Pentecost, we can never be 'all things to all people' *at the very same time.* So adaptation to culture is inevitable.
- This is not relativism! *"No truth which human beings may articulate can ever be articulated in a culture-transcending way--but that does not mean that the truth thus articulated does not*

transcend culture." (D.A.Carson) It is important to keep the balance of this statement! If you forget the first half you'll think there is only one true way to communicate the gospel. If you forget the second half you'll lose your grip on the fact that nonetheless there is only one true gospel. Either way you will be ineffective in ministry. Paul does not change the gospel--but he adapts it very heavily. Sure this opens the door to abuses, but to fear and refuse to adapt to culture opens to abuses of gospel just as much! The balance is to not, on one hand succumb to relativism nor, on the other hand, think contextualization is really avoidable. Both are gospel-eroding errors.

- We can put this another way:
  - Imagine there are five translucent but colored globes, and in the center of each globe there is the same small, solid, triangular stone.
    - Each globe is a different color and texture--red, orange, blue, green, violet.
    - There is no place in the world where that stone exists outside of the globes.
    - Now--what can you tell about the stone and what can you not tell?
  - Because the stone is triangular in every globe, you can assume it probably is triangular. And perhaps there are textures and other aspects of the stone you can see in all the globes as well.
  - But because every globe is tinted, it is difficult to tell just what the color of the stone is. The more globes you look in, the easier it is to tell (for example) that it is a dark color, and you may be able to deductively guess at it. But you can't be sure.
  - The Christian gospel is like the stone and the cultures of the world are like the globe. There is no place in the world where we can directly view a universal, de-contextualized, a-historical gospel. As soon as we choose a particular language, we are 'skewering' Christianity toward our own culture. The word 'God' in English has a different meaning than the word for God in other cultures (every word has a different cultural history and connotation.) So there is no way to express the gospel in a culture-transcending way.

3. *Contextualization is a two-way process.*

- On the one hand, you are seeking to 'correct' the receptor's cultural prejudices and distortions with the gospel. But at the very same time you must use the interaction with another culture as an opportunity to reflect on the ways in which your own understanding of gospel is culturally incarnated and somewhat distorted. You will always assume or feel that some aspects of your familiar gospel Christianity which are cultural adaptations are really universals that everyone should follow. Contextualization is a time for the communicator to notice and correct his own cultural prejudices and distortions of the gospel. If that is not done the contextualization process will simply not work.
- While the Bible cannot be corrected by non-Christian cultures, Christians can be. (A refusal to allow your own Christianity to be corrected means you assume your Christianity is perfectly Biblical.) A non-Christian philosophy can point out something that is a Biblical insight but which the Christians have missed. Such a process shows us what part of our own framework is really Biblical, and what part was our own cultural or emotional baggage.
- For example, secular individualism as a philosophy is very sensitive to violations of human dignity on the basis of race. It doesn't really have a sufficient basis for calling racism evil, but its system (which idolizes individual freedom) is a radar screen which picks up racial prejudice wherever it exists. Now if secularists point out racism in a society, Christians might be forced to go back to the Scriptures and find that the Bible speaks far more about the evil of racism than they had thought. Christians are not correcting the Bible, but are correcting their understanding of the Bible, through humble interaction with non-Biblical philosophies. Why is it humble?--because we know our own sin, we know that we are not thoroughly Biblical, and we know that God in his mercy sometimes gives pagans morally informed consciences (Romans 2), which sense real evil and truth even if their intellectual furniture has no basis for their insights.
- Another example: Korean Christians have a heavy pre-layer of Confucian culture (which makes an idol of human tradition and worships ancestors). So when they read the Bible,

they see the emphasis on submission to authority, loyalty, commitment. American Christians have a heavy pre-layer of Western individualism (which makes an idol of individual feelings and needs). So when they read the Bible, they see the emphasis on freedom and personal decision. But Korean Christians will be able to pick up American Christian's phobia about commitment and hatred for authority (ie where they "screen out" Biblical truth), and American Christians will be able to pick up Korean Christians tendency to toward authoritarianism in their institutions and to enshrining human traditions in a Phariseeical way (ie where they "screen out" Biblical truth).

4. *Contextual theology is the set of answers to a particular questions you ask the Bible.*

- When a church writes down a confession of faith, it is not simply writing down what the Bible is saying. Rather it is writing down its answers to the particular questions it is asking the Bible. Harvie Conn used to point out that though the western church insisted that the Presbyterian churches of Korea adopt the Westminster Confession, there is essentially nothing in the confession about attitude toward ancestors and very little on how we should regard parents and grand-parents. Those issues are absolutely enormous in Korean culture, but the writers of the WCF did not ask the Bible about them. If the Koreans had written their own confession (using older confessions as a guide, as the WCF writers themselves did,) they would have asked quite a few questions that the 17th century British did not.
- So then what is 'contextual theology'? It is the *not* the sender simply taking his or her cultural incarnation of the gospel and expressing it using a few illustrations from the receptor's culture. It is facilitating a true interaction of the Bible and gospel with the members of the receptor culture.

5. *Contextualization is a balance of accepting and rejecting, of entering and challenging.*

a. Missionary strategy consists of two parts: a) On the one hand, be sure *not* to remove *any* of the offensive essentials of the gospel message, such as the teaching on sin, the need for repentance, the lostness of those outside of Christ, and so on. b) On the other hand, be sure *to* remove *any* non-essential language or practice that will confuse or offend the sensibilities the people you are trying to reach. The key to effective mission is to know the difference between essential and un-essential.

- If we over-adapt to a culture we are trying to reach, it means we have bought in to that culture's idols. For example, we may take a good theme (e.g. "the freedom of the individual" in the West--which fits with the 'priesthood of all believers') and allow it to be an idol (e.g. "individualism" so our church can't do pastoral accountability and discipline). If, on the other hand we under-adapt to a culture, it means we have accepted our <u>own</u> culture's idols. To the degree a ministry is over or under adapted, it loses culture-transforming power. It is therefore impossible to avoid the very real dangers of contextualization by simply holding on to the old, familiar ways. That would be as much of a cultural trap as to over-adapt.
- There is great danger in '<u>over</u>-contextualization' of course. As soon as you 'open the door' to change a ministry that has borne Biblical fruit in the past, you are in danger of undermining the gospel itself. There is always a danger that something we think is 'relative' is really 'required'. Once you lose a <u>required</u> aspect, you are going to find ministry collapsing. (For example, if we think that the doctrine of God's holiness and wrath against sin is 'relative' and should be dropped, we will find that the doctrine of God's love and mercy doesn't move or convert people. This is a mistake early 20th century liberal Protestantism made.)
- But that is not the only danger with regard to contextualization. There is just as much a danger of <u>under</u>-contextualization. Why? Every gospel ministry is contextualized to a particular culture, language, and time already. There is no 'culture-free' Christian

ministry. We all exist in time and space and culture and so every form of ministry is an 'incarnation' of Biblical themes in a particular cultural 'flesh.' That means that every form of ministry has some culturally relative aspects. If you are unwilling to recognize that--if you mistake 'relative' for 'required'--you are falling in to another serious error. It is the error of the Pharisees, who elevated human traditions and customs to the level (or above the level!) of Scriptural absolutes (Mark 7:8-9.)

b. So those who say they refuse to contextualize cannot really avoid it.

- Often, in Reformed circles, the greatest critics of contextualization may uncritically adopt favorite historical models of ministry (from Calvin's Geneva, or English Puritanism, or 19th century revivalism, or the traditional parish method from the "old country", and so on).
- On the other hand, those who tend to over-contextualize often do so because of their inability to distinguish an abiding principle from a particular method. Practitioners often are not theologically grounded and reflective enough to tell the difference. For example a principle may be: "A person should not be forced to thoroughly change his or her culture as a requirement for becoming a Christian", based on Romans 14. However, some church growth experts articulate this principle as follows: "Churches should consist of people who are all alike racially and culturally." Now this latter statement is really an particular method and application (and a controversial one!) of the Biblical principle. A minister/leader who does not grasp this distinction can only reproduce the same ministry programs wherever he goes, regardless of context or new insights from the Bible. But a leader who understands the difference can become a sensitive theologian-minister who is able to distinguish principle from method.

Summary:

- If you over-contextualize your ministry--if you mistake the 'required' for the 'relative'--you give too much authority to the new culture to which you are reaching. You 'buy in' to the new culture's idols. But
- If you under-contextualize your ministry--if you mistake the 'relative' for the 'required'--you give too much authority to the old culture from which you are reaching. You 'buy in' to the old culture's idols.

You certainly can 'lose the gospel' by over-contextualization, since you may give away some part of the gospel's doctrinal components (like the holiness of God, his wrath, and so on.) But you can 'lose the gospel' by under-contextualization, because under-contexualization is a form of Phariseeism. It is (at least implicit) moralism. The gospel of grace should free us to look at our culture critically. It should take away 'cultural self-righteousness'--the attitude that 'my culture is vastly superior'. This attitude is usually a product of a self-justifying heart. The gospel undermines such self-justification.

c. If the culture is not truly *entered* (that is, if the gospel communication comes in the undiluted cultural-form of its sender,) then the receptors have a 'cultural conversion.' They do not actually encounter God, but simply adopt the culture of the sender. If, on the other hand, the culture is not truly *challenged* and re-worked (that is, if the basic idol(s) of the culture are not really removed,) then the receptors also have only a 'cultural conversion.' They simply get a lightly 'Christianized' version of their own culture! In both these cases, non-contextualization leads the 'converts' to an encounter with culture rather than God. Conn says, *"The world-view is the change-center and the gospel of the kingdom is the change-maker."* See figure 9 attached. From H.Conn, "Conversion and Culture--A Theological Perspective with Reference to Korea" in *Down to Earth,* ed. Stott and Coote (1980)

- Harvie gives an example of how in many cases the gospel had a 'power-encounter' with Confucian traditional Korean culture. Confucianism made an idol out of hierarchical authority and therefore was deeply self-righteous and believed no one of any stature should repent. It represented a loss of 'face.' Good and evil were not absolutes anyway

in the Confucian view. Opposites needed to be blended and brought into harmony by submission to traditional authorities, parents, ancestors, and so on.

- But the gospel brought about a power-encounter with the self-righteousness of the Confucian world-view at the heart of Korean culture. A new concept of humility and greatness in the gospel brought about an enormous shift in the lives of converts. Nevertheless, Harvie hints that in some situations Koreans have been brought in to the Christian church and Christian faith without that profound shift. It is possible for a Korean church to simply 'Christianize' and keep the old Confucian world-view and approach to personal identity and hierarchy virtually in tact.
- So 'cultural conversion' can occur either if the sender does not recognize common grace in the receptor culture and brings in his own enculturated form of the gospel *or* if the basic world-view of the receptor culture is not grasped and challenged. Only if the gospel is brought into a real and startling encounter with a culture can there be conversion to Christ.

6. Contextualization is entering, challenging, and re-telling the culture's basic 'story-lines' and 'cultural narratives.

The previous part of the outline could lend the impression that culture is a pile of discrete, disjointed beliefs and practices, and it is the job of the Christian contextualizer to simply sift through them, keeping the acceptable, rejecting the unacceptable, and mildly adapting the offensive but not totally unacceptable. But that is the old 'functionalist' mechanistic view of culture. Rather, the contextualizer must discern a culture's basic 'story-lines' and connect the culture's stories to the great Christ-story of redemption.

a. Human beings can't make sense or attach meaning to anything without placing it in some kind of 'narrative-structure' or a 'story-line.'

- This has been the consensus of a remarkable amount of study over the last 20 years (and this crosses the lines of 'liberal' and 'conservative' thinking)
- The example of September 11. No one could ever discuss the event without placing it into some kind of narrative structure.
    - Some liberal voices said, "See—this is the result of America's abuse of its imperial power in the world." Some conservative voices said, "See—this is the result of evil forces in the world who hate us because we are good." Some leaders in New York City said, "See—this is the way we can become a better city, by pulling together and being strong and getting through it."
    - But *no* one was able to talk about what 9-11 meant unless they could see it as part of a story-line. We need stories to provide meaning to things.

b. What *is* a story or narrative?

- **1st** a story begins when something throws life off balance. For example: "Little Red Riding Hood took her grandmother some goodies" is not a story. But "Little Red Riding Hood was going to her grandmother to bring her some goodies, but a big bad wolf tried to eat her" -- is.
- **2nd** and a story progresses as the central characters fight to restore that balance. This means—and it is something many scholars don't like—that stories unavoidably divide characters into protagonists (those struggling toward the restoration of balance/peace) and antagonists (those struggling against the restoration and the protagonists). Thus since there can be no meaning without stories—and no stories without good guys and bad guys--then there can be no meaning or community identity or personal identity without the creation of 'the Other'--the 'bad guys', the people we are not like.
- **3rd** the story ends as the struggle results in either the restoration of the balance or the failure to restore it.
- **Sum:** So a 'story' consists of the answer to three questions: 1) "how are things supposed to be? "(implied in any story—unavoidably—is a theory about how life ought to be 2)

"what has gone wrong?" what is the main problem with things? 3) "what is the solution and can it be realized?"

c. Human beings use stories not only to make sense of events, but also of our entire lives and the world itself.

- Since the beginning of history, people have not only used stories to make sense of events and of *life itself.*
  - Everyone knows that the world as a whole is out of balance—seriously out of whack. No one says the world or life is fine.
  - First, there is something wrong *within* us. Nothing ever seems to make us happy or fulfilled in anything but the most passing way. Lovers, landscapes, experiences all seem to promise us ultimate joy but can never deliver it. We seem to want something that they point to—something that nothing in this world seems to satisfy.
  - Second, there is something also wrong *among* us. The world is filled with poverty, war, suffering, and injustice. Something seems to have knocked the whole world off balance. What is it? And what is the solution?
  - It is impossible to live life without a working theory or belief about *what is mainly wrong with things* and *what will put it right.*
- The result of any answers to these 'big' questions—is what has been called a 'world-view'—a mental/spiritual map of reality.
  - We call it 'mental' because it is a set of assumptions through which understand things—it is a 'macro-story' that helps us attach meaning to the events around us. We put every event into the macro-story to make sense of it. (That is why a liberals and conservatives could both take 9-11 and make it confirm what they always had thought about the world.)
  - We call it 'spiritual' because any answer to these questions is unavoidably a set of faith beliefs. It is always based on views of human nature, a commitment (again, unavoidable) about God's nature, importance. It is an understanding of *the* problem in life and *the* struggle against it and *the* way to be 'saved.'
  - It is unavoidable to have some kind of working 'world-story' or world-view. It answers questions: what is life all about? What is worth doing and not worth doing? In other words, every culture has had a World-Story, which consists of the agreed upon answers to the three questions. The Greeks saw the main problem to be the body and the material world. Eastern religions and cultures however believed the main problem was the illusion of individual consciousness and the selfish craving it engendered. So a 'world-view' is a 'World-Story'—an account of how things ought to be, what knocked them out of whack, and how we can put things right

d. The Christian 'story-line' of the gospel can actually encompass and complete other world-view 'story-lines.'

- Compared to Christianity, other views of reality (and thus cultures) identify <u>some created thing</u> as being 'the problem' with the world and <u>some created thing</u> as 'our hope, our trust' to get us through. (These are the 'protagonists' and the 'antagonists' of their world-view's story of the world.) But Christianity says that the answer to the first question is 'sin', and the answer to the second question is 'Jesus only'. Without the gospel, you have to make *some*thing besides the Lord into a savior, and thus something else into the demonic 'other' or 'enemy'.
  - Thus Marxism assumes all our problems come from the powerful, greedy capitalists who won't share the means of economic production with the people. The solution is a totalitarian state.
  - Freud on the other hand believed all our problems comes from repression of deep desires for pleasure. The solution is the unrepressed freedom of the individual--thus the villains become repressive moral 'gate-keepers' in society like the church.

- Plenty of people have a "traditional values" world-view (which is the very opposite of Freud's.) They think the problem with the world lies in bad, undisciplined, selfish people who won't submit to traditional moral values and family responsibilities. The solution is a moral 'revival' in society of religion and morality and virtue.
- Only the Christian world-view locates the problem with the world *not* in any one part of the world or in any one group of people but in Sin itself. And it locates the solution in God's grace and the coming of the kingdom. Sin infects us all, and so we cannot simply divide the world into the 'good guys' and the bad. Without an understanding of the nature of the kingdom, we will be either naively utopian or cynical and disillusioned. We will be demonizing something that isn't all that bad and we will be idolizing something that isn't all that good.

- The Christian story line works beautifully a) to make sense of things, and b) even to appreciate the truth embedded in stories that clearly come from another world view.
  - The Christian 'story' line is: Creation, Fall, Redemption.
    - *Everything is good.* God made the world and everything in it was good. There is no intrinsically evil parts of the world. Nothing is evil in the beginning, even Sauron was not so. You can look for the 'creational good' in anything. Like Tolkien did with his celebration of ancient (pagan) Anglo-Saxon culture and even the nature spirit (Tom Bombadil). Non-Christian world-views make idols out of created things, but Christianity can appreciate the goodness of anything the culture lifts up (though too high.)
    - *Everything is fallen.* There is no part of the world not effected by sin. For example, is reason bad but emotion good? No. Are emotion and passions bad, and reason good? No. Is the physical bad and the spiritual good? Is the normal day-to-day world profane, but religious observances good? No. All of these distinctions fail the gospel world view and try to locate the world's problems in some created thing instead of in sin. Non-Christian world-views villainize and demonize some created thing, but Christianity can appreciate the evil and danger of anything the culture denigrates (though too much.)
    - *Everything is going to be redeemed.* Jesus is not going to redeem just the spirit but also all things. This means in Christ's future redeemed world virtually all the *main* hopes of any non-Christian culture will be realized.
  - The Christian, then, can appreciate the truth in any world-view *while at the same time 'deconstructing' it.* The Christian who is 'contextualizing' the gospel must show the destructiveness of making something besides God into the central thing. You must show the culture that their own world-view will not be able to give them their deepest hopes. You must show that only in Christ will your culture's basic story have a 'happy ending.' The macro-gospel story line is remarkably able to 'take in' all sorts of mini-stories and make sense of them in a way that doesn't offend or make feel coerced. For example.
    - Modern example. The radical deconstructionist in NYC wants to show that all truth claims are really just power grabs. He uses deconstruction to free people from oppression--which is his ultimate hope.
      - But when you make the deconstruction tool into an ultimate it deconstructs itself. If all truth claims are just power grabs--so is that, and why do we have to listen to it? *In end, to see through <u>everything</u> is not to see.*(CSL, *Abolition of Man*)
      - But Jesus deconstructs *moralism.* The oppressiveness that demonizes 'the Other' comes not from the idea of truth but from trying to save yourself by believing and obeying the truth. There is a true deconstruction (the gospel of grace) that deconstructs Phariseeism and oppression without deconstructing itself.
    - Ancient examples. This is what Paul is doing in 1 Cor 1 when he says that the Jews wanted power (but the cross is weakness) and the Greeks wanted wisdom

(but the cross is foolishness) and YET Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God.
    - This means that in one way the gospel story challenged *both* the Jewish baseline culture narrative (the search for power) and the Greek's baseline cultural narrative (the search for wisdom.)
    - Paul is saying that in one way the gospel enters the culture's story (because yes, power is important and yes, wisdom is important) and yet it tells each culture how it will never find true power or wisdom except in Christ. There are always tensions in the culture's story-- antagonists that you cannot over come--without Jesus. Paul "entered" and sympathized with both Jews and Greeks in their cultural aspirations but also showed how the culture's plot-lines can only be resolved in Jesus. The Jews were offended by the idea of a weak Messiah--but in the end Jesus gives the Jewish believers the ultimate power their entire culture has been seeking so passionately. The Greeks were offended by the idea of a foolish Messiah (and by the whole idea of revelation)--but in the end Jesus gives the Greek believers the ultimate wisdom their entire culture has been seeking so passionately
- A generational example.
    - The older generations in America had this as their cultural story--What life is all about is being a *good* person: a good person, a good father/mother, son/daughter, to live a decent, merciful, good life.
    - The younger generations in America have this as their cultural story--What life is all about is being a *free* person. We must be *free* and self-created and authentic (theme of freedom from oppression) and we must make the world safe for everyone else to be the same (theme of inclusion of the 'other')
    - We must then show how only in Christ can we have freedom without slavery. Only in Christ can we truly embrace the 'other' without injustice. We must 're-tell' the culture's story and show how its story lines only resolve themselves in the death and resurrection of Jesus.
- Some current cultural examples.
    - In the 20th century hundreds of millions of Africans concluded that when comparing tribal animism, Islam, secular capitalism, and Christianity--Christianity best resolved the their hopes and aspirations as Africans to be a moral people with freedom from the forces of darkness in the world (That is their fundamental cultural story. Not, like the Jews a quest for wisdom, nor like the Greeks a quest for philosophy and wisdom, but a quest for freedom and authority over the spiritual forces in the world.)
    - In the 21st century it looks like hundreds of millions of Chinese may conclude something similar as they compare Confucianism, Communism, secular capitalism, and Christianity.
- So gospel communication does not mean only a 'head on collision'--i.e. my story is better than your story. Rather, gospel communication is: Jesus resolves the plot lines in your story better than anything else can. So a great writer like Tolkien enters the old did old northern European pagan world and resolves their main story lines of valor and glory and doomed-fulfillment-of-duty. So a great writer like Flannery O'Connor enters the racist narrow Southern culture and resolves it with grace. (See "Revelation")
- The concept of the gospel as <u>the</u> 'Good Story' has enormous implications for communicating the gospel in every culture. Lamin Sanneh <u>*Translating the Message*</u> insists that only Christianity does not decimate an indigenous culture's story, but rather a) enters it, b) cleanses it of distortions, demonic and idolatrous elements, and c) resolves its unresolved story lines in Christ.

So Tolkien wrote:

The Gospels contain…a story of a larger kind which embraces all the essence of fairy-stories. But this story has entered history and the primary world…There is no tale ever told that men would rather find was true, and none which so many skeptical men have accepted as true on its own merits. To reject it leads either to sadness or to wrath… [T]his story is supreme; and it is true. God is Lord, of angels, and of men--and of elves. Legend and History have met and fused.

Christianity *is* the true story of the life of Jesus, through which God entered history and the material world in order to redeem and restore it to himself and to us.

Lamin Sanneh wrote:

"Translation is a highly problematic enterprise. The original is assumed to be inadequate...or inappropriate, but at any rate ineffective for the task at hand. Thus a peripheral role comes to be assigned to the original mode. In addition, translation forces a distinction between the essence of the message and its cultural presuppositions, with the assumption that such a separation enables us to affirm the primacy of the message over its cultural underpinnings. The translation involves some degree of cultural alienation on the part of the translator....Thus mission as translation makes the bold, fundamental assertion that the recipient culture is the authentic destination of God's salvific promise..."Paul faced the combined demands of Jewish particularity in seeking messianic consolation and the Greek expectation of philosophical emancipation by affirming the cross....He writes to the church at Corinth: "For the Jews demand signs and Greeks seek wisdom, but we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles, but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God." (1 Cor 1:22-24) The gospel is thus recognized by both Jew and Greek as [both a challenge to and] a confirmation of their respective particularity..."[2]

7. The gospel itself is the key to contextualization.

- Religion (*I obey-therefore I am accepted*) leads to either pride (if I am living up to standards) or inferiority (if I am failing to live up to standards) but the gospel (*I am accepted through Christ--therefore I obey)* makes us both humble and confident at once.
- This makes us contextualizers! If we need the approval of the receiving culture too much, it shows a lack of gospel confidence. If we need the trappings of our own culture too much, it shows a lack of gospel humility. Gospel humility directs us to neither hate tradition nor be bound to it. It is proud to imagine that other Christians did not find much grace in past 'contextualizations' and therefore we do not ignore tradition. But it is also proud to think that new cultural trends have no grace in them and that former cultures were all more spiritually pure. Thus we adapt.

  "[When] the church had lost track of an important element in the saving work of Christ and was teaching that believers are justified not by faith but by being sanctified...as a result it became very easy for the church to revert to an Old Covenant lifestyle....Uneasiness about justification [by grace alone] produced a flowering of asceticism reflecting an unconscious need for lists of clean and unclean activities and a rebirth of Pharisaism. .....Thus [those] who are not secure in Christ cast about for spiritual life preservers with which to support their confidence, and in their frantic search they not only cling to the shreds of ability and righteousness they find in themselves, but they fix upon their race, their membership in a party, their familiar social and ecclesiastical patterns, and their culture as means of self-recommendation. The culture is put on as if it were armor against self-doubt, but it becomes a mental straightjacket which cleaves to the flesh and can never be removed except through comprehensive faith in the saving work of Christ. Once faith is exercised, a Christian is free to be enculturated, to wear his culture like a comfortable suit of clothes. He can shift to other cultural clothing temporarily if he wishes to do so, as Paul suggests in 1 Cor.9:19-23, and he

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[2] Lamin Sanneh, *Translating the Message: The Missionary Impact on Culture* (Orbis, 1989), pp.31,34.

is released to admire and appreciate the differing expressions of Christ shining out through other cultures.[3]

C. Theological resources for contextualization.

1. Incarnation
In Philippians 2:6-11, we are told that Jesus Christ did not hold on to his heavenly culture and identity, but submitted himself to our form and became a servant for us. Paul insists that we all imitate the incarnation, telling us to "not only look to your own interests, but also to the interests of others." (v.4)

So there may be two kinds of churches. One kind says to its community: "you can come to us, learn our language, our interests, and meet our needs." The other kind says to its community: "we will come to you, learn your language, learn your interests, meet your needs." Which of these approaches imitates the incarnation? The latter. And it is this latter kind of church that is likely to adapt its shape in such a way as to communicate most effectively with the people God has called us to reach.

2. Hermeneutics
Whenever a believer reads the Bible, he or she must ask: "how can I obey the Bible here and now?" Why? Nothing in Scripture is revealed simply to be known abstractly. Rather, everything is revealed to be obeyed in our concrete situation (Deut.29:29). This is because "the Creator-creature relation is a covenant relation, a Lord-servant relation."[4] All revealed truth is a summons by God to know him and obey him. The Biblical God is a covenant Lord, speaking to covenant servants, he expects us to apply the word to the situation (the age and the culture) in which we live.

The effect of this understanding of the Scripture as "covenantal revelation" is to keep united what has traditionally been separated, namely "meaning" and "application".

> "Over and over, preachers (and others) try to proclaim the `meaning' of the text and then its `application'--the first part is `what it means', the second `what it means to us'....[But] every request for `meaning' is a request for an application...the one who asks doesn't understand the passage well enough to use it himself...A person does not understand Scripture, Scripture tells us, unless he can apply it to new situations, to situations not even envisaged in the original text (Matt.16:3; 22:29; Luke 24:25; John 5:39f.; Rom.15:4; II Tim.3:16f.; II Pet.1:19-21-in context)." [emphasis mine][5]

Frame's argument is this: <u>we don't understand what a text means unless we understand how we are to *use* it and obey it</u>. Scripture cannot be understood unless it is being obeyed, and it cannot be obeyed except in the concrete situation. When we use this approach in ministry design, the results are radical. Many Biblical scholars have tried, in their study, to distill from the Bible a single, pure ministry design or church structure which must then be faithfully reproduced wherever one goes. Frame argues that this is a misunderstanding of Scripture as covenantal revelation. Instead, the Biblical absolutes which give the church its form must take different shapes as they become expressed in different times and cultures. There will be many church "models" and many ministry designs, all very Biblical.

Therefore, there is no such thing as 'pure theology' that can be extracted from the Scripture and which then must be 'contextualized.' All theology is to one degree or another <u>already</u> "contextualized" culturally in its very form. What *is* systematic theology? It is a series of

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[3] Richard Lovelace, <u>*The Dynamics of Spiritual Life*</u> (IVP, 1979) p.190-191,198
[4] John Frame, *Doctrine of the Knowledge of God,* p.13.
[5] Ibid, p. 83-84

answers to questions we have asked the Bible. But what determines the questions on that list? Why does a theologian ask the particular set of questions he or she does? It is largely because our experience in our time and culture poses such questions to our mind. Then we seek answers to them in the Bible, and the result is a culturally influenced systematic theology. In the Westminster Confession, for example, there is nothing about ancestor worship, because none of the Westminster divines asked the Bible that question. In Korean culture, however, that is a pressing issue.

Thus every systematic theology ever written is 'contextualized' already. And in every age and culture, we must come to the Scripture with new questions relevant to that time and society. Since we are not relativists (who teach that truth is entirely subjective and bound by our experience), we are not to discard or demote the penetrating and comprehensive confessions of past eras. But new congregations must not only propagate formulae which were the result of another centuries' set of questions. They must also answer the questions of the age and apply the gospel to the forms of confusion and brokenness we confront now.

3. History of Redemption.
Redemptive history is also the history of revelation, and in revelational history we continually see God adapting his communication to the capacities of the receiver. Geerhardus Vos in his Biblical Theology has shown that God unfolds revelation in a history, in stages, with each stage adapted to the ability of the people to whom he speaks. "Revelation has a history because God respects our creaturely existence. Revelation honors it without capitulating to it, adjusts to it without compromising its own truth-filled character. It bends down without being distorted."--Harvie M. Conn, *Evangelism: Doing Justice and Preaching Grace* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1982), p. 14.

- God sends his message through a human prophet when the people complain they cannot listen to his voice directly (Deut.18:15-19).
- When God entered into a relationship with Israel, he adopted a cultural form, the specific format of suzerain-vassal treaties in the Near East during the second millennium B.C. See Meredith G. Kline, *The Structure of Biblical Authority* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1972), pp. 21-38.
- Paul boasts that he becomes "to the Jews as a Jew...to the weak I became weak...that I by all means save some..." (I Cor. 9:19-23). Studies have been done of Paul's adaptation of the gospel message to the diverse cultures of his many audiences. Paul varied his use of emotion and reason, his citation of approved authorities, his vocabulary, his choice of points of contention (avoiding unnecessary issues), his identification of the audiences concerns, hopes, and needs. In every case, he had a specific kind of people "targeted". See Jay E. Adams, *Audience Adaptations in the Sermons and Speeches of Paul* (Presby. and Reformed, 1976), especially pp. 61-64.

4. Biblical authority.
A high view of the Bible demands that we believe in contextualization. Why? The Bible gives us great freedom in the details of living. (That is why it can be used in all cultures.) Since the Bible does not tell us specifically how to dress or specifically what kind of music to listen to, there is freedom to shape dress and music in such a way that both honors the Biblical boundaries and themes and yet fits a culture. To deny that much of our Christianity is culturally relative is to elevate human tradition to divine authority and to therefore dishonor the Scripture.

5. Paul's contextualization in Acts, Romans, and 1 Corinthians.
We continually see Paul's approach to contextualization:
- A church must avoid all unnecessary cultural offense. Where the Bible has not spoken, and has left the conscience free, we must not elevate relative human cultural norms to make them absolutes. For example, we should not insist that rhythmic music is less

pleasing to God than melodic music and must be excluded from worship. We must not absolutize styles of dress, and so on.

- On the other hand, it must not eliminate the offense of the gospel. The cross is a skandalon, an offense. What the Bible has clearly and absolutely taught, we cannot soft pedal or discard. If we do, we have not adapted to the culture, we have capitulated. For example, if we have a congregation of rich people, and we never speak of social justice, we eliminate a Biblical skandalon.

Paul applies these two principles to the question of meat offered to idols (I Corinthians 8:1ff) This was a cultural problem--Jews saw the idols as nothing and former pagan Greeks were offended because of their culturally framed consciences (cf.I Cor. 10:32). Though Paul agrees that the meat was harmless and thus the "weak" brothers were being controlled by a strictly cultural taboo (I Cor. 8:4-5), the "strong" should not unnecessarily "offend" the weak by exercising their freedom from the culture (I Cor. 8:10-12). Cultural accommodation here does not compromise the gospel.

Francis Schaeffer was taking up this whole issue when he admonished the church to recognize the difference between Biblically prescribe "form" and cultural "freedom." "Anything the New Testament does not command in regard to church form is a freedom to be exercised under the leadership of the Holy Spirit for that particular time and place." See The Church at the End of the Twentieth Century (IVP, 1970), p.67. We must not absolutize styles of worship, communication, leadership, education, and outreach where the Bible leaves us free.

In summary, churches will grow if 1) they choose models of ministry and communicate the gospel in forms "contextualized" to their community, 2) they answer the questions of the age from the Scripture, and 3) they give no unnecessary cultural offense, while challenging the culture with the irreducible truths of the gospel.

THE RISE OF POST-WESTERN CHRISTIANITY

A. The pattern of Christian expansion.

1. Christianity has not grown like any of the other religions. For example, Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam are all still demographically centered on their land and people-group of origin. That is, the lands that began as Hindu, Buddhist, and Islamic have stayed so and thus each religion remains dominated by its original people group--Indian, or Asian, or Arabic/Middle Eastern. Of all the major world religions, Christianity alone is quite different. The original center of Islam was and still is Mecca. But the original center of Christianity, Jerusalem, is no longer that. What is the Christian pattern of expansion?

2. At first, Christianity was centered on Jerusalem but within a century, the center of Christianity was the Hellenistic world of the Mediterranean. That was the center for several centuries, but as the Roman empire collapsed the barbarians of Northern and Western Europe became the new center. Europe was the center of Christianity for many years, though one might say that over the last couple of centuries North America took that role. Now however Christianity is losing influence in Europe and only holding its own in North America, but it is growing at 7 to 10 times the rate of the population in the parts of the world growing the fastest--Africa, Latin America, and Asia. Already more Christians live south of the equator than north of the equator. The centuries of Christian institutions and the greater financial resources of the West continue to give the churches of the west dominance despite their dwindling numbers. But over the next few decades and century increasingly the centers of theological reflection and training as well as the centers of ministry and of the most influential churches will be outside the West.

3. So this is the pattern: Christianity always flourishes better away from its own center, at or beyond its periphery, among people who are excluded from power. It tends to weaken at its own center and renew itself at its margins. This means:

> **a)** Christianity is the only truly multi-cultural religion. It is the only religion that has truly been owned and operated by a series of different racial/cultural groups. And on a related note, we can say--
>
> **b)** Ultimately no one people group owns the Christian faith. Lamin Sanneh puts it in the form of a rhetorical question of his book-title, *Whose Religion Is Christianity?* His point is that Christianity can*not* be seen as primarily or only a Western religion, any more than it was primarily a Hellenistic religion or a Jewish sect. As Andrew Wall says *"That is, there is no 'Christian culture' the way there is an 'Islamic culture' which you can recognize from Pakistan to Tunisia to Morocco."* ("The Expansion of Christianity: An Interview with Andrew Walls" *Christian Century,* August 2-9, 2000, p.792)

B. The magnitude of the Christian expansion.
The Phillip Jenkins "The Next Christianity" (*The Atlantic*) *The Next Christendom* (Oxford Press) was the first scholar to get media attention for this phenomenon, though Andrew F. Walls and others had been writing about it for a couple of decades. It is arguably the event that will have the most impact on the history of the world over the next century. Some interesting details in order to put things in perspective (the following are from Jenkins and Sanneh):

1. Only 5% of the world's Catholics now life in North America, and only 10% of the world's Anglicans in North America and the Great Britain combined. (from Jenkins)

2. In 1900 Africa had 8.7 million Christians, about 9% of the total population of 107.9 million, and most of these were Coptic and Ethiopian Christians. By contrast Muslims in Africa were 34.5 million strong and outnumbered Christians more than 4 to 1. By 1970 there were 120 million Christians. Today there are 370 million Christians, about 45% of the total population of 840 million. The Christians now are just about equal in size with Muslims and all projections are that Christianity will grow to over 600 million within 25 years and comprise over 60% of the African population.

3. The size of the church in China is notoriously hard to count. The Communist government's official estimates are no more than 15 million, but it only officially recognizes a certain number of registered churches called the "Three Self Patriotic Movement" and ignores the millions of house churches. High estimates are 80-90 million Christians in China, out of the 1.28 billion population (5-7%). However, there is consensus that something much like the African 'explosion' of Christian faith is happening in China. Even the Three-Self movement acknowledges enormous growth statistics of 20% or more over the last couple of years. Many predict that by 2050 the Christian population in China could approach 400 million.

4. By the year 2050 there will be 500 million Buddhists in the world, but there will be 1 billion Pentecostals alone (!) and probably 1.4 billion Catholics, to say nothing of other Protestants and Orthodox churches. Pentecostals alone will equal the number of Hindus in the world. And all Christians will continue to outnumber Muslims by 2 to 1. (See Jenkins)

C. The nature of post-western Christianity.

1. Post-western Christianity. Lamin Sanneh uses the terms "world Christianity" and "global Christianity" to refer to two somewhat different movements. "World Christianity" is the faith as it takes shape in a new society that expresses itself through the cultures, customs, and

traditions of the people. (p.22) "Global Christianity" is a term he uses to describe the replication in other countries of forms of Christianity forged in Europe.

2. How it has emerged. How does 'post-western' world Christianity emerge?

a. Both Andrew Wall and Lesslie Newbigin describe the stages that a new culture goes through as it receives Christianity. At first the converts receive the faith in a form fairly close to the form of the faith in the missionary's home culture. As the converts read the Bible after a time they come to see things in the Word that the missionaries 'played down' (like exorcisms) and other things they 'played up' in accordance with their own cultural perspectives and biases. This may lead to a time of *over*-reaction against the missionaries' form of faith in which they try to purge themselves of any feature of 'western' Christianity at all. Eventually the converts come to terms with their own cultures and traditions--rejecting parts of it, affirming parts of it, and modifying parts of it all in light of their reading of the Scriptures.

b. How does this happen? Here is an over-simplified answer, based on the writings of Wall:

(1) Unlike Islam and other religions, Christianity has an incarnate God, a God who comes to express himself in our own flesh. Jesus was both a 'prisoner' of our humanity (it limited him in many ways) yet a 'liberator' of our humanity.

(2) In Acts 15 the leaders of the earliest church, the Jerusalem Christian community, concluded that the Gentiles could enter the new Israel without becoming Jews. *"Though circumcised, Torah-keeping Jews themselves, they recognized that Gentile believers in the Messiah could enter Israel without becoming Jews. They were converts, not proselytes....It is hardly possible to exaggerate the importance of this early controversy and its outcome; it is a pivot on which Christian history turns...for it built the principle of cultural diversity into Christianity in perpetuity."* (A.Walls, quoted by Mark Gornik in his unpublished paper "Andrew Walls on the Changing Church and Missions") In principle the church has always been multi-cultural. Today it is finally realizing what it has always been in principle.

Note: to Walls a 'proselyte' is someone who has simply adopted someone else's culture. A 'convert' is someone who has appropriated Christ into one's *own* thought, life, and culture where it makes radical changes but nonetheless expresses itself.

(3) This is why we believe in translating the Word of God into the languages of the hearers. Islam does not believe the Koran can really be translated. You must learn Arabic (and therefore Arabic thought forms and culture) in order to hear God's word. It makes sense that Muslims don't believe God's word is translatable. To use the words of a new language is always to use the concepts of that language's culture. For example, the word 'God' exists in every culture, but it is tied to the traditions of that culture's non-Christian past. So to translate holy writings into a new language is both to correct and connect to that culture's traditions. It corrects because the 'God' of the Bible does not act like the 'God' of that culture's past. And yet the very use of the word causes people to see ways that God was working in their own cultural past before they knew of Christ.

- For example, Paul's use of the Hellenistic idea of *pleroma* ("fullness") and John's use of the word *logos* ("reason" or "Word") connects to the Greek pagan past automatically. Their use of the words says to readers something like: "the aspirations of your ancestors and people for wisdom is now found in Christ.
- For example, 20th century Africans had a long tradition of belief in a supernatural world of good and evil spirits. Their tribal religions, however, were proving

inadequate to really help people overcome the evil they saw around them--personal, social, political, spiritual. This was particularly true in the social breakdowns that have occurred in Africa since the end of colonial rule after World War II. But what alternatives did Africans have? There was western secularism (with its disdain of the supernatural) and Islam (with its disdain of the African past). When Africans began to read the Bible in their own languages, with their own traditional words for God used in the text, they began to see in Christ the final solution to their own historic longings and aspirations as Africans.

The old [African] religions provided the rules, rewarding good conduct and punishing wrong, but they had only a limited ethical range....Christianity answered this historical challenge by a reorientation of the world-view....People sensed in their hearts that Jesus did not mock their respect for the sacred nor their clamor for an invincible Savior, and so they beat their sacred drums for him until the stars skipped and danced in the skies. After that dance the stars weren't little anymore. Christianity helped Africans to become renewed Africans, not re-made Europeans. (Sanneh, p. 43)

(4) Something like that is happening in China. While the Africans realize that Christianity (rather than the alternatives of Islam, tribal animism, or western secularism) is the best way to honor their own African-ness (rather than Confucianism, Communism, and western secularism) so the Chinese are coming to realize that Christianity is the best way to honor their own Chinese-ness, their historic aspirations and character as a people. Every form of Christianity is 'imprisoned' in a culture (somewhat limited by it) but at the same time is its liberator, transforming and purifying it with the gospel.

c. It is quite right to worry about syncretism, which is the corruption and over-adaptation of Christianity to a culture. (Syncretism is 'selling out' some gospel distinctives in order to make Christianity palatable to a new society.) But if a 'sender' won't adapt Christianity at all to a new 'receptor' culture that means you have wedded Christianity too close to *your* culture. It means you have turned your own culture's incarnation of the faith into a absolutely universal form of Christianity. You don't see that the Christianity of your heart is partially a 'prisoner'--is limited and adapted to your culture.

Lamin Sanneh (drawing on Wall) defines conversion as *"turning of our selves to God, and that means all of ourselves without leaving anything behind or outside. But that also means not replacing what is there with something else. Conversion is a re-focusing of the mental life and its cultural/social underpinning and of our feelings, affections, and instincts, in the light of what God has done in Jesus."* (Sanneh, p.43-44.) This is quite helpful. When Africans become a Christian, their African-ness is converted it is not replaced with Chinese-ness or European-ness. Along the same lines, Miraslov Volf insists every Christian must get distance from his or her home culture through Christ, yet not 'arrive' in some other culture in order to be Christian. African believers must get distance enough to critique their African traditions according to the gospel and the Word, yet must also embrace and inhabit their African culture.

Summary: Contrary to popular opinion, Christianity is not a western religion. It is not the creation or result of any particular culture, but it is the result of the Spirit re-creating Christianity in the soil of each and every culture. Christians are Christians first, and Europeans or Asians or Africans second. But Christianity does not make Africans into Europeans. Christianity *completes* and fulfills Europeans, Asians, and Africans as themselves, at the very same moment binding together people in Christ who previously could not unite in peace. Christian conversion is the trans-cultural work of the Spirit of God, incarnating the gospel in every culture, bringing down the barriers that have divided the human race.

3. Post-enlightenment Christianity. As we noted above, perhaps the chief characteristics of the new 'post-western world Christianity' is that it did not make its peace with the Enlightenment the way western Christianity did. This is one of the main differences between it and western churches.

a. Both liberal and conservative Christian theology have been profoundly effected by the Enlightenment, which assumes there is an extremely firm line between the empirical time-space world and the spiritual world. Liberal Christianity essentially believes the line is completely firm. It uses historical criticism on the Bible that denies the miraculous elements as necessarily 'legendary'. It re-interprets the deity and resurrection of Christ as 'symbols' only. But conservative Christian theology, while fervently defending miraculous events in Biblical times, is extremely skeptical of the supernatural today. We believe that the line between the supernatural and the natural world was breached at several places (the incarnation, resurrection, Pentecost, and very rare other instances since then, perhaps.) Guidance, prayer, Christian growth--are all interpreted in very rational ways, largely as the application of sound doctrine through our minds and our wills.

But non-western cultures did not pass through the Enlightenment in the same way. They see the line between the supernatural and the natural to be a very porous boundary--being crossed every day. Their understanding of evil is much more multi-dimensional than western people and even than western Christian. They understand that evil has a spiritual life of its own--it is not just the result of discrete actions. When non-western people read the Bible, they see that the Bible does not recognize the very strict boundary between the supernatural and the natural that western people assume.

b. Ironically, Christianity is much less 'imperialistic' toward cultures than western Enlightenment-drenched secularism. Secularism is extremely disdainful of belief in miracles, healing, and demons and is uncomfortable with any religion at all.

- *"Should we not instead be talking about goodwill among all people without regard to religious labels?"* is a typical secular western observation expressed in Lamin Sanneh's book. Sanneh responds: *"Let us talk about the expansion of goodwill among all people, but let us not make that goodwill an alternative or a rival to religion lest we become sectarian and triumphalistic in another way."* (p.33) Sanneh's point is that western culture's seeming 'tolerance' of all religions is actually a rival religion--a sectarian and triumphalistic anti-supernaturalism and individualism that will replace and mock Africans' "respect for the sacred".
- At another place in Sanneh's book another typical western view is expressed. *"I have an objection to Bible translation as being too simplistic. It perpetuates an anachronistic, pre-scientific worldview about creation, the virgin birth, miracles, bodily resurrection, life after death, the second coming of Christ, and judgment day as literal truths."* Sanneh responds, *"You were complaining just now about missionaries using the Bible as a stealth platform to advance their own agenda. Shouldn't you, to be consistent, complain just as vehemently if we...promote the Enlightenment agenda of rationality? Because that would be stealth invasion no less....The peoples of the world have a right to come to their own view of the matter...and not accede to our [western] standards of progress."* (p.115-116Islam is just as insistent that converts take on Arabic culture. So Christianity is the least imperialistic of the world-views. That is a point Sanneh tries to make, but it is an extremely difficult point for western skeptics to recognize (or refute!)

c. So what is the emerging "Supernatural" Christianity? It holds

(1) the entire trustworthiness of the Bible, though they may read it more 'mystically' than we would read it--not dissecting and interpreting it but 'inhabiting' it and embodying it,
(2) the redemptive work of Jesus as the only, gracious basis for salvation, though they may see the cross more in *Christus Victor* terms of Jesus' triumph over the evil forces that bind us
(3) the historical reality of miracles, the virgin birth and incarnation, the resurrection of Jesus, though they are much more likely to believe that such miracles continue today
(4) the necessity of the supernatural work of the Spirit to convert and renew individuals, though their understanding of daily guidance and victory over sin and evil would also be considered parts of the normal work of the Spirit.
(5) the return of Jesus Christ personally and historically to renew the whole world.

c. The Christianity growing in the world today is not identical to *any* western variety, but it is furthest from the mainline-liberal Christianity that was the most heavily steeped in a skepticism of the supernatural. The irony of this is that for most of the 20th century this very rationalistic version of religion was thought to be the only kind of Christianity that would grow in the future. The very liberal Bishop Spong published a book entitled *Christianity Must Change or Die* yet the very kind of Christianity he insists must change is flourishing at an enormous rate.

Another irony is that for so many years the liberal western church sought to be an advocate for the poor and the oppressed of the world. Now the very churches of the poor and the oppressed oppose the theology and policies of the dominantly liberal mainline churches (e.g. the controversy in the Anglican Communion over homosexuality.) Someone quipped, "the liberals opted for the poor, but the poor opted for born-again Christianity." While 'liberal' mainline is still enormously wealthy in Western world, with billions in assets, and therefore will not simply collapse but will continue as an institution for many years--it is nonetheless dwindling in numbers and very rapidly becoming marginal to the concerns of the world church.

D. Post-western Christianity and the future.
What are the implications for us, now, in light of this momentous development?

1. Theological education. There needs to be a significant change in theological education and reflection. We need to study not just the history of the church in the West, but the history of the church in Asia, Latin America, and Africa. Why? Non-western church history can teach us about how to deal with pluralism--something western churches have not faced in 1500 years. While European Christianity spread through the power of the nation-state (princes and rulers adopting Christian faith on behalf of their people) that has not been the situation of the post-western church in any part of the world. Also, we have much to learn from them on a) evangelism from a position of cultural marginality, b) theological reflection on the poor, c) worship and spirituality, and d) a wholistic approach to counseling the person. (This list is from Mark Gornik's paper)

2. Cooperation and mutual learning. Cooperation and mutual learning must occur across the barriers. Every culture that receives Christ contributes to our understanding of the fullness of Christ. *It would fit the postmodern fashion to say that each local Christian discourse is valid and sufficient in itself. But the church is Christ's body, and the picture we are given in the Epistle of the Ephesians of the relations of different cultural presences in the body is neither of uniformity nor of separated diversity but of mutual possession."* (A.Wall, "Christian Scholarship and the Demographic Transformation of the Church") In other words, just as Christ is not reflected fully in the gifts of any one person--but only the whole church reflects him--so Christ is not reflected fully in the gifts of any one culture--but only the whole world-wide body of Christ

reflects him. In other words, only when Christians from all the different cultures come together will we really see who Christ is!

One of the first places this 'coming together' will be in the great cities of the western world. As we noted above, most non-western cities are not globalized, they tend to grow through immigration from their own heartlands and rural areas. Western cities, however, grow though immigration from all over the world. The first place that the new post-western Christianity will meet western Christianity will be in the major cities, especially New York City. London and Paris have less connection to Latin America or East Asia. Los Angeles and the U.S. west coast have small connection to Africa. Only NYC has a strong connection to every part of the emerging world Christianity. African, Chinese, Indian, newer Latinos, Caribbean people groups which are now on the rise and are supplanting the older ethnic groups of the city.

No place has a great opportunity for leaders from churches of the world to do theological reflection and education together than NYC.

GOSPEL SUMMARIES

A. A long outline of the gospel- <u>The Drama of the World in Four Acts</u>

1. Act 1 - CREATION *How things were supposed to be*
Christianity teaches that within the one God there are three persons--Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. While that can be mind-boggling, the implications of this belief for our understanding of the world is remarkable.

> **a. What ultimate reality is.** Before the world existed there was a community of persons who were inter-dependent and loving rather than independent or self-serving--there was an other-orientation in the nature of God. Friendship, relationship, belonging, love and service are thus not accidents or illusions or temporary conditions but the very essence of reality.
>
> **b. Why the world exists.** And why would God then create the world? A Trinitarian God would not need to create other beings in order to receive communications of love and adoration. He already had that! God did not create us to <u>get</u> the joy of mutual love and enjoyment, but to <u>share</u> it. It is completely consistent for a loving God who is 'other-oriented' in his very core to create a universe of beings who can share the joy and love God has himself. God created us to 'step into the circle' of loving, joyous relationship he already had within himself. We were made to serve not ourselves but God and others--this is the way he experiences glory, love, and joy, and this is how he created us to live.
>
> **c. How we were supposed to live. (1)** First, we were made for God, to know and live for him rather than ourselves. He made us and we are dependent on him for every fiber of our being--so we are his. **(2)** Second, we were made for inter-dependent community, and therefore for a deep kind of peace and well-being known in the Bible as *shalom*-peace. Human beings were not designed to live for self-interest but for the interest of others. All human beings and all beings were made for inter-dependence, inter-connection, inter-wovenness. Even the tri-personal God is inter-dependent within himself. (No one person can do without the others.) Since the unity yet diversity of the Trinity is the basis for the creation of the world, God wants the various races, classes, and nations to live together in peace and inter-dependence.
>
> **Sum:** Everything was set up so that more we lived *for* God and *for* others the happier and more fulfilled we would have been, since the world was designed to operate on the

basis of the inner life of the Trinity, to reflect the glory of that life and draw the same joy through our participation in it.

2. Act 2 - DISINTEGRATION - *How it all went wrong*

It is not too hard to see that the original, intended world never came about. But what happened, why, and what can be done about it?

a. What happened? The Bible says (and everyone knows anyway) that ordinary human behavior is to choose to live selfishly and choose our own interests over against God and others. Since we were designed to live for God and others, it only makes sense that if we determined to live for ourselves this would lead to disintegration in the fabric of the world God created (as eating fatty steak all the time it leads to disintegration in the fabric of your cardio-vascular system.) All the things that should be kept together are disintegrating and breaking down. The inner harmony and peace we were built for has been replaced by warring forces—our conscience against our desires, our reason against our passions, desire against desire. The relationships between the races, the classes, the nations, and the genders are always fracturing and erupting into hostility. We even seem to be at war with the natural environment. We abuse it, but it also abuses us. Our bodies as well as our souls are in a pattern of break-down and disintegration. It ends inevitably in death. Now, 'things fall apart.'

b. Why did it happen? When we make anything but God our ultimate joy or glory, it automatically leads us away from loving all people and creation. If the central thing in our life is our family, it will lead us to love our own relatives more than other families. If the central thing in our life is our business, or our political causes, or our nation's interests--in every case it leads us to love one group of people more than others. But if God's glory is the central thing in our life, then we are freed to love all persons and groups of people. Making other things more central and important than God, living for oneself rather than God and others--this is *sin.* Sin ruined the world as it should have been.

c. What is sin and how do we recognize it?

But what is sin? How can we get a handle on it? The very word is extremely unpopular in our culture and with good reason. It has often been used by one group to de-humanize another group, or to inflict enormous guilt, as when someone says: "we are the good people, but you are sinners." Christianity teaches the *universality* of sin, and therefore such a usage is illegitimate, but that has not stopped people from doing it! No wonder people today are wary of utilizing this term. But we cannot do without it. When we look around at the devastation in our world, we cannot conclude that this is just the result of a lack of education, good social planning, and good government (as liberal voices might say) nor just the result of a lack of self-control, strong family values, and moral training (as conservative voices might say.) So what is sin?

- **Sin is false identity.** Sin is failing to build your identity on God. It is seeking to establish a sense of self by making something else more central to your happiness, purpose, and significance than God.
    - Everyone has to get their identity--their sense of being distinct and being valuable—from something. In the 1980's movie *Rocky* the title character's girlfriend asks him why it is so important to 'go the distance' in the boxing match. "Then I'll know I'm not a bum," he replies. In the movie *Chariots of Fire* one of the main characters explains why he works so hard at running the 100 yard dash for the Olympics. He says that when each race begins, "I have 10 lonely seconds to justify my existence." The fact is that *every* person must find *some* way to 'justify their existence' to themselves and others, and to stave off the universal fear that everyone has that they may be 'a bum.'

- In more traditional cultures, the sense of worth and identity came from fulfilling duties to family and giving service to society. In our contemporary individualistic culture, we tend to look to our achievements, our social status, our talents, or our love-relationships. There are an infinite variety of identity-bases. Some get their sense of 'self' from gaining and wielding power, others from human approval, others from self-discipline and control. But everyone is building their identity on <u>some</u>thing. We have to.
- But any such identity is inherently unstable. Without God our self-esteem and sense of worth may seem to you to be solid, but it never is—it can desert you in a moment. For example, if we build our identity on being a good parent, we have no true 'self'—we are just a parent, nothing more. If something goes wrong with our children or our parenting there is no 'you' left. There is no way to avoid this insecurity outside of God. Even if you say, "I will not build *my* happiness or significance on anyone or thing," you will actually be building your identity on your personal freedom and independence. If anything threatens *that,* you will again be without a self. Even if you say, "I will build my happiness and significance on obeying all of the rules of morality and living a life of sacrificial service to others"--you still have the same insecure identity. What happens if you don't live up to your moral standards? <u>Both</u> religion (in which you build own identity on your moral achievements) <u>and</u> irreligion (in which you go your own way without regard for traditional morality) are both, ultimately, spiritually identical courses to take. Both are "sin."

- **Sin as disordered love.** Building your identity on anything but God leads automatically to internal dislocation, disorder, and enslavement. What do we mean by that?
  - When we make things that are good into things that are *ultimate* to us--when they become what makes us desirable and significant more than God--then they set the course of our lives, *they* define us, *they* are the thing to live for, *they* give us security and worth, *they* control our lives. Without them we have no worth or purpose, so we *have got* to have them. If something blocks us from getting them, we get uncontrollably angry and bitter. If something only threatens them, we get uncontrollably anxious and fearful. If we ourselves fail to achieve them, we get uncontrollably guilty, ashamed, or despondent. It is an illusion, therefore, to think that anyone is really 'free and independent.' We do not control ourselves, we are controlled by whatever we build our identity on.
  - When we turn good things (like children and parenting) into ultimate things, we are (as it were) spiritually 'addicted.' St. Augustine put if far more elegantly when he said that 'our loves are not rightly ordered.' He famously said to God that 'our hearts are restless until they find their rest in thee!' If we try to find our rest in anything else, our heart is dislocated in God and its loves are then 'out of order' and we fall into major patterns of life that are not unlike substance addiction. If we love our art, our family, our work, the causes we work for, our achievement—all good things—more than we love God, and take our meaning from them to a greater degree, then they enslave us. Usually, as in substance addiction, we cannot admit that we have God-substitutes nor the degree to which we are controlled by them. And inordinate love creates inordinate, uncontrollable emotions if anything goes wrong in our quest for them. If we lose them, we feel lost forever.
  - A classic example is Madonna's interview in Vogue magazine, in which she said, "All of my will has always been to conquer a fear of being mediocre. I push by one spell of it and discover myself as a special human being, and then I get to another stage and think I'm …uninteresting. Because even when I've become somebody, I still have to prove I'm <u>some</u>body. My struggle probably will never end." So 'success' in life and love is no escape from the inner enslavement and

disorder that comes from building your life on anything but God. But this is only the main internal effect of sin. There is an external effect of sin as well.

- **Sin as exclusion.** When we build our identity on any particular factor, and feel significant because we have it, then by definition it makes us despise those who do not have or have not achieved our identity-factor.
  - If we get any identity from being politically liberal--"the people who work for more just distribution of wealth"—we cannot avoid feeling in some ways superior to those political conservatives who oppose us. If you are somewhat relativistic, you are extremely indignant over people you think are bigots. If you are a very moral person, you are extremely indignant over people you think are licentious.
  - In other words, human identity always creates 'the Other.' If we are OK because we are X, then anyone who is non-X is not OK. If the identity-factor ("X") that we have chose gives us any sense that we are significant and good, then those without it or especially who oppose it are *bad.* So we exclude people who are the Other.
  - Exclusion occurs when you see 'the Other' as someone who you cannot identify yourself with them at all—you cannot begin to fathom why they do what they do. *Every* kind of identity—pride in your race, your politics, or even in your open-mindedness and lack of principle (!)—leads you to despise and feel superior to *some*one. Lauren Slater in a recent *New York Times Magazine* article showed that there is empirical evidence that people with 'high self-esteem' are more likely to be cruel to others!
  - Exclusion takes several forms. We may expel them and simply send them away or avoid them completely. We may try to assimilate them, forcing them to be just like us. Or ultimately we may subjugate them and overtly try to control and harm them. In every case, the ordinary bonds of community—of giving and receiving in mutuality—are cut. So racism, class-ism, sexism, and homophobia are not simply a matter of ignorance, of a lack of education. Foucault and others in our time have shown it is far, far harder than we think to have an self-identity that doesn't lead to exclusion. Our world and cultures are all being torn apart by our disordered hearts, wracked by inordinate desires for things that control us, that lead us to feel superior and exclude those without them, and that fail to satisfy us even when we get them.

d. What can put it right? The French author Simone Weil recognized the problem and laid out it's solution years ago. She wrote: *"To empty ourselves of our false divinity, to deny ourselves, to give up being the center of the world in imagination, to discern that all points in the world are <u>equally</u> centers and that the true center is outside the world…Such consent is love. The face of this love, which is turned toward thinking persons, is the love of our neighbor."* What does she mean?

At first sight, she seems to be saying, 'become religious and spiritual,' but we know that often it is the <u>most</u> religious and moral people who are the very worst at the sin of exclusion. Why would that be? Because building your life on morality and religion is not really building identity on God and his love, but is just one more effort to earn one's own significance through your record and performance. In all your religiosity, you are still trying to create an identity by your own achievement. You are building your worth on your religion—and this automatically leads you to feel superior to those who do not have your religion or moral fortitude. Even, then, the most religious person has what Weil called *"a false sense of divinity."* They are, as it were, trying to be their own Saviors. They are trying to create and "earn" their own identity and worth through their own efforts. And so even (or maybe especially) moral people are building their identity on things besides God, which leads them internally to anxiety, insecurity, and anger and externally to marginalize, oppress, and exclude others.

3. Act 3 - LIBERATION- *The great Intervention*

The story could have ended here. God did not have to make the world. He 'made room' in himself for the universe as an act of love and self-giving. Our being—all *being* apart from God's own—is a gift. When we began to abuse and ruin what God made for us out of his own free generosity, he would have been perfectly justified in taking *being* back, and that would have been the end of the story. But that would have been an unhappy ending, and God graciously willed to have our story end in joy. God promises to intervene in the world in order to redeem his world. But how?

a. Christmas salvation. As the later Psalms hint, and as the prophet Isaiah predicts things are so bad that the world will only be put right is if God himself returns to time and space to put things right. This is the meaning of Christmas. The New Testament tells us that God entered history in Jesus Christ. As C.S.Lewis put it, this was the 'good invasion,' an invasion for liberation, as when the Allies invaded France on D-day. Jesus has opened a cleft in 'the pitiless walls of the world,' breaking through the solid concrete wall between our real world and the ideal world where good always triumphs over evil, love conquers all, and death is banished forever.

b. Good Friday salvation. On the cross, Jesus atoned for our sins so we could be accepted by God. But why does Jesus have to die in order for us to be re-united with God? *Why can't God just forgive us?*

The answer is that no one can "just" forgive <u>any</u> serious wrong. If someone has betrayed you deeply and caused great harm to you, there is an indelible, unavoidable sense that this wrong cannot just be shrugged off dismissed or ignored. There is a deep sense that this is a debt, this person is liable, this person *owes* and is now in a condition of obligation. Once you realize that, there are only two things to do about it:

1) You can make them pay. You can seek revenge and cause pain until you feel the debt is gone.
2) On the other hand, you can forgive, and how do you forgive them? Forgiveness means refusing vengeful actions when you deeply want to make them pay for what they did. It means refusing to 'run them down' to others when you deeply want to slice up and ruin their reputation. It means even refusing thoughts of ill-will and rather turning your thoughts to pity and hope for their change. And as time goes on--if you stay this course, the anger will go away and the forgiveness is complete. But as anyone knows who has ever tried it--this is extremely painful, costly, and agonizing.

Now these are the only two options. If you seek revenge you make <u>them</u> suffer, then evil spreads. It spreads to you (making you hard and angry) and to others (bringing about more strife and cycles of revenge.) Or on the other hand if you seek forgiveness <u>you</u> suffer. But then evil is defeated. You eventually become humbler, wiser, deeper, more compassionate and peace spreads.

In summary, there is no way to deal with deep wrong and injustice without suffering, and <u>all</u> forgiveness is a form of voluntary suffering. There is no middle ground. Either you can make the perpetrator pay down the debt you feel (as you take it out of his hide in vengeance!) in which case evil wins--or <u>you</u> will absorb the debt yourself. It is the same in the economic realm as in the psychological realm. If someone knocks over your $100 lamp and says, "I'm so sorry" and you say "forget it!" you have forgiven them. But the $100 debt does not vanish into thin air. Either you make them pay it or you absorb it yourself (by buying a new lamp or going without light in that corner.) So we see this principle—that when a serious wrong is committed, there is a "debt" that cannot be

ignored or dismissed but must be dealt with, and that it must be dealt with through suffering.

Now, if we see this principle at our human level—that only way to defeat evil is through forgiveness that entails suffering—why are we surprised when we hear God telling us it is the same with him? If when we are wronged we sense a debt cannot be just willed away, that must be paid for with suffering--how much more is God unable to just dismiss the enormous debt of human beings' sin against one another and against the creation and against God himself. Either there must be judgment so that we suffer, or there must be forgiveness so God must suffer! There is no middle way. He cannot "just forgive" either. On the cross, God paid the debt himself. There we see at the spiritual and cosmic level what we know unavoidably at the psychological and relational level. (And since he made us it only makes sense that there would be a strong echo of his nature in us!)

c. Easter salvation. Jesus did not only die--he was raised bodily from the grave. This is what Easter is about. What does this mean?

- First, the resurrection means that the debt of sin Jesus paid is *completely*. Jesus' Jewish followers would never have believed that the death of a mere mortal could atone for sin, but the resurrection demonstrated a) this was the Son of God, and b) the debt is now completely paid. (You are not let out of prison until the entire penalty has been fulfilled.)
- Second, the resurrection means that Jesus is not only the Savior that takes away the penalty of sin, but he is the risen Lord and King who takes away the *power* of sin which creates the brokenness in our lives and society.
    - The religious leaders of Jesus' day knew quite well of the prediction that a *"Messiah"*—an anointed prince from David's line--would rise up and take the kingship of the people and 'put things right.' Many also knew of the prediction of the prophets that on some future "Day of the Lord" God would put down *all* evil and injustice and even death itself would be banished and the righteous would be bodily raised from the dead. When God returned fully into time and space as King, the world would become a Garden of Eden again. So spoke the prophets. But this hope of the future coming of the 'kingdom of God' seemed far off and remote.
    - Then Jesus came, and claimed the title "Son of David" and "Messiah" He claimed that in him, the future kingdom of God *had* come! But this proclamation could not have been more confusing and incongruous to the religious authorities of the time. Instead of reaching out to the strong and moral in order to form powerful alliances and coalitions, he reached out to lepers, women, the poor, common people, and religious "sinners"—those that the world considered outcasts, losers, and worse. And instead of leading a revolt, Jesus taught that the climax of his career would be his execution! The kingdom-salvation *he* would bring (he said) would come *not* through strength and accruing power but through weakness, service, and giving away power. And if that is how his salvation is accomplished, that is also (he says) how it must be received. You can't be saved through Jesus by claiming to be religious, moral, respectable, but by admitting your weakness, your moral inadequacy, and your need for grace. None of this made any sense to the 'powers that be,' the moral and religious leaders of the time. It seemed to radically subvert the importance of the law, the temple, and the religious establishment.
    - So Jesus was arrested, tried for insurrection, and killed. But after his death hundreds of people saw Jesus alive, raised bodily from the dead. He was not resuscitated to die again (like Lazarus and others who had experienced miraculous healings) but raised into a whole new state in which death and

decay was utterly banished. So he was not just 'spiritually' alive. He was not *less* physical but *more* physical and than anyone had ever been. He could be touched, embraced, he could eat—but nothing could harm him now. To his Jewish followers—who understood that the resurrection of the dead was the sign of the renewal of all things—this could only mean one thing, The future kingdom of God was here in a way no one had looked for. Jesus had already entered the future realm in which all the world would be cleansed of its decay and disintegration. And yet, death, decay, and injustice was still pervaded everywhere. The kingdom of God, then, was coming in two stages. It was here powerfully but partially, really but not fully. This was a revolutionary new concept that swept through all those who saw the risen Christ. By faith in the risen Christ the healing power of kingdom of God could begin in you and work through you—until the last great day when Jesus returns to finish the job.

- So what is the kingdom of God that Jesus brings through his cross and resurrection?
  - First, it is a *power.* We have seen that when we serve ourselves rather than God it leads to the 'unraveling' of the fabric of creation, spiritually, psychologically, socially, physically. Despair, broken families, hatred and strife, war, poverty, addiction, racism, disease, and death itself are all the results of this disintegration. The kingdom, then, is the re-entry into the world of God's ruling power that will eventually heal and 're-weave' all of creation back together in every aspect. Now, Jesus' sacrificial love for me is the new basis for my identity. It assures me of God's acceptance *apart* from my performance. Those who finally understand that they can be saved by sheer grace through Christ stop seeking 'salvation' (e.g. identity, emotional fulfillment, or the meriting of God's blessing) any longer through human power, status and achievement. That destroys the power of such things in their lives. Things that used to 'drive' me because they were 'ultimate things'--pseudo-salvations--no longer drive me. To the degree I live my life based on Jesus' salvation instead of some 'self-salvation', the Spirit reweaves and heals me to some degree (partially, since the kingdom is not yet here fully.)
  - Second it is a *reversal of values,* both because of the way Jesus' salvation is accomplished and received. We are saved by grace, not by pedigree, status, recognition, or achievement. Other identities--based on right performance, morality, blood-lines, nationality--lead necessarily to despise others. But a Christian says: "I am loved because when I was believing all the wrong things, Jesus came and entered into my reality, took on the weakness of my human nature, radically re-adjusted his life for me, and died for me." A Christian's self worth is based on the one who *was* excluded for us—Jesus was socially and spiritually cast out. Christians do not need to feel superior to other classes or races in order to have a strong identity. They no longer envy or resent those 'above' them socially nor despise those 'below' them. They no longer are driven by the desire for them nor the fear of losing them. Racial and class superiority, accrual of money and power at the expense of others, yearning for popularity and recognition--these normal marks of human life--the opposite of the mindset of those who have understood and experienced Christ's salvation. Christ creates a whole new order of life.
  - As a result of all this, becoming a Christian is not simply to enter a new personal, individual relationship with God, but also to enter a 'kingdom community'—a counter-culture—the church--that gives a foretaste of what future kingdom will look like. As one writer put it: *"The local congregation... stands not primarily as the promoter of programs for social change (although it will be that) but as itself the foretaste of a different social order. Its actions for justice and peace will be, and will be seen to be, the overflow of a life in Christ,*

where God's justice and God's peace are already an experienced treasure." It models what every aspect of human life will look like—family life, business practices, economic sharing, race relations, art and culture—will look like when peoples heart-loves are re-ordered and the need to exclude is healed by Christ.

Act 4 – RE-CREATION – *A New World Coming*

At the end of the account of the "Fall" in Genesis 3, God does not remove the 'breath of life' from Adam and Eve, but rather banishes them, with a cryptic promise that one of the woman's offspring will conquer evil at its sources. God's plan for the world *will* end in joy-a 'happy ending.' What will that future world be like?

a. Like good story tellers, the Biblical writers only give us the most exciting hints, which inflame our appetite for it. It will be a "new heavens and a new earth." At the end of the final book of the Bible, we see the very opposite of what other religions predict. We do not see the illusion of the world melt away (as is conceived by Eastern thought) nor do we see spiritual souls rising up to escape the physical world into heaven. Rather, we see heaven *descending* into our world to unite with it and purify it of all its brokenness and imperfection. The prophet Isaiah depicts this as a new Garden of Eden, in which there is again absolute harmony of humanity with the nature and the end of any injury, disease, or death, along with the end of all racial animosity and war (Isaiah 11.) There will be no more poor, slaves, criminals, slaves, or broken-hearted mourners (Isaiah 61.) The glory of the Lord will do this (Isaiah 35:1-2.)

b. Jesus says that when he returns to take up his throne, it will bring about the *renewal of all things* (Matthew 19:28.) The word uses here is the Greek word *"palingenesia"* –the re-genesis of the world. Some of the Greek philosophers had believed that history was cyclical, not linear, an endless downward progression. But at the end of every epoch the entire universe was purged in a giant conflagration, and then the historical cycle would begin again. Here, however, Jesus speaks of *the palingenesia*! His claim is astonishing. There will *is* one final climax to history, in which all that is wrong with the world will be purged away once and for all. His kingship is the 'fire' powerful enough to do this. His royal love will destroy only evil and under it all the potentialities in creation, latent until then, will explode into fullness and beauty. Compared to what we will be then, we are now only vegetables. Before his face even the trees will sing and dance (Psalm 66, 96.)

c. God plans a 'happy' ending for the world-story. That does not mean, of course, that it is all a happy *story,* only that the ending will be so great and joyous that it ending will engulf and 'take up' the evil and suffering into it (as the resurrection takes up the cross and makes it moving not just tragic) so that even the evil will only serve to make the final world more wonderful for once having been broken. This is the ultimate defeat of evil. God won't just give us an incredibly joyous world despite evil, but somehow it will be even greater through it.

Doestoevsky says this in *The Brothers Karamazov: " I believe that suffering will be healed and made up for, that all the humiliating absurdity of human contradictions will vanish like a pitiful mirage, the despicable fabrication of the impotent and infinitely small Euclidian mind of man, that in the world's finale, at the moment of eternal harmony, God will bring to pass something so precious that it will suffice for all hearts, for the comforting of all resentments, for the atonement of all the crimes of humanity, of all the blood they've shed; that it will make it not only possible to forgive but to justify all that has happened with men."*

Near the end of *The Lord of the Rings* one of the main characters, Sam Gamgee, says: "I thought you were dead! But then I thought I was dead. *Is everything sad going to come*

untrue?" If you ask Jesus this question about the world, the answer is "Yes! You thought you were dead, and you thought I was dead, but everything that has been sad is going to come untrue, and even be all the greater for having once been sad." The end of the world will be somehow even richer than if there had been no bravery, no sacrificial love, no cross, no salvation.

This is the Drama of the World in four acts--according to Jesus. And it provides the most powerful possible hope for human life. Some world-views teach that once we die we rot and that when the sun dies the world will be as if it had never existed. Many others teach that the soul will survive in a bodiless eternity. But Christianity teaches that this world *matters*. God is against disease, conflict, poverty, suffering and is going to put an end to them. This is nothing less than revolutionary. It keeps Christians from being either utopian or disillusioned about the world, either naïve or cynical. We neither put our hopes fully in any human system as an antidote to the world's problems, but neither can we sit back and accept the world as it is. We know God himself was willing become enmeshed in the suffering and agony of this world in order to renew and redeem it. We cannot therefore be passive ourselves. Christians have a hope that not only assures them that their battle against evil and suffering will succeed, but a hope that will enable them to face death gladly rather than give in to them. There is nothing quite like the life that flows out of an embrace of this Story—that the Jesus, the King, returned in weakness and will return in power, so that everything sad will come untrue.

B. Two shorter ones.

The Fabric of the World (More emphasis on the corporate aspect of salvation.)
God himself is a community of persons who perfectly love and defer to one another. God made us also for the joy of community and relationships--designing us to love and serve him (primarily) and others, and to care for and enjoy the material world. But we turned away to be our masters. As we sought freedom from him the fabric of all things--all the interwoven psychological, spiritual, social, and physical unities that existed under God--began to unravel and break down. Disease, death, alienation, emptiness, hatred, meaninglessness, injustice, poverty, war and strife dominated our existence and no one could discover a cure though we turned to morality, religion, empire, and science. Things now fall apart.

Though he could have abandoned the world God promised to return. He returned the first time when Jesus Christ was born. To everyone's surprise he did not come with economic and political power but to die on the cross to pay our debt and open the way for forgiveness. Jesus' dying on the cross in sacrificial service convicts us of our own self-centeredness and turns our hearts to him. And Jesus dying on the cross in payment of the debt we owe opens the way for a just God to accept us and proceed to destroy the evil of the world without destroying us. Jesus' first coming opens the way for the Spirit of God to begin renewing us--putting us back together again spiritually, psychologically, and socially. He begins a new community--the church--that gives the world a foretastes of the kind of love and unity and healing that is possible under his healing rule.

God is not removing us from the material world into an ethereal heaven, but rather is eventually bringing heaven down into the world to purify it and make it a paradise again. That is the ultimate goal of Jesus' salvation. That is one of the reasons we fight against hunger, disease, poverty, and injustice because it is also the goal of God's salvation to remove them. Also, the future world will contain a joy so great that it we will see that even the evil and suffering of history has only served to make the final glory even greater than it otherwise would have been.

When Jesus returns the second time, at the end of history, all the hopes of the human heart will be surpassed. All death, suffering, injustice, disease, and pain will be taken away. Those who have begun to experience the partial but real spiritual re-weaving of the new birth in

Christ live with full assurance of the final and ultimate Spring-time when the world is renewed, and *"everything sad will become untrue."*

The Recovered Identity (More emphasis on the individual aspect of salvation.)

1. Created for community.
God created us to love and serve him and others. But we determined not to defer to God or others and became deeply self-centered, seeking not service but control of God and others. So God made us for a love-relationship--but he lost us.

2. Sin as false identity.
(In order to stay in control of our own lives we seek to find our significance and security in something besides God. Since we are fundamentally made for worship of God, we had to worship and adore *some*thing as the basis of our purpose and significance.) In traditional societies we build out identity on the prospects of our family, clan, and tribe. In western society we build our identity on our individual achievements, recognition, and approval. But when we build our identity on something other than God--whether it be career, possessions, appearance, romance, peer groups, achievement, good causes, moral character, religion, marriage, children, friendships, or a combination of a several--this leads:

a) Internally, to personal instability and enslavement. The things we live for enslave us with guilt (if we fail to attain them) or anger (if someone blocks them from us) or fear (if they are threatened) or drivenness (since we must have them) or despair (if we ever lose them completely).

b) Externally, to social and cultural exclusion and oppression.. If we are desperately trying to get our identity out being a member of our class or party or people or culture, we tend to 'demonize' the 'other'.

[Optional addendum: This means, then a) Even the most irreligious people are really worshipping something. Whatever thing or things from which we choose to derive our value become the ultimate meaning in our lives--thus it serves as a 'god' and a gives us a sense of worth or 'righteousness' even if we don't think in those terms. Something is "Lord of our lives". People who want to be popularity are controlled by approval. People who want power are controlled by money and politics. But we do not control ourselves. b) Even the most religious people may not really be relying on God. Religious people may look to God as Helper, Teacher, and Example, but it is their moral performance which is serving as their Savior. They are just as guilty and self-hating if they fail it, just as angry and resentful if someone blocks it, just as fearful and anxious if something threatens it, just as driven "to be good". **Sum:** So both religious and irreligious people are avoiding God as Savior and Lord--but in different ways. Both are seeking to keep control of their own lives by looking to something besides God as their salvation.

3. Jesus restores the unity**.** Imagine your spouse has left you and has gone so wrong she (or he) is a drug-addicted criminal, on the run from the law. How do you get him or her back? Here's how God did it.

a) First, there is a legal barrier. He or she is 'in trouble with the law.' Jesus died on the cross to be the great Forgiver. Forgiveness after a wrong is always 'expensive' and painful. On the cross we see God paying our debt for what we have done. This means God can accept us despite our record.

b) Second, there is a personal barrier. He or she is addicted. Jesus died on the cross to be the great Healer. His sacrificial love shows us we have value to God apart from our achievement, pedigree or status--it is by grace. This frees us from the powers that bind us. We can enjoy family, money, etc--but they no longer serve as ultimate things. We are freed from them. There is only one Master, however, who can *forgive* (none of the rest ever will), and who is *last* (none of the rest ever can). Neither failure on our part nor

the circumstances of life can separate us from Him. Thus only in service to Him will we find freedom.

4. Faith's new liberty .
When we believe and rely on Jesus' work and record (rather than ours) for our relationship to God, his healing kingdom power comes upon us and begins to work through us. Christ gives us a radically new identity, freeing us from both self-righteousness and self-condemnation. He liberates us to accept people we once excluded, and to break the bondage of things (even good things) that once drove us. In particular, the gospel makes us welcoming and respectful toward those who do not share our beliefs. He puts us into a new community of people which gives a partial but real foretaste of the healing of the world that God will accomplish when Jesus returns.

TOPICS FOR TRAINING

Gospel and Life- Course 1 (Belief) FAITH Believing - Prophetic

1 - The Gospel
2 - The Glory of God
3 - Our Sin
4 - The Incarnation
5 - The Cross
6 - Idolatry
7 - The Kingdom
8 - The Church
9 - The Bible
10 - The City

Gospel and Life- Course 2 (Practice) LOVE Doing - Kingly

1 - Prayer
2 - Worship
3 - Community
4 - Justice
5- Witness
6 - Forgiveness
7 - Money
8- Family
9- Sexuality
10 - Work

Gospel Christianity - Course 3 (Character) HOPE Being -Priestly

1 - Discipleship
2 - Growth
3 - Friendship
4 - Contentment
5 - Humility
6 - Self-Control
7 - Suffering
8 - Tolerance
9 - Integrity
10 - Guidance

Week 3 – Urban Ministry II **Tim Keller**

I. GLOBALIZATION AND THE CITY.

A. The rise of post-western Christianity.

1. The pattern of Christian expansion.
Christianity has not grown like any of the other religions. For example, Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam are all still demographically centered on their land and people-group of origin. That is, the lands that began as Hindu, Buddhist, and Islamic have stayed so and thus each religion remains dominated by its original people group--Indian, or Asian, or Arabic/Middle Eastern. Of all the major world religions, Christianity alone is quite different. The original center of Islam was and still is Mecca. But the original center of Christianity, Jerusalem, is no longer that. What is the Christian pattern of expansion?

At first, Christianity was centered on Jerusalem but within a century, the center of Christianity was the Hellenistic world of the Mediterranean. That was the center for several centuries, but as the Roman empire collapsed the barbarians of Northern and Western Europe became the new center. Europe was the center of Christianity for many years, though one might say that over the last couple of centuries North America took that role. Now however Christianity is losing influence in Europe and only holding its own in North America, but it is growing at 7 to 10 times the rate of the population in the parts of the world growing the fastest--Africa, Latin America, and Asia. Already more Christians live south of the equator than north of the equator. The centuries of Christian institutions and the greater financial resources of the West continue to give the churches of the west dominance despite their dwindling numbers. But over the next few decades and century increasingly the centers of theological reflection and training as well as the centers of ministry and of the most influential churches will be outside the West.

So this is the pattern: Christianity always flourishes better away from its own center, at or beyond its periphery, among people who are excluded from power. It tends to weaken at its own center and renew itself at its margins. This means:

> **a)** Christianity is the only truly multi-cultural religion. It is the only religion that has truly been owned and operated by a series of different racial/cultural groups. And on a related note, we can say--
>
> **b)** Ultimately no one people group owns the Christian faith. Lamin Sanneh puts it in the form of a rhetorical question of his book-title, *Whose Religion Is Christianity?* His point is that Christianity can*not* be seen as primarily or only a Western religion, any more than it was primarily a Hellenistic religion or a Jewish sect. As Andrew Wall says *"That is, there is no 'Christian culture' the way there is an 'Islamic culture' which you can recognize from Pakistan to Tunisia to Morocco."* ("The Expansion of Christianity: An Interview with Andrew Walls" *Christian Century,* August 2-9, 2000, p.792)

2. The magnitude of the Christian expansion.
The Phillip Jenkins "The Next Christianity" (*The Atlantic*) *The Next Christendom* (Oxford Press) was the first scholar to get media attention for this phenomenon, though Andrew F. Walls and others had been writing about it for a couple of decades. It is arguably the event that will have the most impact on the history of the world over the next century.

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Some interesting details in order to put things in perspective (the following are from Jenkins and Sanneh):

- Only 5% of the world's Catholics now life in North America, and only 10% of the world's Anglicans in North America and the Great Britain combined. (from Jenkins)
- In 1900 Africa had 8.7 million Christians, about 9% of the total population of 107.9 million, and most of these were Coptic and Ethiopian Christians. By contrast Muslims in Africa were 34.5 million strong and outnumbered Christians more than 4 to 1. By 1970 there were 120 million Christians. Today there are 370 million Christians, about 45% of the total population of 840 million. The Christians now are just about equal in size with Muslims and all projections are that Christianity will grow to over 600 million within 25 years and comprise over 60% of the African population.
- The size of the church in China is notoriously hard to count. The Communist government's official estimates are no more than 15 million, but it only officially recognizes a certain number of registered churches called the "Three Self Patriotic Movement" and ignores the millions of house churches. High estimates are 80-90 million Christians in China, out of the 1.28 billion population (5-7%). However, there is consensus that something much like the African 'explosion' of Christian faith is happening in China. Even the Three-Self movement acknowledges enormous growth statistics of 20% or more over the last couple of years. Many predict that by 2050 the Christian population in China could approach 400 million.
- By the year 2050 there will be 500 million Buddhists in the world, but there will be 1 billion Pentecostals alone (!) and probably 1.4 billion Catholics, to say nothing of other Protestants and Orthodox churches. Pentecostals alone will equal the number of Hindus in the world. And all Christians will continue to outnumber Muslims by 2 to 1. (See Jenkins)

3. The nature of post-western Christianity.

a. Post-western Christianity. Lamin Sanneh uses the terms "world Christianity" and "global Christianity" to refer to two somewhat different movements. "World Christianity" is the faith as it takes shape in a new society that expresses itself through the cultures, customs, and traditions of the people. (p.22) "Global Christianity" is a term he uses to describe the replication in other countries of forms of Christianity forged in Europe.

How it has emerged. How does 'post-western' world Christianity emerge?

- Both Andrew Wall and Lesslie Newbigin describe the stages that a new culture goes through as it receives Christianity. At first the converts receive the faith in a form fairly close to the form of the faith in the missionary's home culture. As the converts read the Bible after a time they come to see things in the Word that the missionaries 'played down' (like exorcisms) and other things they 'played up' in accordance with their own cultural perspectives and biases. This may lead to a time of *over*-reaction against the missionaries' form of faith in which they try to purge themselves of any feature of 'western' Christianity at all. Eventually the converts come to terms with their own cultures and traditions--rejecting parts of it, affirming parts of it, and modifying parts of it all in light of their reading of the Scriptures.
- How does this happen? Here is an over-simplified answer, based on the writings of Wall:

  (1) Unlike Islam and other religions, Christianity has an incarnate God, a God who comes to express himself in our own flesh. Jesus was both a 'prisoner' of our humanity (it limited him in many ways) yet a 'liberator' of our humanity.

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(2) In Acts 15 the leaders of the earliest church, the Jerusalem Christian community, concluded that the Gentiles could enter the new Israel without becoming Jews. *"Though circumcised, Torah-keeping Jews themselves, they recognized that Gentile believers in the Messiah could enter Israel without becoming Jews. They were converts, not proselytes....It is hardly possible to exaggerate the importance of this early controversy and its outcome; it is a pivot on which Christian history turns...for it built the principle of cultural diversity into Christianity in perpetuity."* (A.Walls, quoted by Mark Gornik in his unpublished paper "Andrew Walls on the Changing Church and Missions") In principle the church has always been multi-cultural. Today it is finally realizing what it has always been in principle.

Note: to Walls a 'proselyte' is someone who has simply adopted someone else's culture. A 'convert' is someone who has appropriated Christ into one's *own* thought, life, and culture where it makes radical changes but nonetheless expresses itself.

(3) This is why we believe in translating the Word of God into the languages of the hearers. Islam does not believe the Koran can really be translated. You must learn Arabic (and therefore Arabic thought forms and culture) in order to hear God's word. It makes sense that Muslims don't believe God's word is translatable. To use the words of a new language is always to use the concepts of that language's culture. For example, the word 'God' exists in every culture, but it is tied to the traditions of that culture's non-Christian past. So to translate holy writings into a new language is both to correct <u>and</u> connect to that culture's traditions. It <u>corrects</u> because the 'God' of the Bible does not act like the 'God' of that culture's past. And yet the very use of the word causes people to see ways that God was working in their own cultural past before they knew of Christ.

- For example, Paul's use of the Hellenistic idea of *pleroma* ("fullness") and John's use of the word *logos* ("reason" or "Word") connects to the Greek pagan past automatically. Their use of the words says to readers something like: "the aspirations of your ancestors and people for wisdom is now found in Christ.
- For example, 20th century Africans had a long tradition of belief in a supernatural world of good and evil spirits. Their tribal religions, however, were proving inadequate to really help people overcome the evil they saw around them--personal, social, political, spiritual. This was particularly true in the social breakdowns that have occurred in Africa since the end of colonial rule after World War II. But what alternatives did Africans have? There was western secularism (with its disdain of the supernatural) and Islam (with its disdain of the African past). When Africans began to read the Bible in their own languages, with their own traditional words for God used in the text, they began to see in Christ the final solution to their own historic longings and aspirations as Africans.

  The old [African] religions provided the rules, rewarding good conduct and punishing wrong, but they had only a limited ethical range....Christianity answered this historical challenge by a reorientation of the world-view....People sensed in their hearts that Jesus <u>did not mock their respect for the sacred nor their clamor for an invincible Savior</u>, and so they beat their sacred drums for him until the stars skipped and danced in the skies. After that dance the stars weren't little anymore. Christianity helped Africans to become renewed Africans, not re-made Europeans. (Sanneh, p. 43)

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(4) Something like that is happening in China. While the Africans realize that Christianity (rather than the alternatives of Islam, tribal animism, or western secularism) is the best way to honor their own African-ness (rather than Confucianism, Communism, and western secularism) so the Chinese are coming to realize that Christianity is the best way to honor their own Chinese-ness, their historic aspirations and character as a people. Every form of Christianity is 'imprisoned' in a culture (somewhat limited by it) but at the same time is its liberator, transforming and purifying it with the gospel.

c. It is quite right to worry about <u>syncretism</u>, which is the corruption and over-adaptation of Christianity to a culture. (Syncretism is 'selling out' some gospel distinctives in order to make Christianity palatable to a new society.) But if a 'sender' won't adapt Christianity at all to a new 'receptor' culture that means you have wedded Christianity too close to *your* culture. It means you have turned your own culture's incarnation of the faith into a absolutely universal form of Christianity. You don't see that the Christianity of your heart is partially a 'prisoner'--is limited and adapted to your culture.

Lamin Sanneh (drawing on Wall) defines conversion as *"turning of our selves to God, and that means all of ourselves without leaving anything behind or outside. But that also means not replacing what is there with something else. Conversion is a re-focusing of the mental life and its cultural/social underpinning and of our feelings, affections, and instincts, in the light of what God has done in Jesus."* (Sanneh, p.43-44.) This is quite helpful. When Africans become a Christian, their African-ness is <u>converted</u> it is not <u>replaced</u> with Chinese-ness or European-ness. Along the same lines, Miraslov Volf insists every Christian must get distance from his or her home culture through Christ, yet not 'arrive' in some other culture in order to be Christian. African believers must get distance enough to critique their African traditions according to the gospel and the Word, yet must also embrace and inhabit their African culture.

Summary: Contrary to popular opinion, Christianity is not a western religion. It is not the creation or result of any particular culture, but it is the result of the Spirit re-creating Christianity in the soil of each and every culture. Christians are Christians first, and Europeans or Asians or Africans second. But Christianity does not make Africans into Europeans. Christianity *completes* and fulfills Europeans, Asians, and Africans as themselves, at the very same moment binding together people in Christ who previously could not unite in peace. Christian conversion is the trans-cultural work of the Spirit of God, incarnating the gospel in every culture, bringing down the barriers that have divided the human race.

b. Post-enlightenment Christianity. As we noted above, perhaps the chief characteristics of the new 'post-western world Christianity' is that it did not make its peace with the Enlightenment the way western Christianity did. This is one of the main differences between it and western churches.

- Both liberal and conservative Christian theology have been profoundly effected by the Enlightenment, which assumes there is an extremely firm line between the empirical time-space world and the spiritual world. Liberal Christianity essentially believes the line is completely firm. It uses historical criticism on the Bible that denies the miraculous elements as necessarily 'legendary'. It re-interprets the deity and resurrection of Christ as 'symbols' only. But conservative Christian theology, while fervently defending miraculous events in Biblical times, is extremely skeptical of the supernatural today. We believe that the line between the supernatural and the natural world was breached at several places (the incarnation, resurrection,

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Pentecost, and very rare other instances since then, perhaps.) Guidance, prayer, Christian growth--are all interpreted in very rational ways, largely as the application of sound doctrine through our minds and our wills.

- But non-western cultures did not pass through the Enlightenment in the same way. They see the line between the supernatural and the natural to be a very porous boundary--being crossed every day. Their understanding of evil is much more multi-dimensional than western people and even than western Christian. They understand that evil has a spiritual life of its own--it is not just the result of discrete actions. When non-western people read the Bible, they see that the Bible does not recognize the very strict boundary between the supernatural and the natural that western people assume.
- Ironically, Christianity is much less 'imperialistic' toward cultures than western Enlightenment-drenched secularism. Secularism is extremely disdainful of belief in miracles, healing, and demons and is uncomfortable with any religion at all.
    - *"Should we not instead be talking about goodwill among all people without regard to religious labels?"* is a typical secular western observation expressed in Lamin Sanneh's book. Sanneh responds: *"Let us talk about the expansion of goodwill among all people, but let us not make that goodwill an alternative or a rival to religion lest we become sectarian and triumphalistic in another way."* (p.33) Sanneh's point is that western culture's seeming 'tolerance' of all religions is actually a rival religion--a sectarian and triumphalistic anti-supernaturalism and individualism that will replace and mock Africans' "respect for the sacred".
    - At another place in Sanneh's book another typical western view is expressed. *"I have an objection to Bible translation as being too simplistic. It perpetuates an anachronistic, pre-scientific worldview about creation, the virgin birth, miracles, bodily resurrection, life after death, the second coming of Christ, and judgment day as literal truths."* Sanneh responds, *"You were complaining just now about missionaries using the Bible as a stealth platform to advance their own agenda. Shouldn't you, to be consistent, complain just as vehemently if we...promote the Enlightenment agenda of rationality? Because that would be stealth invasion no less....The peoples of the world have a right to come to their own view of the matter...and not accede to our [western] standards of progress."* (p.115-116Islam is just as insistent that converts take on Arabic culture. So Christianity is the least imperialistic of the world-views. That is a point Sanneh tries to make, but it is an extremely difficult point for western skeptics to recognize (or refute!)

So what is the emerging "Supernatural" Christianity? It holds

(1) the entire trustworthiness of the Bible, though they may read it more 'mystically' than we would read it--not dissecting and interpreting it but 'inhabiting' it and embodying it,
(2) the redemptive work of Jesus as the only, gracious basis for salvation, though they may see the cross more in *Christus Victor* terms of Jesus' triumph over the evil forces that bind us
(3) the historical reality of miracles, the virgin birth and incarnation, the resurrection of Jesus, though they are much more likely to believe that such miracles continue today
(4) the necessity of the supernatural work of the Spirit to convert and renew individuals, though their understanding of daily guidance and victory over sin and evil would also be considered parts of the normal work of the Spirit.
(5) the return of Jesus Christ personally and historically to renew the whole world.

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The Christianity growing in the world today is not identical to *any* western variety, but it is furthest from the mainline-liberal Christianity that was the most heavily steeped in a skepticism of the supernatural. The irony of this is that for most of the 20th century this very rationalistic version of religion was thought to be the only kind of Christianity that would grow in the future. The very liberal Bishop Spong published a book entitled *Christianity Must Change or Die* yet the very kind of Christianity he insists must change is flourishing at an enormous rate.

Another irony is that for so many years the liberal western church sought to be an advocate for the poor and the oppressed of the world. Now the very churches of the poor and the oppressed oppose the theology and policies of the dominantly liberal mainline churches (e.g. the controversy in the Anglican Communion over homosexuality.) Someone quipped, "the liberals opted for the poor, but the poor opted for born-again Christianity." While 'liberal' mainline is still enormously wealthy in Western world, with billions in assets, and therefore will not simply collapse but will continue as an institution for many years--it is nonetheless dwindling in numbers and very rapidly becoming marginal to the concerns of the world church.

4. Post-western Christianity and the future.
What are the implications for us, now, in light of this momentous development?

a. Theological education. There needs to be a significant change in theological education and reflection. We need to study not just the history of the church in the West, but the history of the church in Asia, Latin America, and Africa. Why? Non-western church history can teach us about how to deal with pluralism--something western churches have not faced in 1500 years. While European Christianity spread through the power of the nation-state (princes and rulers adopting Christian faith on behalf of their people) that has not been the situation of the post-western church in any part of the world. Also, we have much to learn from them on a) evangelism from a position of cultural marginality, b) theological reflection on the poor, c) worship and spirituality, and d) a wholistic approach to counseling the person. (This list is from Mark Gornik's paper)

b. Cooperation and mutual learning. Cooperation and mutual learning must occur across the barriers. Every culture that receives Christ contributes to our understanding of the fullness of Christ. *It would fit the postmodern fashion to say that each local Christian discourse is valid and sufficient in itself. But the church is Christ's body, and the picture we are given in the Epistle of the Ephesians of the relations of different cultural presences in the body is neither of uniformity nor of separated diversity but of mutual possession."* (A.Wall, "Christian Scholarship and the Demographic Transformation of the Church") In other words, just as Christ is not reflected fully in the gifts of any one person--but only the whole church reflects him--so Christ is not reflected fully in the gifts of any one culture--but only the whole world-wide body of Christ reflects him. In other words, only when Christians from all the different cultures come together will we really see who Christ is!

c. Urban ministry. One of the first places this 'coming together' will be in the great cities of the western world. As we noted above, most non-western cities are not globalized, they tend to grow through immigration from their own heartlands and rural areas. Western cities, however, grow though immigration from all over the world. The first place that the new post-western Christianity will meet western Christianity will be in the major cities, especially New York City. London and Paris have less connection to Latin America or East Asia. Los Angeles and the U.S. west coast have small connection

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to Africa. Only NYC has a strong connection to every part of the emerging world Christianity. African, Chinese, Indian, newer Latinos, Caribbean people groups which are now on the rise and are supplanting the older ethnic groups of the city.

No place has a great opportunity for leaders from churches of the world to do theological reflection and education together than NYC.

B. Globalization and the importance of the city.

Sources:

Saskia Sassen, *The Global City: New York, London, and Tokyo* (Princeton: 1991)
_____, *Globalization and its Discontents: Essays on the New Mobility of People and Money* (New Press, 1998)
Thomas L. Friedman, "A Manifesto for the Fast World", *New York Times Magazine,* (March 28, 1999)
J.F.Kennedy School of Government, Harvard U. "Trends in Economic and Social Globalization: Challenges and Obstacles" Spring 1999 Syllabus.
Mark Gornik, memo "What is Globalization?"

Globalization is the unprecedented mobility of people, ideas, and capital across geographical and geo-political barriers which have become almost completely porous.

1. Causes of globalization:

a. Political. The end of the "Cold War" 1) opened travel borders as the 'Iron Curtain' collapsed (enhancing the movement of people), and 2) opened huge new markets as centralized economies connected with Cold War collapsed (enhancing the movement of capital).

b. Technological. The technological revolution connects the world by phone, fax, satellite dish, wireless phones, and Internet (enhancing the movement of information).

c. Intellectual. While the relationship of social conditions to intellectual conditions is difficult and symbiotic, it appears that most of the national elites of every country and major city are educated at the same schools (Oxford, Harvard, Sorbonne) and increasingly have broken traditional ties and learned the individualism of late modernity/post-modernity (enhancing the fluidity of identities).

2. Characteristics of globalization:

a. From a Bi-polar to Multi-polar world. The old paradigm of 'power-dyads' aligned with the old East-West Cold War dichotomy is now replaced by more complex relationships between multiple poles of power. Samuel Huntingdon's thesis is that there will be several 'civilizations' locked in a series of complex conflicts for power. (Some of his 'civilizations': Orthodox, Muslim, Chinese, Hindu, U.S./Western Europe, etc.) Since 9-11 Huntingdon's thesis has received widespread acceptance. The biggest 'battles' are now not between nation-states but between cultures supported by international networks.

b. From multiple economies to an increasingly unified world economy.

- There used to be multiple working economic models, from communism, to democratic socialism, to laissez-faire capitalism. Now "neoliberal" (lightly

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controlled) consumer capitalism is virtually the only working model left in the world. No one seems to be even thinking of alternatives.
- There used to be somewhat self-contained national economies. Now huge amounts of capital from diverse places moves in and out of whole regions of the world instantly.

c. From Nation-state and national cultures to 'hyper-culture'.
- The globalization of capital means national governments are now virtually powerless to control the flow of money in and out of their own economies, thus greatly decreasing their influence in general. Multi-national corporations, based in major world cities, have the greatest influence, not national governments or national economies.
- The triumph of global capitalism means that public sectors are in general decreasing and private sectors are increasing, thus removing more people and money from the control of and dependence on governments. Again, this decreases their power.
- The technology/communication revolution means that national governments are powerless to control what their people watch or learn. (This was a major factor in the collapse of communism in Europe.)
- The world-view of 'modernity' weakens ties to tradition, tribe, and family and lifts up the individual choice and rights. Increasingly, rapidly, local cultures are being homogenized and being replaced, especially among the young with 'plural modernities', which is a blend of individualistic consumer culture, blended with Confucianism or Buddhism or Islam or Catholicism. 'Plural modernities'.

d. From Cities to City-states.
- For reasons noted above we now have the first major erosion of nation-state power in 800 years. N.Pierce: *"Great metropolitan regions--not cities, not states, not even the nation-states--are starting to emerge as the world's most influential players."*
- Sassen: The world-class cities are the location of the "brain" of the global economic system. (Sassen calls London-New York-Tokyo '*the* global city'—the economic capital of the world. Other western cities (LA-Paris) come up closely behind. Decisions about what to put on MTV, what to market--are made in the cities. Urban culture now reaches out far beyond the city limits into the suburbs and even rural areas. Kids in Iowa or even Mexico are becoming more like young adults in L.A. and New York City than they are like adults in their own locales.
- Major world cities are becoming more like one another with rapid movement of people and ideas between them.
- New class structure.
  - World-class cities produce a highly connected new elite class which is far more like the elites in other world-class cities then like the rest of their own country and culture.
  - On the other hand, the poor and working classes of the world are moving massively to western mega-cities, where economic resources and opportunities are vastly greater than in their own nations. So they cram into London-NYC-Tokyo-LA-Paris in order to become part of the new global economy.

3. The implications of globalization and non-western Christianity on mission. The implications are enormous:

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a. The Christian church must ***think of <u>cities</u> primarily for mission.*** How can we put this? Of course we need churches everywhere there are people! And it is too soon to move away from the traditional missionary concern with 'unreached people groups'—often remote tribes and other overlooked groups in rural areas. But the currents of history are going to be sweeping these people *either* 1) literally into the cities geographically, as rural economies fail to sustain older ways of life, or 2) into the cities <u>culturally</u> as technology connects younger generations to global hyper-culture. Traditional missions to 'unreached peoples' may be aiming at a world that will be gone in another 20 years. **Case study:** "My kids raised by my parents" as technology makes African and Asian kids like their U.S. counterparts. If you go to the cities, you will be able to reach the remnants of each culture still outside it. But if you go to the outside, you will never reach the growing edge of the culture inside it.

It may be helpful to those who harbor misgivings about cities...to reflect on the fact that urbanization as a present fact of life for most of the human family is a reality under the providential control of God. In Acts 17:26-27 the apostle Paul observes: "...he determined the times set for them and <u>the exact places where they should live</u>. God did this so men would seek him and perhaps reach out for him and find him. Viewed in light of these verses, city growth is not something to be perceived as entirely the work of the devil, but as part of God's providential plan in history. God's redemptive purpose behind urban growth is that 'men should seek him and reach out for him'. By means of these enormous gatherings of people, God provides the church with one of history's greatest opportunities for evangelization. Pressed together in metropolises, the races, tribes, and diverse people groups are geographically more accessible than ever before. In some cases the processes of change that new urbanites pass through make them more receptive to the gospel. If this is the case, world urbanization should be viewed in an eschatological as well as missionary framework. God in our time is moving climactically through a variety of social, political, and economic factors to bring earth's peoples into closer contact with one another, into greater interaction and interdependence, and into earshot of the gospel. By this movement God carries forward his redemptive purposes in history. A sign of our time is the city. Through worldwide migration to the city God may be setting the stage for Christian mission's greatest and perhaps final hour.[1]

b. The Christian church should ***think cities rather than this people group or that people group.*** In cities, a person's identity becomes much more complex. In non-urban areas, you can simply think of how to reach a 'people group', and this elevates the importance of the 'homogeneous unit principle' of mission. (That is, people tend to come to Christ in settings with other people like themselves.) But in cities people have multiple, overlapping commitments and social circles, thus making identity more complex. **Case study:** Asian-Americans, Asian-American churches, and Redeemer. Can the 'second generation' be reached as a people group? Or are they better reached by churches reaching 'young urban professionals'? Or, will they only be reached as we conceptualize <u>how to reach NYC</u> rather than <u>how to reach Asian Americans</u>?

c. The Christian church should ***think cities rather than 'home' and 'foreign' mission.*** Cities are becoming <u>as</u> linked or even more linked to one another than they are to their own country and society. This means, for example, a group of suburban Americans who want to reach Manila by raising support from other

[1] Roger Greenway, "World Urbanization and Missiological Education", in *Missiological Education for the Twenty-First Century: Essays in Honor of Paul Pierson* (Orbis, 1996).

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Americans and going to live in Manila are taking the very longest way around. There are no natural connections of people, information, and capital from U.S. suburbia to Manila. Rather, they should go to U.S. cities, and minister there with a City-Growth vision, and follow the organic global currents and connections to the other global cities from there. You don't reach the world now by "going over" to cities, but by "going down" into cities and "coming up" wherever the links take you. **Case Study #1:** One urban church in Queens has planted three daughter churches: one in neighboring College Point, one in the neighboring Bronx, and one in the neighboring Philippines! Why? The church reached so many Filipino immigrants in its neighborhood that the new Christians wanted to plant a daughter church among their friends and relatives in their country of origin. Each major city is now a 'portal' to most of the nations of the world. That is where they must be reached. Queens is closer to Manila than to Pennsylvania. **Case Study #2:** Increasingly churches from other nations are approaching Redeemer and asking for our help in planting churches in their biggest cities (Sao Paulo, Amsterdam, Budapest, London.) They insist that while American churches in general would not be good models for their national churches in general, they say, "what works in NYC *will* work in our biggest cities because the people in our cities are so much like the people in NYC." We will find increasingly that ministry which is effective in a world-class city has remarkably wide applicability, especially with the emerging generations.

d. The Christian church should ***think cities rather than 'evangelism' and 'social action'.*** Globalization will most definitely aggravate and widen the gap between the rich and the poor. Both the less able and the less privileged will be shut out of the new wealth and will receive most of the blows of global economic undulations. Under the pressure of being economically competitive, governments everywhere are rolling back entitlements and welfare and safety nets. Meanwhile, enormous wealth creation will seduce the new global elites into a culture of materialism. The need then will be for a) ministries among the non-elites that increasingly takes into consideration mercy and justice ministry as well as evangelism and church planting, and for b) ministries among the elites that instructs them to use their resources sacrificially for the common good. The elites will not be disciples into Christ-likeness without that emphasis. Point: We can no longer afford to concentrate only on evangelistic ministries to specific populations. There will be a "symbiosis" not only of ministries among different people groups (#2 above) but between ministries of word and deed. Thus we must think of 'City-growth' rather than just 'Church-growth'. Globalization makes the old dichotomy between 'evangelism' and 'social action' increasingly obsolete.

e. The Christian church should ***think of western cities in particular as the most receptive place for the gospel.*** In North America and Europe the cultures are becoming less and less receptive to orthodox Christianity, but the western cities are filling up with people from the parts of the world were Christianity is *growing* in credibility (Africa, the Caribbean, Latin America, Asia.) Multi-ethnic urban centers should therefore be extremely important fields for church planting and evangelism. See below part C.

SUM:

- ***Reach the city to reach both your region and 'overseas'.*** You can't reach the urban centers from the suburbs, but you can most definitely reach the suburbs from the city. Regional people-flow is from the urban center outward. Students grow up, singles get married, immigrants make money and want more space--and all of them move out from the center to the suburbs. Ministries that begin and

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thrive in the city will eventually spread all through the suburbs, following their converts out to their new neighborhoods. But ministries that begin in the suburbs only reach toward the city center with great difficulty.

- ***Reach the city to reach new generations and people groups—your <u>future</u> country.*** As we just noted, cities are magnets for new immigrants move into the cities first, students, and young professionals. There you see the people who will be prominent in the country 20-30 years from now.
- ***Reach the city to reach 'the culture'.*** As we have seen, cities more than ever influence the culture and values of the world. The single most effective way for Christians to influence the culture of a nation is to have large numbers of them stay in cities and simply "be the church" there.
- ***Reach the <u>whole</u> city to reach the world.*** As we have seen, there is no part of the city that can be neglected. First, the poor cannot be neglected, because God has always worked mightily among the urban poor. 'Word' and 'deed' ministry will have to be combined, both in ministries to Christians within the community and outside of it. The church's attitude toward and work with the poor will be a significant sign of its validity to others. Second, the immigrants--the 'nations'--cannot be neglected, because they are far more open to (and more conscious of their need for) gospel ministry than they ever were in their homeland. Third, the 'elites' cannot be neglected, because they are disproportionately powerful and must be called to use their educational, economic, and cultural power for the service of others and the Lord. The church in the city must show its concern for the *peace* of the whole city (Jer 29:7).
- ***Reach the whole city to reach your own heart with the gospel.*** In the city you'll find many things that will challenger your grasp of the gospel. You will find many people that seem 'hopeless' to you spiritually and morally. But if the gospel of grace is true, why would you think that their conversion be any more a miracle than your own? You will find people of other religions and of no religion who are wiser, kinder, and deeper than you. Even after growth in grace, lots of Christians are weaker people than lots of non-Christians. But if the gospel of grace is true, why *did* you think that Christians are basically 'better' kinds of people than non-Christians? After a while these and other examples will begin to show you that even though you may intellectually understand the doctrine of justification by faith alone, you functionally assume salvation by moral goodness and works.

  Early in Redeemer's ministry we discovered that it was not enough for Christians to feel pity or even just affection for the city. Staff and leaders had to humbly learn from and respect New York City and its people. Our relationship with the people of Manhattan had to be a consciously reciprocal one. We had to see God's 'common grace' in them. We had to learn that we needed them to fill out our own understanding of God and his grace, just as they needed us for the same. We had to be energized and enriched by the city, not just drained by it. Even Jesus so united his heart with the people he ministered to that he 'needed' their friendship (Matt.26:36-41). Ministry in the city, then, will help you grasp the gospel of grace in powerful ways. You may even come to see that you spiritually need the city more than the city needs you.

C. Case Study of Globalization and Mission: A Plan for New York City

Globalization is changing NYC and there may now be a historic opportunity to change NYC from a secular to a 'faith-filled' city. What is the opportunity and how could this happen?

1. The opportunity.

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- ***Immigration.*** Globalization is changing the ethnic/cultural face of western cities. A major wave of immigration is changing NYC from an Irish/Italian/ Jewish city into a multi-ethnic city drawn mainly from the southern and eastern hemispheres.
  - These are the areas of the world where Bible-believing orthodox Christianity is growing the fastest and is gaining in credibility----Asia (China), Latin America, Africa. People from these areas are, humanly speaking, most receptive to the gospel, and these groups bring their own indigenous Christian leaders with them.[2]. Thousands of new indigenous church leaders are streaming into the city[3]. The working-class grassroots population of the cities could become orthodox Protestant to a greater extent than has been seen in the last 100 years.
  - They will change NYC from the outside-in. As they move up in society and into the center city professional sectors over the next 2-3 generations they will come to wield great power in the areas of finance, media, and culture. This has the potential to radically change NYC spiritually.[4]

- ***Cultural power.*** As we have seen globalization only increases the city's culture-forming power. Also globalization has led to the rise of capitalism and therefore greater competition in society in general. For example, it is probably 5-10 time harder to get into Ivy League colleges today than it was 30 years ago. The competition for places in the 'elite' schools and jobs in the 'elite' cities is more fierce than ever because global capitalism has increased the spoils for the winners. For example, average household income in Greenwich and New Canaan CT went up 33% in the 90's while in inner city Bridgeport it went up 2%. In the 1960's and 70's few young people dreamed of moving into the center cities after college, now it is a widespread desire and dream.
  - Globalization has kept NYC as probably the most influential city in the world in the areas of finance, media, international relations, art and culture.[5] In general, as this city goes, so goes U.S. society.[6]
  - Another sociological change may be brewing. George Gallup's NYC lecture in early 2002 noted that: 1) non-white people groups, and 2) Americans born after 1980 show significantly more interest in spirituality in general and Christianity in particular than their older, Anglo counterparts. White elites inviting young non-whites into upper echelons of business and government will be surprised to find there will be a far greater percentage of Christian believers. And <u>all</u> young born after 1980 show more interest religion/faith than previously. (A recent study by from Univ of Pennsylvania show significantly more religious interest among teenagers than their predecessors.) Gallup predicts: As the country becomes more multi-ethnic, and as the younger generation rises up into influence, faith should become much more influential in our society. He predicted that the leaders of the coming spiritual resurgence will be especially African-Americans, the most profoundly Christian of all people-groups in the country, as well as members of the 'millennial' generation.

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[2] Phillip Jenkins, <u>*The Next Christendom*</u>, Oxford, 2002

[3] John Wilson, "New Immigrants and Old Time Religion" <u>*American Outlook*</u> (Fall, 2002)

[4] Thomas Bender <u>*New York Times*</u> (Jan 5, 2003.) Prof. Thomas Bender wrote in the *New York Times "The future of NY is in the boroughs....The proportion of immigrants in the city today roughly matches that at the turn of the century....We can expect a repetition of the cycle of immigration-transformation the city experienced between 1890 and 1950...They'll ultimately transform Manhattan--its economy and culture. We'll see new social movements, led by a new generation of leaders"*

[5] Saskia Sassen <u>*The Global City: New York, London, Tokyo*</u> 2nd ed. Princeton, 1998.

[6] cf. the principles of cultural change in James Hunter. "To Change the World", unpublished paper.

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- Intellectually, there is a growing dissatisfaction with the older secularism and rationalism. (See: Jack Miles "The De-centralization of God." in *NY Times Magazine,* Jan 1997. Gregg Easterbrook "The New Convergence" *Wired* Dec 2002) There is even a new movement away from the newer post-modern skepticism of any truth at all. (See Edward Rothstein *NYTimes* writing since 9-11. See December 2002 *Harper's* "Common Ground" calling desperately get back natural law.) Most interesting is the fact that the number of orthodox Christians in philosophy departments in this country has gone from 0% to nearly 25% in just 30 years. This means that for the first time in 80 years there is 'intellectual space' for Christians to do scholarship, art, and other cultural production. This is big news for center cities like NYC and LA.

2. The strategy.
So globalization has increased NYC's cultural power yet also provided a vast field of grassroots Christians and potential Christians among its vast working classes. What can we do about this opportunity? New York City can be changed into a faith-filled city that effects the U.S. culture if

1st, if we can produce thousands of two kinds of new churches in the cities:

- 1st kind--that can reach the enormous numbers of new immigrants and new residents who are far more open to the gospel than was either the last great wave of immigration (1880-1920), then the working-class and middle classes of the city could become in large part orthodox Christian. Eventually their second and third generations will rise up socially and educationally and move into the professions and the culture-forming venues and institutions.
- **2nd** kind--if we could also produce hundreds of 'center city' churches that would help all the new professionals learn how to operate as Christians in a secular, pluralistic culture, then the cultural-apparatus of the city could be used for 'kingdom values' and actually change our whole society.
    - If individuals come out of the first generation immigrant churches and just go to college and get jobs there will be little cultural change because: a) enormous pressure within society to seal off one's faith from one's work and b) cluelessness of churches to know how to help and support people in secular work.
    - The secularizing effect of our educational system and popular culture will erode distinctive Christian belief and work unless there is an enormous increase in both student ministries and churches that evangelize and disciple secular professionals. We must plant scores of new churches that reach professionals working in the city and disciple them for distinctive Christian service in society and culture.

2nd if we produce new networks and institutions for cultural production and renewal. Christians must be united in a great variety of associations that promote Christian thinking and work in every field. Culture is changed not simply through the accumulation of changed lives, but by Christians uniting to work across vocational fields (e.g. academia, business, the arts, media) in strategic culture producing-centers such as New York City.

3. THE CHURCH PLANTING STRATEGY

a. New Churches - The number of them.

- **1st goal--**Over a generation to bring the number of active Protestant Christians across New York City from the current 8% to 20% of NYC

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residents. How? This requires increasing the number of NYC churches from the current 10,000 to 15,000.

- Plant 100 churches each year asking each to plant 2 more over the next 10 years. Every 100 churches we plant should therefore plant another 150 churches. (Assuming only 25% plant 2 and 25% plant 1 and their daughters plant churches at the same percentage.)
- 100 churches per year at $25,000 each is $2.5 million dollars per yr. Another $500K for supervision and training—for $3million per year.
- After 20 years--there could be close to the 5,000 new churches we need.

- **2nd Goal**- Over a generation to bring the number of active Protestant Christians living and working as professionals in center-city areas from the current .05% to 10% of center-city residents. How? This requires increasing the number of Bible-believing churches in center-city areas from about 5 to over 300.
  - Plant 10 churches each year, asking each to plant 2 more over the next 10 years. Every 10 should therefore plant another 5.
  - 10 churches per year at $130,000 each is $1.3 million. Another $300K for supervision/training—for $1.6 million per year.
  - After 20 yrs-there would be 300 new center city churches in NYC

b. New and renewed churches - The character of them.

Unless we allow the full range of churches that God in his providence has raised up over the centuries, we cannot hope to see a city as large and as diverse as New York City reached with the gospel. But all the churches must be characterized a theologically, spiritually, and culturally 'thickness.' What do we mean by that?

(1) "Gospel-Centered". Pretty much all Christians think they are gospel-centered, but what do we mean by this?

God has entered the world in Jesus Christ to achieve a salvation that we could not achieve for ourselves and thereby renew the whole world.

- This good news is first of all ***grace*- centered**. Jesus has lived the life we should live but won't, and he paid the penalty we owe for the life we do live but shouldn't. So we are not reconciled to God through our efforts and record (as in all other religion) but through his efforts and record. Gospel-centered churches believe in the holiness of God and the importance of believers' holiness. Nevertheless, they are not legalistic. Grace humbles and removes self-righteousness.
- Second, this good news is ***kingdom*-centered**. Jesus is not saving individual souls by removing them from the world, but rather he is bringing the life and power of God down into the material world to eventually renew and restore it. Gospel-centered churches do not only urge individuals to be converted, but also seek the peace and justice in our city. Of course, these grace and kingdom emphases lead us
- Third, to be very ***city*-positive** also, as God directs in Jeremiah 29:1-7 and as seen in Paul's urban-centered mission in the book of Acts. Grace-centeredness leads us to love the city, not despise it. Kingdom-mindedness leads citizens of the 'city of God' to be very *best* citizens of their earthly city. Gospel-centered churches do not despise or uncritically accept the city but rather love it and embrace it.

(2) "Ministry-thick" From this understanding of the gospel flow five ways to minister in the city. Many churches major in only one or two of these (and many do none at all!) But ministry-'thick' churches will be deeply committed to all five.

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- First, they must be churches highly effective in ***evangelism*** to very skeptical and secular people**.** They cannot only reach already conservative and traditional people. The gospel (unlike religious moralism) produces people who do not disdain those who disagree with them. Rather than simply confront contemptuously those who disbelieve, the gospel leads us to sympathetically but effectively find ways to address baseline cultural hopes and aspirations with Christ and his saving work. We must articulate the gospel coherently in a secular and post-secular pluralistic culture.
- Second, they must be churches that seek to spiritually form people mainly through ***community.*** Gospel-centered churches are neither relativistic nor legalistic, and this creates communities that are remarkably distinct from the surrounding culture in the way our uses of sex, money, and power are shaped. Churches must provide counter-cultural community that models the alternate human society that Jesus will bring to earth. Our attitudes toward other races and people who differ with us, our radical generosity with our money to others, our sexual integrity and wholeness--in all these ways Christian community must be distinct and remarkable.
- Third, they must be churches that do ministry in both ***word and deed.*** The Bible's basic narrative plot-line shows that the restoration of the whole world--material and spiritual--is the aim of salvation. Christian churches therefore must work for justice and peace in their neighborhoods through service even as they call individuals to conversion and the new birth. We must work for the common good and show our neighbors we love them sacrificially whether they believe as we do or not. Indifference to the poor and disadvantaged means there has not been a true grasp of one's salvation by sheer *grace*.
- Fourth, they must be churches that help their people integrate ***faith and work*** for cultural renewal**.** Most American Christians 'seal off' their faith-beliefs from the way they work in their vocation. The gospel is seen as a means of finding individual peace and *not* as a 'world-view'-- a comprehensive interpretation of reality that effects all we do. But the gospel has a deep and vital impact on how we do art, business, government, media, and scholarship. Churches must be highly committed to support Christians' engagement with culture, helping them work with excellence, distinctiveness, and accountability in their professions and in 'secular work.' Developing humane yet creative and excellent business environments out of our understanding of the gospel can be part of the work of restoring creation in the power of the Spirit. Bringing Christian joy, hope, and truth to embodiment in the arts is also part of this work.
- Fifth, they must be churches that each intend to be a catalyst for ***a major movement of new churches.*** The only way to permanently influence the city is through multiplying movements of churches with this basic gospel commitment and 'thick' ministry--churches that penetrate literally every neighborhood and people group. If over the next generation we could see thousands of new churches in this mold it would increase the number of active Christians living and working in the culture-forming center by 10-20 times. We must then plant churches that see church planting as a routine and irreplaceable part of their ministry.

Why they are all crucial

We must do <u>all</u> these five because they are all required by the gospel. They are not optional. The grace-orientation of the gospel makes evangelistic worship and deep community both possible and necessary. The kingdom-orientation of the gospel makes wholistic ministry and the integration of faith

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and work imperative. Both grace and kingdom-mindedness provide the motivation for the hard work of church planting. But also, we do all these five because they are inter-dependent. Wholistic ministry, in which Christians work sacrificially for the common good, is the necessary context for any convincing evangelistic call to believe in Jesus. (Why should the people of the city listen to us if we are simply out to increase our own tribe and its power?) And culture cannot be changed simply through numerous conversions if Christians continue to 'seal off' their gospel-beliefs from how they work and live in public. Finally, church-planting is ultimately the only way to increase all these other ministries in the city. Only if we do all of these ministries at once will any of them be effective. They are inter-dependent and inter-locking.

If (and only if) we produce *thousands* of new church-communities which regularly win secular people to Christ, which seek the common good of the whole city especially the poor, and produce thousands of Christians who write plays, make movies, do creative journalism, begin effective and productive new businesses, use their money for others, and produce cutting-edge scholarship and literature--will see our vision for NYC realized and our whole society changed as a result.

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WHAT IS (CHRISTIAN) CULTURAL RENEWAL?
Part 2

Tim Keller

MCM
May, 2003

- Why Christians are culturally marginal - *Dualism*
  - Common approaches
  - Reasons for failure
- How Christians can do cultural renewal - *World-viewness*
  - The ***concept*** of a Christian world-view- what is it?
  - The Biblical ***bases*** for a Christian world-view - why do we have it?
  - The ***content*** of a Christian world-view - what is *in* it? what does it consist of?
  - The ***alternatives*** to a Christian world-view- what are the other, rival world-views?
  - The ***application*** of a Christian world-view - how does the CWLV apply to each basic area such as: art, business, journalism, entertainment, etc.
- Where do we go from here? - *Cultural leadership development*

Note: *Most of the following was sent to you in April. Since we covered a little less than half in the actual teaching time we will complete our discussion of the material May 5.*

Review - *Why Christians are culturally marginal.*

This comes to a great degree from ***'dualism'***--the lack of a comprehensive Christian world-view. 'Dualism' separates the spiritual/sacred off from the rest of life. It originally had roots in Hellenistic thought that viewed the material world as bad and the spiritual world as good. Kantian philosophy has accentuated it. (Kant made a sharp division between the public world of 'objective facts' and a private world of subjective values and spirituality.)

1) The first result of dualism is the widespread belief that the only way to truly serve God is through direct ministry--teaching, evangelizing, discipling. This has effectively removed Christians from places of cultural influence for generations. It sees the church and its activities as good and untainted, while the secular world is bad and polluting.

2) The second result of dualism is that it 'seals off' our personal beliefs and faith from the way we actually live and work in the world. Christianity is seen as a means of individual spiritual peace and strength and not as a comprehensive interpretation of reality that affects everything we do.

3) I would like Redeemer to be as known as much for moving people out of "dualism" as for moving people out of "legalism". The two are related! Legalistic Christianity leads to dualistic Christianity. **a)** When you don't grasp the gospel of grace, you tend toward a Pharisaical obsession with 'ritual purity' or 'cleanness.' Since we are saved by the purity and rightness of our lives, it encourages people to stay very much within the church where we don't have to deal with unbelievers. **b)** Also, while the Bible does tell you a great deal about how the church should operate--it doesn't give details about how to run your business in a Christian way. That takes reflection and creativity. The "everything black or white" world of legalists cannot cope with that kind of flexibility and uncertainty. They are extremely concerned with knowing what the exactly right Biblical position is on everything.

4) The opposite of 'dualism' is 'world-viewish' Christianity. Christianity is not simply a set of beliefs to be held in order to save my individual soul. It is also an interpretation of (and a distinct way of understanding) everything in the world, in life. It must bring a distinct perspective on human nature, right and wrong, justice, beauty, and character. If you believe the universe happened by accident (rather than believing it was created, entered, and redeemed by a personal, Tri-une Creator God) then you will have to have a different view of every one of these fundamental issues. And these issues determine how you live your daily life.

Note: Keep in mind that this is a very basic 'primer' and we will therefore discuss only the most broad, common features to all forms of a Christian world-view. Each of us is part of a human culture, and when we become believers the gospel 'comes in' and radically alters but does not eliminate the particular viewpoint of our native race/culture. The Biblical view of human cultures is complex: a) each reflects the image of God in its particular gifts, and yet b) in their present forms all cultures are based on idolatries (see below.) So there are valid cultural subsets within the overall consensual commitments of the Christian world-view.

BASES OF A CHRISTIAN WORLD-VIEW - *Why do we have it?*

This is a big claim--that Christianity does not simply give us inner peace and a future with God, but also provides us a distinct way to view everything in the world and life. How do we back this up Biblically? Why does Christianity provide us with a whole 'world-and-life view'?

Biblical Teaching on Creation (and the Incarnation) creates a CWLV

- First, the doctrine of creation tells that that the material world is *important.* Genesis 1 and 2 show us that God creates it deliberately. Psalm 145 tells us he has a delight in and love for *every*thing he has made (vv.9, 16-17) and that *all* things he has made in creation, even inanimate objects, by simply being what he made them, are praising and glorifying him (Psalm 19:1-6; 148; 150.) This view stands against the traditional eastern (monistic) view that the material universe is unreal. This view stands against the other ancient myths of creation as either a) eternally existent, or b) an accidental result of a battle, the death of a monster, etc. The material world is a real thing, deliberately designed by God.
- Second, the doctrine of creation tells us that the material world is *good.* Genesis 1 and 2 show God continually saying that everything he made is very good. There was not a thing wrong with it. Biblically considered, Shakespeare was wrong when he wrote, *"To err is human".* That may be so now, but it was not so originally. God made all things good and whole. Matter and human nature are not flawed and weak by design.
- The ultimate proof of God's commitment to the absolute goodness of concrete material reality is the doctrine of the incarnation. There is no other religion with a view of material world as that real or that good. The fact that God became physical, flesh, affirms the goodness of creation and matter, so in one sense this doctrine only confirms what the doctrine of creation already revealed. But the incarnation also has ramifications all its own. It means that God is working in the ordinary, if we only have eyes to see it. It means that, if Jesus became incarnate to live among the ordinary, we should not despise 'ordinary life.'
- *Implications:* There is a fundamental principle here. The world is a good in itself. The arc of an eagle's flight, the sound of the ocean's waves on the shore, growth of a tree, and a piece of great music-- all of these things are beautiful and good *in themselves*[1] because God does not simply spend his time saving souls by his Holy Spirit, but also renewing the material world by his Holy Spirit (See Psalm 104, especially v.30.) A major part of God's work is his delight in continuing to care for, sustain, cultivate, and grow the creation (Psalm 65:9-13; 145:21; 147:15-20.) If *he* does both of these things, how can we say that one of these things is 'the Lord's work' and one is not? The view that, for example, an artist or banker is simply doing 'secular work', not really 'the Lord's work'--does not fit with this view of creation. For God is also an artist and an investor in the material world.

> *"Who formed the world of nature (which provides the raw material for physical sciences)? Who formed the universe of human interactions (which is the raw material of politics, economics, sociology, and history)? Who is the source of all harmony, form, and narrative pattern (which is the raw material for art?) Who is the source of the human mind (which is the raw material for philosophy and psychology?) And who, moment by moment, maintains the connection between our minds and the world beyond our minds? God did, God does."* (Mark Noll, *The Scandal of the Evangelical Mind*.)

Biblical Teaching on the Kingdom (and the Resurrection) creates a CWLV

- First, the doctrine of the kingdom tells us that human sin--rebellion against the rightful kingship of our Creator-God, has led to breakdown and disintegration in absolutely every

[1] Some might think we are 'mixing apples and oranges' to put music in with an eagle's flight. An eagle is 'part of nature' but music is 'man-made.' But an eagle is skillfully using the physics (aerodynamics) of the material world, and a musician is doing the same thing with sound.

area of life. The world was created as a place of complete flourishing and harmony (*shalom)* under God's rule. Sin, resistance to God's authority, led to the 'unraveling' of creation.

- Relationships with God, other races and classes, individuals, and physical nature itself disintegrate where God is not acknowledged as King.
- The alternative to Christ's kingdom in your psyche, your vocation, or your culture is to be controlled by an idol. Some other 'god', 'king', hope, or 'bottom line.' Every field of human endeavor puts forth something other than God--financial profit, individual rights or happiness, human reason, group power--as the ultimate value and goal. This always leads to disintegration and breakdown--spiritually, psychologically, socially, physically, and culturally. (Thus when we do our work with kingdom values, it will be distinctive from the work carried on under the power of ideologies.)

- Second, the doctrine of the kingdom tells us about the re-entry of God's ruling power through Christ's death and rising. <u>If every part of the world is broken by sin, then the goal of Christ's salvation--the restoration of God's ruling power--must be the renewing of every part of creation</u>. Hearts, relationships, communities, and practices are healed and 're-woven' with one another to the degree that they come under the authority of Jesus, through his Word and Spirit. (Ps 72; Col 1:16-20 and Ephesians 1:9-10.) Redemption is much more than simply saving souls. It will ultimately entail the complete healing of creation, including social justice, the reunification of all humanity, and the end of physical decay and death (Is 11:1-10.) But even now it means bringing the health and coherence of Christ's lordship back into every aspect of human life. The Christian church is to be a new society in which the world can see exhibited what family life, business practices, race relations, and all of life can be under the kingship of Jesus Christ.
- The ultimate proof of God's commitment to redeeming the entire world--not just spiritually save us out of it--is the fact of the resurrection. This shows that God not only made both the spiritual and the material but he will redeem both the physical and the material.
- *<u>Implications</u>*: Things in the world are only properly understood when viewed through an understanding of the kingdom. **We only understand a thing if we realize: 1) it was created originally good in itself, 2) it is fallen and marred by sin, 3) it can eventually be redeemed under Christ the healing king.** This simple statement is more radical and has far more implications than you may at first think!

> *Sin...attaches itself to [every good] created thing like a parasite. Hatred, for example, had no place within God's good creation. Nevertheless, hatred cannot exist without the creational substratum of human emotion and healthy assertiveness. Hatred participates simultaneously in the goodness of creation…and in the demonic distortion [fallenness]…*
>
> *The great danger is to always single out some aspect of God's good creation and identify <u>it</u>, rather than the alien intrusion of sin, as the villain. Such an error conceives as the good-evil dichotomy as intrinsic to the creation itself...something in the good creation is identified as [the source] of evil. In the course of history, this "something" has been variously identified as… the body and its passions (Plato and much of Greek philosophy), as culture in distinction from nature (Rousseau and Romanticism), as authority figures in society and family (psychodynamic psychology), as economic forces (Marx), as technology and management (Heidegger and existentialists....As far as I can tell, the Bible is unique in its rejection of all attempts to either demonize some part of creation as the root of our problems or the idolize some part of creation as the solution. All other religions, philosophies, and world-views in one way or another fall into the trap of [idolatry]--of failing to keep creation and fall distinct. And this trap is an ever-present danger for Christians [as well]..."*[2]

[2] Al Wolters, *<u>Creation Regained</u>*, p.50.

- Some have defined culture as 'naming the *good.'* What differentiates one culture, philosophy, or world-view from another is in its identification of 'what is the *ultimate* good? what is the non-negotiable? what is the *most* important thing of all?' One culture designates family as the ultimate good, another individual freedom, and so on. Automatically, something else (the opposite or the most direct nemesis of 'the good' is demonized.) This cannot be avoided--every world-view deifies/glorifies *some*thing, and therefore demonizes something.

  Art can lead you to God. I think that's the purpose of everything. If it's not doing that, what's it doing? It's leading you the other way. It's certainly not leading you nowhere. – Bob Dylan[3]

- Compared to Christianity, other views of reality (and thus cultures) identify <u>some created thing</u> as being 'the problem' with the world and <u>some created thing</u> as 'our hope, our trust' to get us through. But Christianity says that the answer to the first question is 'sin', and the answer to the second question is 'Jesus only'. Without the gospel, you have to make *some*thing besides the Lord into a savior, and thus something else into the demonic 'other' or 'enemy'. Christianity is ultimately the most positive view of human life and culture, refusing to 'demonize' any part of creation--yet it is fiercely anti-utopian, un-idealistic.
- So we see that:
  - That *every* cultural activity has both creationally good elements in it. Yet
  - Every cultural artifact that is not produced from a very solid Christian perspective (and often even those that are) will lay out *some* kind of world-view that makes an idol and a demonic 'other' out of some finite aspect of creation.
  - Christians should thus be the most 'nuanced' of cultural observers, not 'trashing' many things, not dividing the world into 'good, OK, holy, safe' and the 'bad, off-limits, prohibited'.
  - Note: Notice that because non-Christian world-views demonize some part of the good created order (or idolize some part of the fallen created order) they also will tend to create a 'good guys' and 'bad guys' way to divide up the human race.
    - Thus Marxism assumes all our problems come from the powerful, greedy capitalists who won't share the means of economic production with the people. The solution is a totalitarian state. Freud on the other hand believed all our problems comes from repression of deep desires for pleasure. The solution is the unrepressed freedom of the individual--thus the villains become repressive moral 'gate-keepers' in society like the church. Plenty of people have a "traditional values" world-view (which is the very opposite of Freud's.) They think the problem with the world lies in bad, undisciplined, selfish people who won't submit to traditional moral values and family responsibilities. The solution is a moral 'revival' in society of religion and morality and virtue.
    - Only the Christian world-view locates the problem with the world *not* in any one part of the world or in any one group of people but in Sin itself. And it locates the solution in God's grace and the coming of the kingdom. Sin infects us all, and so we cannot simply divide the world into the 'good guys' and the bad. Without an understanding of the nature of the kingdom, we will be either naively utopian or cynical and disillusioned. We will be demonizing something that isn't all that bad and we will be idolizing something that isn't all that good.
  - Summary: In every psychological, cultural, or communal entity something besides the Lord serves as *functional* savior and master. In an individual life, it means psychological disintegration happens by making a 'god' of human approval. In corporate life, it means that cultural and community disintegration happens by making a 'god' of profit, or individual freedom. That means that we can bring redemption into even the 'secular'

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[3] Quoted in Steve Turner, *Hungry for Heaven: Rock 'n' Roll and the Search for Redemption,* rev. ed. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1995), 159.

aspects of life by thinking out and practicing work and cultural production that is a 'sign of the kingdom.'

CASE STUDY #1 - Business (a very brief look)

- What is the 'bottom line'--the ultimate value, 'the *good'*--in a business? In the dominant ideology today the ultimate, non-negotiable, controlling value is "profit" and therefore "economic efficiency." Ultimately, everything the company does it does to maximize economic efficiency and profits for the owners. The business may a) contribute to local community charities, b) promote ethical behavior among its workers and managers, and c) try to be sensitive to worker needs, concerns, and morale--but it does all of these things as a means to the end of making more money. They are only done in order to promote long-term profits. Thus whenever there is a *real* choice to be made between profit and a) community/neighborhood interests, b) ethical principles, or c) worker needs, it is "profit" that always wins. That is the 'bottom line,' and thus the ruling factor--the idol.
- What would happen to a company that was operated on the principle of being a 'sign of the kingdom'?
  - One of the signs of the kingdom is helping the company's broader community and neighborhood flourish. Another is promoting personal character such as integrity and love. Another is promoting the whole welfare of its workers so they flourish not only professionally but also personally. (All of these stem from kingdom of God as *"shalom"*-comprehensive flourishing.)
  - What if these things were ends and not means? And what if then making a profit was the means not the end? (In other words, we *must* make a profit in order to promote the welfare of our community and our workers. If we don't make a profit how can we create jobs, produce products that really meet human needs and make world better, or help workers grow?) Yet what if the profit was only the means to the end, not the end?
  - From the outside there might not be immediately noticeable differences between a company run according to these kingdom values and some other very well run company.
- But inside the company the differences would be quite noticeable. Good stewardship means efficiency, but there would be a noticeable lack of adversarial relationships, a lack of any sense of being exploited, an extremely strong emphasis on product quality, and an ethical environment that goes 'all the way down', even when high ethics mean a loss of money.
- To be a "Christian in business" then means much more than just being honest or not sleeping with your co-workers. It even means more than personal witnessing and holding a Bible study at the office. Rather, it means thinking out the implications of the gospel and God's kingship for your whole work-life.

Biblical Teaching on "Common grace" creates a CWLV.

What (if anything) can Christians assume they share in common with people who apparently have not experienced saving grace? *Is there a non-saving grace that is at work in the broader reaches of human cultural interaction, a grace that expedites a desire on God's part to bestow certain blessings on all human beings, elect and non-elect alike--blessings that provide the basis for Christians to co-operate with, and learn from, non-Christians?*[4]

- *Positive Biblical data*. The answer is "yes."
  - Psalm 19 differentiates between 1) a kind of "wordless speech" about God which comes through nature and tells us about God's glory, and 2) a propositional revelation which comes through the Bible.

[4] Richard Mouw, *He Shines in All that's Fair: Culture and Common Grace* (Eerdmans, 20010 p.14.

- Romans 1 and 2 confirms that there is a primordial knowledge of God that all human beings have. In Rom 2:14,15 he says that God's law is written on the heart of every human being. All have innate senses of honesty, justice, love, the 'golden rule' and so on.[5] All people *know* at some deep level (see below) that there is a God, that we are his creatures, that we know we should serve him, and so on.
- There is a general understanding among Christians that 'raw' nature *reveals* God apart from the Bible. That is, most understand that apart from the Bible and saving faith, God reveals himself generally to all people through the magnificence of nature--as they view the ocean, the mountains, etc. But God also shows common grace (reveals knowledge of himself) through human culture. For human culture is simply a wise recognition of and cultivation (thus the very word 'culture') of nature.
  - Isaiah 28:23-29 *When a farmer plows for planting...when he has leveled the surface... does he not plant wheat in its place, barley in its plot, and spelt in its field? His God instructs him and teaches him the right way...Grain must be ground to make bread...all this also comes from the Lord Almighty, wonderful in counsel and magnificent in wisdom"* This is remarkable. Isaiah tells us that anyone who becomes a skillful farmer, or who brings an advancement in farming 'science' is being taught by God. One writes about this text: "What appears as a discovery (the proper season and conditions for sowing, farm management, rotation of crops, etc.) is actually the Creator opening his book of creation and revealing his truth."[6]
  - Now all human culture is ultimately the same thing as farming. (Remember the Mark Noll quote above.) Isaiah says that every advancement in human learning, every work of art, etc. etc. is just God "opening his book of creation, revealing his truth, and teaching us." Of course, the vast majority of farmers in the history of the world did not know that God was doing this, but Isaiah says that was what was happening. It is 'general revelation' or 'common grace.'
  - All terrific music, skillful farming, new advances in the ability to travel by air, and great political leadership--all of these things are expressions of God's grace. See--
    - James 1:17 says that *"every good and perfect gift comes down from above...from the father of lights."* This means that every act of goodness, wisdom, justice, and beauty--no matter who does it--is being enabled by God. It is a 'gift', and therefore some form of grace.
    - Exodus 31:1ff. we read how Bezalel was *"filled with the Spirit of God, with skill, ability, and knowledge in all kinds of crafts--to make artistic designs...."* Here we see artistic skill is something that comes from God. (As per James 1:17--it would have to!) Salieri (in the play and movie) was right--Mozart's music was the voice of God, regardless of the moral and spiritual condition of Mozart's heart.
    - In Isaiah 45:1 we read of Cyrus, a pagan king that God *anoints* with his Spirit and chooses for world leadership! On the other hand, in Genesis 20:6ff we read how God prevents another pagan king from falling into sin. This is an indication of how God's Spirit does not just function as a non-saving *ennobling* force in the world, but also as a non-saving *restraining* force in the world. This is not the

[5] Frances Hutcheson, 18th century moral philosopher used a famous illustration to demonstrate this. He asks us to imagine that we hear of a man who discovers buried treasure in his backyard--worth millions. But then you hear that he gives it all away to the poor. Even if you would never do so yourself, and even if you swagger publicly that such an act is stupid, you cannot help but admire what was done. There is an indelible sense of the moral beauty of the action.

[6] Alec Motyer, *The Prophecy of Isaiah* (IVP, 1993) p. 235.

Spirit working as a *converting* or a *sanctifying* agent. Rather he acts to give wisdom, courage, insight, and to restrain the effects of sin.

- *Balancing Biblical data:* The answer is "yes---but..."
  - In Romans 1:18, Paul says that we "hold the truth down in unrighteousness." This statement has two edges to it. John Calvin strikes the balance of the Reformed tradition when first he wrote about secular (he was thinking mainly of ancient pagan) authors:

    On the one hand, he writes: *Let that admirable light of truth shining in them teach us that the mind of man, though fallen and perverted from its wholeness, is nevertheless clothed and ornamented with God's excellent gifts. If we regard the Spirit of God as the sole fountain of truth, we shall neither reject the truth itself, nor despise it where it shall appear unless we wish to dishonor the Spirit of God....Those men whom Scripture (1 Cor 2:14) calls 'natural men' were, indeed, sharp and penetrating in their investigation of inferior things. Let us, accordingly, learn by their example how many gifts the Lord left to human nature even after it was despoiled of its true good.* (Institutes, II. 2.15)

    On the other hand, Calvin also wrote that while it is true that*...in man's perverted and degenerate nature some sparks still gleam, [the light is nonetheless] choked with dense ignorance, so that it cannot come forth effectively. [His] mind, because of its dullness...betrays how incapable it is of seeking and finding truth.* (Institutes, II. 2.12) How could the same person write these two seemingly contradictory things within just a few pages of one another? Are non-believers capable of the truth or not? `Yes and no. Calvin is just reading Romans 1 carefully!

  - On the one hand it means that there is no neutrality in the world. Everyone who does not acknowledge Christ as Lord is operating out of a false view of things. No one is objective. Everyone has to live for something; everyone therefore has to idolize some fallen thing(s) and demonize some good thing(s.) Everyone is operating from a world-view that denies Christ as the center or honors him. There is no such thing as a 'view from nowhere.' We must remember this or you make the 'liberal church' mistake of simply assimilating too much to the culture.
  - On the other hand it means that despite the 'false world-views', everyone grasps and to some degree acknowledges truths about God, creation, human nature, and so on. Paul says we "hold down the truth in unrighteousness"--which means that we all "have" the truth in some way. How else could we hold it down?

- *How then do we integrate these two 'sides' to the doctrine of common grace?*
  - This universal knowledge of God and of good has been called "first order beliefs." Romans 1 and 2 tells us that all people do know that there is a glorious creator-God. All people have these beliefs, even if often their conscious, intellectual "second order beliefs" deny him.
  - This means that much--maybe even most--of what non-Christians will do will point to or honor or be based on basic truths that they 'know' at one level and yet 'not know' at another. For example, Leonard Bernstein's "second order beliefs" were secular and naturalistic. But in a famous TV show he said: *Listening to Beethoven's Fifth, you get the feeling there's something right with the world, something that checks throughout, something that follows its own laws consistently, something we can trust, that will never*

let us down. What he was saying was that music gave him not simply good feelings--but *meaning*. Despite the fact that his formal beliefs were that life was a cosmic accident, and therefore there could be no meaning to anything or hope--music made him feel that there was meaning to it all, that it did matter how you live! Some things really matter.

- *The importance of understanding common grace*.
  - Without an understanding of this--the world is a pretty confusing place! As we just noted, Salieri is totally confused and bitter that he, a morally good person, has so little talent, while Mozart (in the movie, a morally despicable person) has very obviously received a major gift from God in his soaring talent. Salieri's problem was (at least) a failure to understand the doctrine of common grace. God gives out good gifts of wisdom, talent, beauty, skill 'graciously'--that is, in a completely unmerited way. He casts them across the human race like seed, in order to enrich, brighten, and preserve the world. But that is not unfair, really. By rights, sin should be making life on earth here much more unbearable than it is. One of the main reasons it is not is because of common grace.
  - Without an understanding of this--Christians will think they can live self-sufficiently. We might feel like we should only go to Christian doctors, work with Christian lawyers, listen only to Christian counselors, buy only Christian artists. Of course, we remember the balance of this doctrine! Every non-believer has serious blindness and is operating out of a false world-view. There is no neutrality. But the fact remains that many of the gifts God has put in the world *for us believers as well as the rest of the human race* are out there in 'un-believers'! Mozart was a gift to us--whether he was a believer or not (James 1:17.) *"He makes the rain to fall and the sun to shine on the just and the unjust"* (Mt 5:45.)
  - Without an understanding of this--Christians may feel no need to study the world and other human cultures in order to get to know God. But we need to appreciate truth and wisdom wherever we find it.
  - Without an understanding of this--Christians will have trouble understanding why non-Christians so often exceed Christians morally and in wisdom. A doctrine of sin means that believers are never as good as our 'right world-view' should make us. A doctrine of grace means that unbelievers are never as messed up as their 'false world-view' should make them. The differences between believers and non-believers across the board is often not striking. One of the reasons is of course "sin"--but the other reason is grace!
- **Note:** Among strands of Christianity (ironically) Roman Catholicism and Reformed Protestantism have had the strongest understanding of common grace (though Catholicism, tellingly, prefers to call it 'natural law' or 'natural revelation.') Catholic and Reformed Christians have a better basis, then, for distinctively Christian approaches to scholarship and non-church vocation.

CASE STUDY #2 - Popular Culture (a very brief look)[7]

- In general, Christians' reaction to popular culture has been some form of dis-engagement. Music, movies, and television are sweepingly evaluated as dangerous, polluting, and/or degrading. The withdrawal has taken different forms. One form is complete withdrawal. Another form is the creation of a 'sub-culture' filled with sanitized, overtly evangelistic forms of music, movies, TV shows, etc. A third form of dis-engagement is uncritical

[7] This case study is heavily based on Ted Turnau, "Reflecting Theologically on Popular Culture as Meaningful", in *Calvin Theological Journal* 37 (2002) pp. 270-296. We will not go into the differences between popular culture and so-called 'high' culture that Turnau explores.

consumption of popular culture (simply imbibing it without any sifting of world-view analysis.) Why this dis-engagement?

- One is a legalistic or *'thin' view of sin* (treated above as 'dualism.')
  - A theologically 'thin' view of sin sees it as a series of discrete acts of non-compliance to God's regulations. Christian growth is seen mainly as seeking environments where you are less likely to do these sinful actions. Sin is something that can be essentially removed from the person. (This view of sin comports with a lack of understanding of the thoroughness and richness of Christ's gracious work for us. If we have to earn our salvation, we need a view of sin that is easier to deal with by conscious effort.)
  - But a theologically 'thick' view of sin sees it as a compulsive drive of the heart to produce or discover idols. [*Not a single person has ever been found who did not fashion for himself an idol or specter in the place of God. Surely, just as waters boil up from a vast, full spring, so does an immense crowd of gods flow forth from the human mind...* Calvin *Institutes* Book 1, V, 12}
  - If we have a 'thin' view of sin, we will remove from our view anything that could tempt us to do overt actions of sexual immorality, profanity, violence. By withdrawing such cultural 'texts' from our view we may feel less sinful, but that is not the case. the complex organic nature of our sin will still be at work making idols out of things that are not overt forms of law-breaking--like our moral goodness, or financial security, or our family, or doctrinal purity, or pride in our own traditional culture, and so on. In fact, too much emphasis on 'withdrawal' makes the likelihood of slipping into 'respectable' idolatries greater.
  - If, instead, we have the 'thick' view of sin--as idolatry that pervades all we do--should lead not to withdrawal or to uncritical consumption, but rather to 'humble, critical engagement.' We should identify cultural idolatries in popular culture as ways of repenting for the seeds of the same in our own hearts and avoiding them. (There is certainly room for specific withdrawal form some texts of popular--or 'high'!--culture, especially when we are younger. We are talking here of blanket withdrawal or uncritical consumption.
- Another cause of dis-engagement is an intellectualistic or *'thin' view of common grace*.
  - As we noted above, Christians have long recognized that all people have 'knowledge' of God that they suppress, according to Romans 1-2. But many conceive of this knowledge mainly (or strictly) as cognitive information that can be retrieved somehow as we argue with people about the existence of God, the truth of Christianity, and so on. In other words, innate *knowledge of God* is thought of in intellectualistic terms.
  - But the language of Rom 1:18-25 gives us a much more comprehensive and dynamic picture of how 'general revelation' or 'common grace' works in lives. The *'truth'* is being *'suppressed'* (v.18) but it continues to bear down on us. The NIV translation of verse 20: *"Since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities...have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so men are without excuse."* But the verbs *nosumena* ("are being understood") and *kathopatai* ("are being seen") are in the form of present passive participles. That is, the reality of God's nature and our obligations to him are continuously present to us. It should not be thought of as static, innate ideas or information, but as a continually fresh, insistent pressure on the consciousness of every human being. In short, every artifact of human culture is a response to God's general revelation (cf. Isaiah 28 above) but always marred by an idolatrous heart that doesn't want to acknowledge the total sovereignty of God (Rom 1:21.) So all cultural production of a dialogue between God's general revelational grace and the idolatrous nature of the human heart.

Loss of faith in a given religion does not by any means imply the eradication of the religious instinct. It merely means that the instinct, temporarily repressed, will seek an object elsewhere. – R. C. Zaehner, Oxford University, 1959[8]

- In short, every human being producing culture (and everyone is!) is in a deep 'dialogue' with the general revelation of God. Therefore human culture is an extremely complex mixture of brilliant truth, marred half-truths, and overt resistance to the truth. Here is an interesting example of this 'dialogue.'

"One of the movies we have shown students is the Vietnamese/American co-production *Three Seasons,* a collection of four intertwining vignettes. One story has to do with a cyclo (sort of a cross between a bicycle and a rickshaw) driver named Hai and his infatuation with an ambitious prostitute, a young woman who is sure she can sleep her way out of poverty into the cool, clean world of the luxury hotels near where she works. After winning some money in a cyclo race, he pays $50 to spend the night with her. He rents a room in the luxury hotel and the scene leads you to expect a typical, erotic love scene. Against the viewer expectations, though, he does not have sex with her. Instead he simply requests to watch her fall asleep, to watch her rest in the world she dreams of joining. Slowly, comfortably, she falls asleep. And he is gone in the morning, having demanded nothing from her except the chance to fulfill her desire to belong. Something snaps in the prostitute, and she finds she cannot return to her old job. [There is some similarity here to how the grace of the bishop transforms Valjean into an honest man in *Les Miserables.*] It is a powerful scene, a completely unexpected glimpse of fragile beauty and self-less, life-changing love. To my knowledge, director/screenwriter Tony Bui is not a Christian, and perhaps has never even heard the gospel…But moments of beauty and truth [and incredibly poignant images of Christ's saving work] are evidence of the work of God who preserves the noble, creative image of himself in us despite the distorting effects of sin."[9]

- Let's get an overview of, then, the different ways we can approach popular culture, according to our World-and-Life view.
  - One widespread approach to popular culture is to look at is *Foucauld-ishly.*
    - Over the past decades, the dominant view in cultural studies has been marked by a deep bias against any real *meaning* in culture. That is, any notion of a deeper meaning (what life is all about, what is good, what is evil) in culture is an illusion. Culture is really just about competing power groups within society that appropriate symbolic resources in order to represent their group or movement and gain leverage over others.
    - Because this has been the dominant view in the academic world for a good while, this view has filtered down so that it dominates the way (for example) movie critics review films. Each weekend the pages of the *New York Times* arts section will tell us that 'Buffy the Vampire Slayer' is not really about good and evil but about female power, while 'Lord of the Rings' is not really about good and evil but about male power. (We will look (in future installments of this subject) of the problem with this and other non-Christian world-views.)
  - A second widespread approach to popular culture is to look at it *dualistically.* As we noted above, the average Christian, with 'thin' views of sin and common grace tends to divide life into the 'sacred' and the 'profane.' This dualism leads to two very different (but inadequate) responses to culture.
    - Some dualistic Christians *withdraw* from popular human culture and insist that we create our own overtly Christian music, cinema, literature, and so on. We talked about this approach above.

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[8] Quoted as the epigraph in Turner, *Hungry for Heaven.*
[9] Turnau, p.279.

- Other dualistic Christians *uncritically consume* popular human culture. They think of their 'Christian walk' as what they do on Sunday. The rest of the week they have no ability to think world-viewishly about what they are imbibing. The idolatrous aspects of popular culture--the tremendous emphasis on appearance, on sexuality, on material prosperity, on absolute individual freedom, etc, etc--are not viewed critically. The sources of the various powerful images are not recognized as idolatrous and so the heart is shaped by them. This happens at a deep level. For example, if you totally hate yourself because you are mildly overweight, it is because you have let the idolatrous images of popular culture a foothold in your heart.

- A third approach to popular culture is to look at it *Christian world-viewishly.*
  - We should be willing to be very engaged with general human culture produced by non-Christians. Why?
    - First, a 'thick' view of sin means that even overtly Christian-produced culture will <u>always have some idolatrous discourse within it</u>. When we become Christians we continue to have powerful amounts of remaining sin in us. We continually struggle with remaining idolatrous impulses. Our 'Christian-cultural production' will not be free from these.
    - Second, a 'thick' view of grace means that even overtly non-Christian-produced culture will <u>always have some witness to God's truth in it</u>. Even the angry, overtly anti-God culture is to a degree a testimony to God's reality. Many of these have an air of desperation about them. They are vainly trying to 'put out' what they know in their hearts.
    - In short, Christians are never as good as their 'right beliefs' should make them and non-Christians are never as bad as their 'wrong beliefs' should make them.
  - In general, then, this means a stance of *critical enjoyment* of human culture.
    - On the one hand it means to recognize the half-truths and to resist the idols. How do we do this? It means when you recognize a cultural artifact that is a blatant, overt (even angry) resistance to God's general revelation, there is no need to delve deeply into it or expose yourself to it repeatedly.
    - On the other hand it means to recognize and celebrate the wide-spread expressions of justice, wisdom, truth, and beauty in culture.

Biblical Teaching on Worship creates a CWLV.

- One of the great messages of the New Testament is that Jesus Christ has completely fulfilled the Old Testament worship ritual. He *is* the altar, the sacrifice, the High Priest. He *has* once for all opened the way in to the 'Holy Place'--the presence of God (Heb 10:19-21.) In passages like Luke 6:1-11 Jesus very explicitly says that the Old Testament worship regulations were provisional and were fulfilled by him. What does this mean for us?
- 1st it means that Christians are called to see *all* of life as worship. The Old Testament language about the temple, priesthood, and sacrifice is now applied to believers' entire lives. Our deeds of service to others (Heb 13:16) and God (Rom 12:1) are now seen as priestly 'sacrifices' (Rev. 1:6.) We no longer go one day a week to the house of God to see the priests offering sacrifices to get us near to God. Rather we *are* the dwelling place of God (I Peter 2:5; Eph 2:19-22), we *are* all priests and everything we do for our neighbor or for God is a 'holy sacrifice' (Heb 13:15-16.)
- The implications are quite important and far-reaching. Here is another stroke against 'dualism.' We cannot separate our spiritual lives from our so-called 'secular' lives. Every part of our life--vocational, civic, family, recreational, material, sex money power--is now to be a 'living sacrifice' to God (Rom 12:1ff; cf. 1 Cor 10:31.) We cannot conduct our business in the world with the same values and attitudes as everyone else, and then confine our spiritual life to the weekend and evenings. The 'glory of God' means his ultimate importance. We are now called to worship--to respond to the glory of God--in

absolutely every area of our lives. We must ask questions like: "if God is the most important thing--how should I be conducting my business? how should I be spending my money? how should I live in my neighborhood and municipality? how should I acting and living in this area of my life?"

Biblical Teaching on Work creates a CWLV.

- The goodness of work. Human beings were put into paradise and given work to do (Genesis 2:15.) This is before the Fall, before sin and before anything was wrong with the world. Work is something we were designed to do.
- The purpose of work. What *is* work? This is a more complex question than may first appear!
  - In Genesis 1-2 God cultivates the world. First, he brings about more complexity where there was sameness (separating light from darkness, land from water, plants from animals.)
  - But second, he then 'interweaves' all these new entities into a coherent *fabric,* interdependent with one another.
    - So our work--whether splicing a gene or doing brain surgery or collecting the rubbish or painting a picture--further a) develops or b) maintains or c) repairs the "fabric of the world". Our work--whether as humble as cleaning a floor--brings 'order out of chaos' and creates new entities and inter-weaves the human community.[10]
- Human work means being partners with God in *his* work. That is the obvious implication of Genesis 1-2. Since (as we saw above) God does not simply spend his time saving souls by his Holy Spirit, but also sustaining, cultivating, and renewing the material world by his Holy Spirit (Psalm 104:30; 145, 147) then you use your gifts in work--whether by making clothes, practicing law, tilling the field, mending broken bodies, or nurturing children--you are participating in God's work. God does not only send ministers to give the world sermons, but doctors to give medicine, teachers to impart wisdom, and so on.

[10] The difference between life in a [wilderness] and here is work. In the [wilderness] you must do everything for yourself. But civilization is sharing in the work of others. Look at the chair you sit in. Imagine making it yourself--even if you had the skills, you'd need the tools. Do you have the skill to make the tools? And even if you had the skills for that, could you mine the ore to get the metal? And if you had the skills to do that, how would you get the ore down from the mountain? Would you make the truck? In other words, to simply make a chair from scratch, in a sense is a lifetime of work for one person. But through the work of others, you can buy it with the fruit of a few hours labor. Civilization is sharing in work of others. Your paycheck, whatever it is, can buy you the use of far more than you could possibly make for yourself in the time it took to earn the check. Work makes us interdependent. Work is cultivating the resources of the material and human universe.... Work is the form in which we make ourselves useful to others; civilization is the form in which others make themselves useful to us. Work unifies the human race and carries out the will of God. -- Lester DeKoster, *Work* (Christian Library Press, 1982)